Hands Calloused, Heart Worse

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Hands Calloused, Heart Worse

by Lunaeryi

Summary

Phainon's just a broke, country-bred good guy trying to survive city life, charm old ladies, and maybe flirt with the man who keeps stealing his coffee. He wasn't planning on falling for him. And he definitely wasn't planning on him being the CEO of the company merging with his.

Mydei's been doing just fine ignoring his feelings and hiding behind overpriced coffee and his resting bitch face, thank you very much. But somehow, this annoyingly charming man with calloused hands and a sunshine grin keeps getting under his skin.

Notes

We got art guys!!!! Check out this wonderful piece <333 and also this one!! You guys are so talented omg 😭

Chapter 1: You Stole My Coffee, Asshole

Chapter Summary

> Phainon spends his morning corralling gossiping grandmas, playing café janitor for free, and nursing existential dread—only for his fancy seasonal latte to get swiped by the city's mystery man, sparking the most petty coffee-shop feud this side of the skyline. Cats are fed, baristas are judged, and one very annoyed hayseed vows revenge.

Chapter Notes

> Finished this during a picnic with my friends😭

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The corner café on Grove Street was a city institution, though no one would ever admit it out loud. It had no name—just a weathered wooden sign over the door with the faded outline of a coffee cup—but at any given hour, you'd find the same cast of characters rotating through its cramped little interior.

Students hunched over half-dead laptops and overpriced study guides. Office workers pretending to take client calls while texting their exes. Cranky freelancers arguing over who'd stolen their usual window seat. And, of course, Mnestia's Book Coven—a gaggle of old ladies who met every Thursday afternoon to tear through spicy fantasy novels and roast the protagonists' life choices over lemon muffins. They wore too much perfume, claimed the corner table like royalty, and left baristas clutching their pearls in their wake.

It was exactly the kind of place Phainon loved.

He nudged the door open with his shoulder, a box of supplies balanced in his arms—Anaxa's latest demand, because apparently *'if you're gonna squat here, make yourself useful'*—and stepped inside, straight into the crush of mid-morning chaos.

Someone immediately shouldered past him without so much as a glance.

Another guy in a sleek suit cut the line with all the entitlement of a man who thought “networking” was a personality trait.

Phainon still held the door open for a woman with a stroller, even as she breezed through without a word. Not even a nod.

And from behind the counter, Anaxa’s familiar voice drifted over the hiss of the espresso machine, dry as the goddamn desert.

“You’re too *glamorous* for this city, hayseed.”

Phainon grinned. “Yeah, yeah. Good to see you too, professor.”

Anaxa, as usual, looked like he regretted every decision that had led him to this point in his life. Sharp-boned, sharp-tongued, and perpetually dressed like a noir detective off-duty, he barely spared Phainon a glance as he wiped down the counter.

“If you’re gonna loiter, at least stay out of the way. I got students stress-buying caffeine and old ladies arguing over dick sizes in chapter twelve.”

“I brought your stuff.” Phainon hefted the box onto the counter with a thud.

“Congratulations, you’ve earned the right to breathe my oxygen a little longer.”

The café was packed, tables full, a line stretching to the door. Somewhere in the back, one of the book club ladies cackled loud enough to make a barista jump.

Phainon rolled his shoulders out, warmth settling over him like a well-worn jacket.

Yep. Welcome to his life.

“Phainon, darling!”

The chorus hit him the moment he turned around. He barely had time to brace before four perfume-clouded hurricanes descended on him from the book club’s corner table.

“Merope, careful,” one scolded, but Merope had already grabbed a fistful of his sleeve. “Where’ve you been, sweetheart? We haven’t seen you in weeks.”

“It’s been three days,” Phainon laughed, easy and warm as a sun-drenched porch swing. “Miss me that bad?”

“Oh, hush,” complained Alkippe, the one with the crimson lipstick and earrings shaped like tiny swords. “You promised you’d pick a book for next month and then vanished into thin air.”

Another hand—Clio, forever in pastels and scandalized expressions—reached up to pinch his cheek. “Look at this face. Wasting it on spreadsheets and coffee. A tragedy!”

Phainon ducked away with a grin, but let them tug him down for a quick, smothering hug that left him smelling like lavender and powder. “You know you’re my favorite part of this city, right?”

“Flatterer,” muttered Merope, pretending not to preen.

“Anaxa, we’re stealing your boy,” Alkippe called toward the counter.

Anaxa didn’t look up from his espresso shot. “Take him. Leave the box. And don’t get any perfume on my beans.”

The old ladies cackled like crows over a carcass, and Phainon managed to extricate himself with promises of visiting their next meeting and bringing better muffins.

Once they were distracted by a fresh round of speculation over the protagonist’s bedroom skills, Phainon slid into the empty stool by the counter, dropped his elbows onto the polished wood, and—with all the

grace of a man whose soul had left his body several hours ago—let his head fall forward with a dull *thud*.

Anaxa didn’t even flinch. He just kept polishing a glass.

“Rough day?”

Phainon groaned without lifting his head. “You have no idea.”

Anaxa set the glass down with a soft clink, grabbed a clean towel, and went right back to ignoring him like a professional.

Phainon stayed like that, forehead against the counter, for a long, blessed moment. The warmth of the wood, the hum of the café, the distant shriek of a milk frother. A cozy little pocket of misery.

“You’re not even gonna ask?” he mumbled.

“No,” Anaxa said flatly, flipping a page in some battered old paperback he kept stashed under the counter. “But you’re gonna tell me anyway.”

Phainon sighed, sitting up halfway. “Rude.”

“Order first,” Anaxa muttered without looking up.

“Alright, alright. I’ll take a—”

“Yes, I *know*, you order the same shameful nonsense every time,” Anaxa snapped, slapping a hand on the counter. “‘Oat milk, cardamom, lavender syrup, double shot, extra foam, sprinkle of nutmeg on top, because you’re a delicate fucking flower.’”

A few patrons glanced over. Phainon shot them a thumbs up. “It’s a good drink.”

“It’s a crime against god and coffee,” Anaxa grumbled, scribbling the order down anyway. “Now vent. Get it over with.”

Phainon huffed out a laugh, propping his chin on one hand as he watched Anaxa work.

“I got called in early. Again. For another ‘company culture revitalization’ meeting.”

“Oof.”

“Which is code for some middle manager telling us to smile through the crushing existential dread of late-stage capitalism.”

Anaxa grunted, setting a mug under the espresso machine.

“And then,” Phainon went on, “I found out they’re probably getting bought out by some corporate juggernaut. Which means new management. Which means layoffs. Which means my broke ass gets to polish my résumé and pray to the god of LinkedIn connections.”

“Guess you should’ve gone to law school like your mama wanted.”

Phainon snorted. “My mama wanted me to marry a preacher’s daughter and take over the family farm.”

Anaxa smirked. “Poor woman.”

“Don’t you dare feel bad for her, she’s thriving.”

They both lapsed into a familiar, easy silence as the espresso machine hissed.

It was stupid, but in moments like this—watching the same old people cycle through, the scent of burnt coffee and pastry sugar in the air, Anaxa’s relentless bitching—the city almost felt like home.

Almost.

The café TV—one of those ancient flat screens bolted into the corner with a crooked bracket—droned softly above the hum of conversation. Normally

tuned to whatever sports highlights or cooking competition Anaxa could stomach, but today it was stuck on some 24-hour business news channel.

Phainon wasn't paying attention until the scrolling ticker caught his eye:

"Castrum Kremnos rumored to acquire Okhema Tech in Q3 corporate merger shakeup."

And of course, right on cue, a perky, too-polished anchor appeared on screen, voice syrupy-smooth and detached from the impending corporate bloodbath she was reporting.

> *"Sources close to the matter suggest that Castrum Kremnos, one of the city's most prominent financial conglomerates, is finalizing negotiations to acquire Okhema Technologies in a multi-million dollar merger projected to reshape the regional tech landscape. The acquisition is expected to trigger a series of departmental restructurings, with analysts forecasting a significant workforce reduction in non-essential roles."*

Phainon groaned, dragging both hands down his face.

Anaxa slid his drink across the counter without a word.

"I swear to god," Phainon muttered into his palms, "if I get laid off and end up working some gig where my uniform involves a visor and a name tag, I'm jumping off the 5th Street bridge."

"You'd survive," Anaxa said, deadpan. "You've got country boy resilience."

Phainon peeked through his fingers. "Would you hire me? If I got fired?"

"No."

"Seriously?"

"You practically work here already. Only difference would be me having to actually pay you." Anaxa smirked over the rim of his coffee. "And I'm not

about to shell out payroll for Aglaea's stray charity cases."

That one hit a little to the left of petty and straight into personal.

Phainon leveled a half-hearted glare at him. "You're still mad at her for that book fair thing?"

Anaxa didn't even blink. "She knows what she did."

"Dude, it was ten years ago."

"She alphabetized poetry under nonfiction."

"…Okay yeah, that's fair."

They let that sit a beat, the anchor still babbling about fiscal quarters and restructuring forecasts like she wasn't announcing the potential end of Phainon's rent-paying existence.

Phainon tipped his head back. "Guess I better start brushing up my fry cook skills."

Anaxa snorted. "You'd set yourself on fire inside a week."

"Maybe I'd like the flames," Phainon sighed.

From across the room, one of the old book club ladies shouted, "Stop feeling sorry for yourself, sugar, and come say hi before we die!"

Phainon gave Anaxa a weary look. "See? My public demands me."

"Go get your cheeks pinched, hayseed."

The next hour passed in the lazy, haphazard rhythm that made this place feel more like a community center than a café.

Phainon made the rounds without meaning to—holding the door for a guy juggling a tray of muffins, helping a frazzled student reconnect to the café's eternally spotty Wi-Fi, and untangling a set of earbuds for a kid who looked

two seconds from tears. Every time Anaxa passed behind the counter, he'd grunt a new order at him: *"Move those crates. Tighten that loose table leg. Tell book club they can't bring in outside pastries."*

And every time, Phainon grumbled back but did it anyway.

Somewhere between refilling napkin holders and rescuing a barista who'd dropped an entire tray of spoons, the Book Coven finally snagged him, pulling him in with the kind of matriarchal gravity no mortal man could resist.

"Sweetheart, come here and settle something," one of them demanded, waving a half-eaten muffin like a gavel.

"Which one of these fictional hunks would you marry?" another asked, thrusting an open book under his nose. The page in question involved a shirtless warrior prince with brooding eyes and an attitude problem.

Phainon laughed, played along, let them tug at his sleeves and pinch his cheek and slip him a contraband strawberry bar under the table.

Across the café, Anaxa watched it all with his usual expression of mild, pained irritation. But when no one was looking, he quietly refilled the glass of water by Phainon's usual spot at the counter. Topped it off with ice, too. And when Phainon came back to set down a handful of stray menus, Anaxa didn't say a word—just shoved it toward him with a grunt.

Eventually, the midday lull started to settle in. Conversations dropped to murmurs. The line shrank to a trickle. The sunlight through the windows edged toward gold.

And then—

"Order for Phainon!"

His name, called sharp and clear from behind the counter.

He perked up immediately, a deep, heartfelt sigh escaping him like a man rescued from the edge.

“Thank god,” he muttered, rubbing the back of his neck as he straightened up from where he’d been crouched, adjusting a stubborn table leg.

A few of the old ladies chuckled knowingly as he made his way toward the counter, threading through scattered chairs and half-finished conversations, already picturing the first perfect, scalding sip of—

The cup disappeared.

Right off the counter.

Before his fingers could even brush the cardboard sleeve.

Phainon stopped mid-step. Blinking.

Someone else’s hand was already around his drink.

And just like that—the universe had decided to screw him again.

Phainon closed his eyes. Took a long, steady breath in through his nose. Counted to three like his grandma used to tell him when he was about to put someone through a wall.

Then he opened them.

“Are you fucking kidding me.”

The words came out low and flat, the kind of tone that made nearby conversations stutter and pause. A few heads turned. One of the old book club ladies made a delighted little *ooh* sound.

Standing there, smug as sin, drink already halfway to his mouth, was *him*.

Mydei didn’t even blink. Took a slow, infuriatingly casual sip of Phainon’s overcomplicated, shamefully indulgent seasonal drink—oat milk, cardamom, lavender syrup, the whole overthought mess—and let out a content little hum like he’d been served nectar from the gods.

“Hmm?” Mydei tilted his head, playing mock-confused. “Oh… was that yours? Thought it was mine. Rookie mistake.”

The air between them went tight as a wire.

Phainon’s glare could’ve cracked glass.

A few tables over, Anaxa didn’t even look up. Just muttered, “And there goes my peaceful afternoon.”

“Give it back.”

Phainon’s voice had dropped to a warning growl, but Mydei just raised a brow, unhurried as ever, taking another pointed sip of the drink. The smug little ahh sound he made after could’ve gotten a lesser man killed.

“Make me.”

It was always like this. Sharp words exchanged like blades, tight smiles masking the constant simmer of irritation that flared whenever they shared air. It wasn’t even about the drink anymore—hadn’t been for months.

The rivalry had started when Phainon, bleary-eyed and sleep-deprived, grabbed a drink off the counter that wasn’t his. Took a huge swig expecting bitter coffee and got walloped with something so aggressively sweet and floral he damn near spat it back into the cup. The memory still haunted him.

Turned out it belonged to *this asshole.*

Mydei, naturally, took that as a personal offense. So, of course, the next time Phainon’s order was called out, Mydei snagged it and sauntered off like nothing had happened.

And now here they were. Every time they crossed paths, it was open season.

Phainon’s jaw ticked. His hand flexed at his side, tempted to snatch the cup back, but…

Goddamn it.

He looked good today.

He hated to admit it—would sooner eat glass—but *fuck*. Mydei was standing there in a black sleeveless turtleneck that clung to his frame a little too well, and over his shoulders hung this soft pink sweater, casually draped like some careless afterthought. His hair was slightly mussed from the wind, sharp features calm and unbothered as ever.

For anyone else, Phainon would've started a bar fight over this. Made a damn expedition out of reclaiming his drink and ending this dumb little war.

But for him…

Well.

"You gonna keep glaring at me or actually do something about it?" Mydei asked, voice mild as ever, but there was a glint in his eye. A challenge.

Phainon gritted his teeth. "One of these days, pretty boy."

Mydei smirked, stepping just slightly closer, lowering his voice. "Promises, promises."

A chair scraped somewhere. The low hum of conversation returned, but the air between them stayed tight as ever.

Phainon reached for the cup—and Mydei smoothly shifted it to his other hand.

Fucker.

Phainon's jaw flexed. His patience—already paper-thin—finally gave.

"You keep this up, and I swear to god I'm gonna—"

Mydei, deadpan and far too calm for his own good, cut in smoothly. "You'll what? Use those big, calloused hands on me?"

The words hit the air like a lit match.

Phainon's mind blanked for a beat, then snapped into motion.

In a sharp, graceless motion, he grabbed a fistful of Mydei's sweater, spun him around, and pinned him against the nearest patch of wall—not hard enough to hurt, but enough to startle a few patrons and knock a flyer loose. His other hand planted firm beside Mydei's head, caging him in.

The café dropped a few decibels. Even Anaxa glanced up from behind the counter with a sigh, already done with this bullshit.

Phainon tilted his head down, leaning in close, just enough for Mydei to catch the glint in his eye and the barely-suppressed smirk threatening at the corner of his mouth.

"Careful what you wish for, sweetheart."

And god, the way Mydei's smug little eyes didn't falter—if anything, it sharpened.

Somewhere off to the side, a student with a laptop muttered under their breath, "Jesus christ, just fuck already."

Neither of them moved.

Phainon's pulse kicked in his throat.

Mydei's eyes flicked down to his mouth, then back up like he was absentmindedly judging him.

Phainon grinned, sharp and wolfish, and stepped back just enough to let him go.

"Asshole," he muttered.

Mydei smoothed his sweater like nothing happened and raised the drink in a mock toast. "See you tomorrow."

Phainon let out a long, exhausted sigh as the door swung shut behind Mydei. He leaned back against the counter like the wind had been knocked out of him, scrubbing a hand down his face.

From the book club table, Merope let out a delighted giggle.

He practically snapped his head in her direction, glare sharp enough to cut glass. “What.”

She only grinned wider, undeterred. Another one of the ladies elbowed her, both of them dissolving into gleeful whispers.

Anaxa from where he was wiping a glass dry, muttered under his breath, “They’re not wrong.”

Phainon scowled. “What was that?”

“Nothing.”

“Yeah, that’s what I thought.”

He pushed off the counter and made for the register again. “Alright, fine, hit me. One more of those ridiculous oat milk, cardamom—”

“Yeah, yeah, I know your shame order,” Anaxa cut him off flatly. “You’ve ordered the same thing for a year, don’t act like you’re surprising me.”

Phainon grumbled, pulling out his phone to check his rapidly dwindling bank account. He winced. “Jesus, how is this shit eight bucks? What’s it brewed with, liquid gold and student tears?”

Anaxa snorted. “Nah. You’re just broke.”

“I hate you.”

“You wish you could.”

Phainon eyed the menu board again, sighed, then shoved his phone back in his pocket. “You know what, forget it. Coffee’s a scam anyway.”

“Coward.”

“I said I’m good.”

Anaxa grunted, set down the glass, and grabbed a small paper bag from behind the counter. Without ceremony, he lobbed it at Phainon, who barely caught it in time.

“You’re off shift. Get out of my café.”

Phainon blinked down at the bag—fresh pastries, still warm.

“…You’re a softie.”

“Eat shit.”

A few of the regulars called out their goodbyes as he made for the door. One of the students gave him a lazy salute. The book club people waved their hands, rings glittering.

“See you next week, darling!”

Phainon grinned, adjusting the bag under his arm. “You know it.”

And with that, he stepped back out into the city’s chill, the door shutting behind him with a soft jingle.

Phainon stepped out into the street, the cool air hitting his face like a wake-up slap. He sighed, rolling his shoulders, the weight of the day settling in again now that the brief chaos had passed.

A flicker of movement by a lamppost caught his eye.

There, crouched in the shadow of a trash bin, a scrappy gray cat watched him with wary yellow eyes. One ear was nicked, its fur a little patchy, but it held itself like a tiny, threadbare king.

Phainon huffed a soft laugh, crouched down, and tore a corner off one of the pastries in the bag. “You’re out here hustling too, huh?” He tossed the

bit of pastry toward the cat, who eyed it, sniffed, then devoured it like it might be his last meal.

“Yeah,” Phainon muttered, straightening up. “I get it.”

With a final glance at the café—still bright, still loud, still carrying on without him—he adjusted the strap of his bag, stuffed his hands in his pockets, and made his way toward work.

Chapter End Notes

> What do we think abt the concept? I love a classical CEO story sue me 😐

Chapter 2: God, You’re Always Here

Chapter Summary

> Phainon and Mydei accidentally go to dinner together, swap shitty date stories, and somehow don’t kill each other. Phainon nearly bankrupts himself, gets saved by a friendly waitress, simps over Mydei under moody streetlights, and gives him a crumpled pressed flower like a Victorian maiden. An Uber driver named Sal (allegedly, maybe) ships it immediately. Neither of them admit they’re having a good time.

Chapter Notes

> I need sleep, but the yaoi won me over. Why do I always post these mf’s so late😭

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The city at night was a living thing.

Neon signs flickered in storefront windows, throwing lazy, half-hearted glows against rain-slicked concrete. Somewhere in the distance, a late-night bus groaned around a corner, headlights washing over puddles and uneven sidewalks. Distant club basslines bled into the streets—low, thrumming reminders that somewhere out there, people were still awake, still dancing, still doing something other than working themselves into the ground.

Phainon could hear his own footsteps.

Heavy. Unsteady. Bone-deep tired.

The streetlights hung in hazy halos, a pale gold cutting through the blue-black of the city’s late hours. A stray cat darted under a parked car. Teenagers loitered by a shuttered store, passing a vape back and forth, the thin stream of it catching in the light before vanishing into the damp air.

Phainon adjusted his grip on the strap of his bag, the leather biting into his shoulder through the thin fabric of his shirt. Said shirt was a mess—crumpled, sleeves pushed up to his elbows to reveal forearms marked with faint old scars and a faint spatter of blue pen ink from somewhere around hour ten of today's corporate hellscape. His tie hung loose and lopsided around his neck, long since given up on being anything more than decorative.

He could still hear his supervisor's voice ringing in his skull.

"We need this cleaned up by the end of the day."
"But it's already the end of the day."
"Then stay late."

That was fourteen hours ago.

A logistics crisis some other department had caused had landed in his lap, and of course the higher-ups at Okhema—eager to look competent ahead of the impending merge—had decided to drop it squarely on his department. Fix it. Damage control. Make them look good, or don't come back Monday.

And Phainon wasn't stupid. He wasn't deaf to the murmured talks of restructuring, of trimming the fat, of redundancies when Castrum Kremnos finally sank its teeth into Okhema's throat. Like he'd talked about with Anaxa before, layoffs would be coming. And people like Phainon, people without seniority, without anyone watching their back?

They'd be the first to go.

So he stayed late.

Worked through lunch, through dinner, drank shitty office coffee until his hands shook, watched the sun set through the crack in the blinds. And when it was done—when the files were patched and the numbers were spun into something the investors could stomach—no one even thanked him.

"We knew you'd pull through," was the closest he got.

Phainon let out a long breath, dragging a hand down his face. He didn’t bother fixing his tie. Didn’t bother rerolling his sleeves. His shoulders ached from hours hunched over his desk, from carrying a department’s worth of fuckups on his back, and now all he wanted was food cheap enough to pay for with pocket lint and pride.

A dollar slice. A shitty diner. Hell, maybe just a coffee he didn’t have to expense.

A man on a bike zipped past, delivery bag bouncing against his back. Someone shouted from a fourth-floor window. The smell of hot garbage and fresh rain lingered like an old, stubborn bruise.

Phainon squared his shoulders.

“Okay,” he muttered to no one. “Food. Then sleep. Then do it all over again.”

He forced a long breath in through his nose, jaw tight.

Think about something good.

It was a trick Cyrene taught him back home, one of those old things that stuck no matter how many years you spent scraping by. Count your blessings, no matter how rotten the day.

He dug for them.

Okay—he hadn’t gotten fired.

The crisis hadn’t sunk the department.

The overworked printer in his office hadn’t caught fire this time.

Someone in HR had brought in stale muffins. He’d managed to steal two.

Was that four? That was four. Not bad.

And… okay. That one old lady at the boutique store this morning had called him *“handsome in a scruffy way,”* which technically counted. Five.

Phainon let out a huff of a laugh at that, soft and tired, his steps falling into a slower rhythm as he rounded the corner onto a quieter stretch of street. The city dimmed a little here—neon signs sparse, the shops all shuttered, only the occasional glow of a distant window or flickering streetlamp.

His stomach grumbled, a reminder that muffins weren’t a real dinner.

He passed a shuttered bodega, metal grate halfway drawn, the flickering light inside catching on rows of dusty snack bags and sun-faded lottery ads. In the window, a cat sat perched on a stack of cardboard boxes, one paw tucked under its chest, watching the world with the unbothered detachment only cats and the very rich ever managed to pull off.

Phainon slowed, pausing in front of the glass.

The cat blinked at him. Yellow eyes, slitted and disinterested. Its ear twitched once.

“Lucky bastard,” Phainon muttered.

The cat yawned, wide-mouthed and unconcerned, before curling deeper into itself and turning its gaze elsewhere.

Phainon huffed, a threadbare smirk tugging at the corner of his mouth. He adjusted the strap of his bag and kept moving, his footsteps the only thing marking time against the hush of the street.

And then, as he rounded the next corner—

He almost plowed straight into a silhouette standing dead-center beneath a streetlamp’s halo.

Phainon’s foot caught on uneven concrete, his balance tipping forward fast enough that his stomach dropped, the world tilting with it. He barely had time to hiss a curse through his teeth before a hand caught him—firm,

steady, a palm pressed against his chest and fingers curling tight around his upper arm.

“Woah, hey—”

“Shit, sorry—! Fuck, I wasn’t—” Phainon scrambled, the strap of his bag sliding off his shoulder as he instinctively grabbed the stranger’s wrist to steady himself. “Didn’t see you, I wasn’t—walking, just—I mean, I was, but not like at *you*, I—”

“Are you oka—”

The voice stopped.

Phainon’s words tangled in his throat as he looked up, gaze colliding with a pair of sharp, gold-shot eyes. Not amber, not hazel, but that unmistakable glinting, metallic warmth that looked downright supernatural under the streetlamp’s glow.

His stomach flipped.

Oh, fuck me.

It was *him*.

For one long, stifling moment, neither of them moved. Phainon still half-bent from the fall, a fistful of the other’s wrist, the stranger’s—*Mydei’s*—hand braced against his shoulder like he was debating whether to shove him off or steady him again.

Phainon’s brain supplied details against his will.

The cigarette, unlit but half-raised, still smoldering faintly between Mydei’s fingers where he must’ve just sparked the lighter. The slim band of a simple, worn signet ring catching the light. Red nail polish—a sharp, deep crimson—slick and immaculate on blunt, elegant fingers.

The shirt was black. Mandarin collar. Off-center button closure that ran in a precise line down the side of his chest. Tapered trousers, cut so well they

probably cost more than Phainon's rent. Black leather ankle boots with a slight heel that clicked faintly against the sidewalk when Mydei shifted his weight.

Phainon was… leaning. And looking. And if his stomach did a weird little dip about it, that was the exhaustion talking.

Neither of them spoke.

Somewhere in the distance, a car horn blared. The world thinned to the ring of streetlights, the haze of rain-damp air, and the relentless, shared *oh-god-it's-you* moment stretching thin between them.

Mydei's gaze dragged over Phainon's face, down to the loose tie, the ink stains, the crumpled shirt, then back up. His expression barely flickered, save for the smallest, impossible-to-read lift of one brow.

Phainon's brain cells screamed in union, move, *say something, stop standing here like an idiot.*

He cleared his throat. "Of course it's you."

The words came out rougher than intended.

Mydei's mouth curled at the corner—not a smile. Something far more sardonic. The cigarette flared to life between his fingers, a brief halo of orange-red glow that painted the edges of his cheekbones and made the gold in his eyes catch like a predator's.

"Likewise," Mydei said, smoke curling from the corner of his mouth.

They separated like someone had cut a wire between them. Phainon dropped his hand, jerking his bag back up onto his shoulder with a sharp motion. Mydei casually stepped back a pace, like gravity itself was a minor inconvenience to him.

Phainon turned on his heel, scowling hard enough to sour milk, and muttered, "Just my fucking luck."

Behind him, the soft click of a boot heel on wet concrete and a quiet exhale of smoke.

Neither of them left.

Somewhere down the block, a drunk laughed too loud. The cat in the bodega window pawed lazily at a moth.

Phainon adjusted his bag higher on his shoulder with an exaggerated motion. He wasn't leaving. He could feel the expectant weight of Mydei's stare, like the bastard was *waiting* for it—for him to slink off first, to be the one who relented. Phainon planted his feet harder, jaw set, scowl sharp enough to cut glass.

He wasn't the one walking away first.

Across from him, Mydei took a long, unhurried drag from his cigarette. The ember flared, catching red against the damp-dark curve of his cheekbone. Smoke slipped from between his lips in a lazy ribbon, and he made a show of exhaling like he didn't have a single care in the world.

But he wasn't leaving either.

They stood there like two storm fronts refusing to break, both too spiteful to retreat.

Phainon's patience snapped first.

"Should've let me faceplant," he muttered, glaring at some imaginary spot over Mydei's shoulder. "Would've improved my night."

Mydei didn't miss a beat. His gaze cut sideways, sharp and impossible to read.

"And rob myself of the entertainment?" Another drag. "No thanks."

The nerve of him.

Phainon scoffed, a disbelieving huff that was half laugh, half threat. “Didn’t peg you for a sadist, but I guess I should’ve known.”

Mydei’s mouth twitched—not quite a smirk, but god, it wanted to be. “You assume I’m not already one. How sweet.”

“Trust me,” Phainon shot back, stepping a fraction closer, “there’s nothing sweet about me.”

“That look might work on softer men,” Mydei said, flicking ash to the curb. “But I stopped pitying creatures like you years ago.” A pause, eyes catching Phainon’s for a beat too long. “Shame, though. I imagine you’ve still got a line of them, hoping for a turn.”

Phainon’s heart did something awful in his chest—a sharp, traitorous stutter—but his mouth was faster.

“Bet you’re at the front of that line.”

It landed like a thrown glove.

Mydei’s eyes snapped back to his, pupils sharp slits in the gold. The tension wound itself tighter, something electric and crackling in the scant inch that separated them now. They’d both shifted without realizing it, the place narrowing to a single, suffocating point of contact. Phainon could smell the smoke on Mydei’s breath, could see the sharp gleam of red polish on his fingers where they held the cigarette, could hear his own pulse in his ears.

Neither of them moved again.

“You couldn’t handle me,” Mydei accused.

Phainon didn’t lean in, but

he didn’t lean back either. He huffed a quiet, humorless laugh.

“Wouldn’t have to,” he said automatically. “You’d fall apart first.”

The city noise blurred.

The distance between them was paper-thin.

Phainon clicked his tongue, sharp and annoyed, and finally stepped back a pace. His nose wrinkled, waving a hand as if to clear the thin coil of cigarette smoke hanging between them.

“Hate the smell of smoke,” he muttered, pointed and petty, like the problem was the cigarette and not the man holding it.

Mydei hummed, utterly unbothered, taking one last drag before flicking the half-finished cigarette to the curb. He ground it out under the heel of a black boot, the sharp click of sole to pavement louder than it should’ve been in the hush between them.

“Tragic,” he murmured.

Phainon’s jaw clenched. He shifted his bag higher on his shoulder and muttered, half to himself, “I need to find something to eat before I chew through my own goddamn hand. Shame that sandwich place closed up...”

“Same,” Mydei replied, smooth and light, like this wasn’t the worst coincidence imaginable.

They both turned, sharp little movements like dueling cats, heading off in separate but unfortunately mirrored directions—only to realize, a few paces in, that it was the same one.

A pause.

Both stopped, turning just enough to look at each other.

“Which way,” Phainon ground out, already knowing the answer.

Mydei lifted a brow, and without a word, pointed down the street.

Phainon pointed too.

They stared. No blinking. No flinching. Just the unspoken, bone-deep of course sinking between them.

Phainon dragged a hand down his face. “The place down the street?”

Mydei gave a soft, disbelieving laugh through his nose. “You’re kidding.”

Phainon shot him a glare. “Do I look like I’m in a joking mood?”

“Never,” Mydei deadpanned, lips curling just enough to count as a smirk.

Another beat. Another unspoken *fuck you.*

“Well,” Phainon sighed, starting down the street with grim resolve, “don’t walk too close. People might think we’re friendly.”

Mydei fell into step beside him anyway. “Unlikely.”

They walked in silence for maybe half a block. The damp air stuck to Phainon’s skin, heavy with rain and exhaust, and his stomach growled again —loud enough this time for him to sigh, more annoyed than embarrassed.

He sighed, “if I don’t eat in the next ten minutes, I might actually start gnawing on a street sign.”

Mydei snorted, not even looking his way. “Might improve your face.”

Phainon shot him a glare. “You’re one to talk. You’ve got the kind of face that looks like it’s used to getting slapped.”

“Funny,” Mydei said, flicking a glance sideways, the corner of his mouth tilting. “You strike me as the type who’d ask for it.”

“That supposed to be a kink thing or are you just bad at insults?”

“Why not both?”

Phainon let out an amused scoff, surprised it escaped him. He caught Mydei watching him then—not obvious, just a sliver of gaze from the corner of those sharp gold eyes, like he was filing the sound away.

The street dipped a little ahead, light pooling in uneven patches. From the corner of his eye, Phainon spotted a drunk couple halfway through an argument, voices sharp and slicing through the quiet. The guy gesturing too wide, the other's face pinched in frustration. Instinct kicked in—Phainon edged closer to Mydei's side without thinking, angling his body just enough to put himself between the man's flailing arm and Mydei's path.

He didn't say anything about it.

Mydei either didn't notice or was too proud to. He kept walking half a step ahead, still picking up the thread of their argument like it hadn't skipped a beat.

"… and for the record," Mydei was saying, "that sandwich place didn't close. It moved two blocks down."

"Bullshit."

"I had lunch there last week."

"Yeah, well, maybe the food's fine if you're the type who thinks truffle oil makes up for a dry bun."

"Ah," Mydei sighed, mock-sympathetic. "A man of low standards."

"Hey now," Phainon grinned, adjusting his grip on his bag. "I'll have you know, I'm a man of simple pleasures. Good bread, strong coffee, a halfway decent sunset—that's it. Not all of us need gold flakes on our fries to feel something."

Mydei made a soft noise at that. Not quite a scoff, not quite a laugh. More intrigued.

"Country boy wisdom," he said dryly. "Touching."

Phainon smirked. "Don't act like you aren't charmed."

"I'd rather gnaw on a street sign."

And for reasons neither of them would admit, they both kept close.

Because at 11PM in a city like this, even the worst company was better than none.

Eventually, in the middle of humming some old tune to pass the time—Phainon realized they'd stopped.

He glanced up, expecting some flickering diner sign or a ratty awning half-hanging off a corner pizza joint. Something cheap, grimy, familiar.

Instead, glass.

Tall, sleek panels stretched up into the night like sheets of dark water, catching the city lights in smooth, liquid reflections. Warm, understated lighting spilled from inside, painting the sidewalk gold. And then—the name. Etched in clean, elegant lettering above the door.

Phainon's brain hiccupped.

Wait a second—

He knew that name.

Twilight & Courtyard.

Not because he'd ever set foot in the place, but because some executive at the office once bragged about dropping a casual three grand there on "a light evening out." It was the kind of place where the menu didn't have prices, where everything came in portions small enough to insult your grandmother, and where they probably charged extra if you had the nerve to ask for tap water.

And here it was. Right in front of him. Right where they'd apparently been walking this whole time.

What the hell—

“Didn’t know this was here,” he muttered without thinking, the words slipping out numbly.

In his head, they were both heading for the same late-night dive. Greasy noodles. Shitty coffee. A place where it wouldn’t matter that he looked like hell. He figured they’d pass this place, maybe trade a cheap shot about pretentious rich assholes, and move on.

Except Mydei didn’t stop.

Didn’t even hesitate.

Like it was nothing, like he’d done it a hundred times, Mydei stepped forward and pushed through the heavy glass door. A suited host looked up from his podium, expression smoothing into polite recognition.

Phainon’s stomach dropped.

Oh, oh no.

He was still standing there when Mydei glanced back over his shoulder, one brow faintly arched. “You coming, or planning to admire the sidewalk all night?”

His tone wasn’t condescending. Like he genuinely thought they’d been headed to the same place this whole time. Which somehow made it worse.

For half a second, Phainon considered cutting his losses. Making up some excuse about needing to take a call, fake-limping away, getting hit by a bus —literally anything but walking into a place where his whole month’s rent probably wouldn’t cover the bread basket.

But then his gaze snagged on Mydei’s face in the glow of the glass doorway —those sharp features softened in the warm light, gold eyes catching like the city itself had made a home in them. And for reasons he would never, ever say out loud, Phainon’s spine stiffened.

His brain screamed *oh fuck oh fuck oh fuck*, but his feet moved anyway.

Maybe it was stubbornness. Maybe it was pride. Maybe it was that deeply stupid part of him that couldn't back down from a pretty face if it tried.

So he squared his shoulders, forced a smile over the rising panic, and followed.

His stomach was somewhere around his ankles, his wallet preemptively sobbing, but screw it—if he was going to die financially, he wasn't about to do it looking like a coward.

Inside, the air changed. Gone was the grit and damp of the city, replaced with soft amber lighting and a scent like clean linen and expensive liquor. Crystal glasses caught the glow in delicate prisms. A pianist somewhere in the back let notes of slow, unobtrusive jazz drift through the room like smoke.

Phainon was already recalculating his life choices when the host approached.

"Sir Mydeimos," the man greeted smoothly, giving a polite nod that Phainon swore bordered on deferential. "Your table's ready."

Mydei gave an absent wave of acknowledgment, leaning in just enough to mutter, "My contact bailed. I'll be dining with him instead."

A tilt of his head toward Phainon.

Phainon's brows shot up. *Him?*

Okay, so maybe his company wasn't entirely repellent. Huh.

Not that Mydei gave him even a flicker of attention—already dismissing the moment like it meant nothing. Which, sure. Fine.

Phainon went to make some offhand comment, but then the host gestured, and instead of heading toward the modest scattering of well-dressed tables like normal people, they were led down a short, narrow hallway lined with glass that seemed to dim the world outside.

And into a separate dining area.

Not a backroom, not a corner booth. This was some VIP, no-price-listed, jazz-playing, waiters-who-look-like-they-commit-clean-hits-on-weekends type shit.

Phainon's jaw nearly hit the floor.

There were maybe four tables in the whole space, each glowing under its own delicate ring of light. The walls were dark wood, and somewhere overhead hung a chandelier that probably cost more than his annual salary. Menus were already placed at their table, printed on paper so thick it felt illegal to touch. No prices. Because if you had to ask, you couldn't afford it.

Phainon's stomach dropped straight to his shoes.

He opened his mouth—already halfway through the mental drafting of *actually, hey, I just remembered I have to go wrestle a raccoon or pay rent or cry in a corner somewhere*—when Mydei gestured smoothly to the opposite seat.

"You're already here," he said, tone light but leaving no room for argument. "Sit down."

The way the amber light caught in his hair, those long fingers resting against the crystal glass like he belonged in a noir film or some doomed love story—it framed him in a way that made something low in Phainon's chest twist.

This was a bad idea.

A *horrible* idea.

So of course he coughed, adjusted his sleeves like he did this shit every night, and dropped into the chair.

"You better be picking up the check," he muttered, snatching the menu open only to immediately regret it when he couldn't pronounce a single thing. It wasn't even a menu, it was a test. A fucking tax bracket IQ test.

His brain whimpered.

Still—he flicked a glance up at Mydei, letting a crooked grin tug at the corner of his mouth. “Fair warning, though. If any of this turns out to be snails or foam pretending to be food, I’m ordering a burger on the way home.”

A few minutes passed. Phainon kept his eyes trained on the menu, or what he assumed was a menu, though most of it wasn’t even in English. A delicate, serif font spelled out words in French, Italian, maybe ancient Latin for all he knew, while his brain gamely tried to translate *crème de something-something* into ‘probably soup.’

He was sweating.

His palm dragged against the thick, linen napkin in his lap as he hunted for anything that didn’t sound like it required a black market organ sale to afford. Mydei sat across from him, the very picture of disinterest, one elbow propped on the table, head tipped back just enough for the warm light to catch the edges of his sharp cheekbones. His eyes flicked lazily over the drink selection.

Neither of them spoke.

Phainon was halfway through internally debating whether it was more shameful to fake a phone call or just bolt when a soft voice cut through the tension.

“Good evening, gentlemen.”

He glanced up—and his stomach did a spectacular somersault.

Why?

It was Hyacine.

Hyacine, as in *Anaxa’s Hyacine*, the one he’d helped move a busted futon up three flights of stairs a month back. Anaxa’s assistant, med student, soft-

spoken and genuinely sweet in a way that always made him feel like a crow sitting next to a dove.

She stood there in tailored black, a notepad in hand, hair back neatly. A small silver pin gleamed at her collar. For a second, she didn't register him. She was too busy doing her job, giving the same warm, polished smile every waiter in this place had to have patented.

Then she did a double take.

Her brow furrowed, head tilting, recognition sparking behind those bright eyes.

"Phainon?"

His name came out soft, surprised. She blinked, as if mentally recalculating what the hell he was doing in a place like this.

Phainon felt the color drain from his face. He sat up straighter, his hand flattening over the menu like he could hide behind it. "Uh—hey."

Her gaze flicked to Mydei, then back to Phainon. The pieces clicking. A bright little smile tugged at the corners of her mouth. "Oh… are you two —?"

"No," both men said at once.

Too quick.

A heavy pause dropped between them.

Phainon ran a hand through his hair, scowling at his own knee. Mydei didn't even look up from the drink options. It would've been funny if it wasn't mortifying.

Hyacine, to her credit, smoothed right over it. She gave Phainon a subtle, wordless look. The kind that translated across rooms and lifetimes.

Baby, what are you doing here?

Phainon’s lips twitched in a helpless grimace.

I can’t pay for this.

One brow quirked. A tiny head tilt.

I got you, idiot.

His soul all but floated out of his body in sheer, unholy gratitude.

And with a pro-level smoothness that would’ve impressed an actual hitman, Hyacine turned to Mydei like none of it had happened. “Our chef’s special tonight is a seared lamb with saffron couscous and roasted heirloom vegetables,” she said lightly, “but if either of you prefer something off-menu, we’re happy to accommodate.”

Phainon didn’t even pretend to look at the menu again.

“Yeah, uh—sure,” he said, gesturing vaguely. “Whatever’s good.”

Hyacine’s mouth twitched. She knew. God, she knew.

“And for you, sir?” she asked Mydei.

Mydei glanced up, finally, golden eyes catching hers. “The special’s fine.”

“Excellent,” she said, scribbling it down. She glanced back at Phainon one last time, amusement flickering behind her polite professional veneer. “I’ll make sure they don’t poison it.”

Phainon snorted, his tension breaking just a fraction.

As she walked away, Phainon slumped back against his chair, casting a sideways glare at Mydei who reached for the glass of water in front of him like this wasn’t the most bizarre, financially ruinous night of Phainon’s life.

Phainon tapped a fingertip against the base of his glass. Mydei leaned back in his chair, one arm hooked lazily over the backrest, his expression unreadable in that maddening way Phainon was already learning to despise.

“So,” Phainon started,“You eat at places like this often, or is this a ‘make your enemies feel poor’ sort of thing?”

Mydei snorted, lips quirking. “Not usually. Was supposed to be a work dinner.”

“Ah,” Phainon said, nodding slowly. “So I’m the charity case.”

“More like a contingency plan,” Mydei replied, glancing sidelong at him. “Didn’t want to waste the reservation.”

“Yeah, heaven forbid you lose your preferred spot in the bourgeoisie feeding trough.”

That earned a quiet, breath-of-a-laugh sound from Mydei, the kind Phainon wouldn’t have noticed if he hadn’t been watching so closely.

A moment passed. Mydei sipped his water, then asked, casually, “You always this charming, or is it a special occasion?”

Phainon gave a crooked grin. “Depends. You always this smug, or is it genetic?”

Mydei tipped his head, considering. “Bit of both.”

Phainon chuckled, despite himself.

It should’ve stopped there—but the weird current between them didn’t let up. Something about the soft lighting made the sharp edges between them dull just enough to invite curiosity in.

“So,” Phainon said, leaning forward on his forearms. “Since we’re apparently trapped here ‘til our organs show up on tiny plates, might as well make conversation.”

Mydei quirked a brow, amused. “You’re doing a stellar job of it.”

“Yeah, well,” Phainon drawled, a hint of charm slipping in like second nature, “if I don’t flirt with my enemies a little, I get rusty.”

The words left his mouth before he could stop them, and to his surprise—no, horror—it actually landed.

Mydei's lashes lowered just a fraction, his gaze a glint of something unreadable in the dim light. "Is that what this is?" he murmured, tone mild but edged.

Phainon grinned wider, tapping the table. "Wouldn't you like to know."

Another pause, a hair longer than necessary. Then Mydei leaned back, that same faint smirk still tugging at his mouth.

"Alright then, country boy," he said. "What's the worst date you've ever had?"

Phainon blinked. "What?"

"You heard me. You're so full of talk—let's hear it."

Phainon huffed a laugh, rubbing a hand over his jaw. "Fine. There was this one girl back home, real sweet, but we went to this late-night diner and she, uh… tried to convince me to join her in stealing a bus."

Mydei's brow lifted. "A bus."

"Full-sized," Phainon confirmed. "Like, transport-children-to-school kind. Her plan was to drive it into a cornfield and 'see what happens.'"

Mydei laughed—actually laughed, rich and low. Phainon tried not to visibly preen.

"What about you?" Phainon asked, grinning now. "Gotta be a few skeletons in your walk-in closet."

Mydei swirled his water, thinking. "One guy took me to this pop-up sushi place in an alley. Swore it was 'an underground gem.' Turned out it was literally underground—as in, basement of a vape shop. I left halfway through when he started a monologue about how monogamy was a capitalist construct."

The sound Phainon accidentally made was loud enough to turn a server's head.

And just like that, the air between them shifted. Not soft, not easy—but something that wasn't pure antagonism. A truce under dim lighting and linen tablecloths.

Phainon pointed a finger at him, grinning. "See? You're not as soulless as you look."

Mydei rolled his eyes. "Don't get sentimental."

Phainon's grin only widened.

By the time their food arrived, the conversation had mellowed into something sharp-edged but weirdly easy. The plates, when they landed, looked more like works of art than anything meant to be eaten.

A server set a gleaming dish in front of Mydei—some immaculate arrangement of the seared lamb mentioned before, delicate foam, and edible flowers that Phainon didn't even pretend to recognize. The only thing he did clock was Mydei's faint, satisfied hum as he eyed it.

"Special's good," Mydei said absently, already reaching for his utensils.

Phainon's stomach was halfway to his knees when a second plate arrived—not quite as pretentious but still leagues beyond what his budget could've swallowed. He blinked up to see Hyacine standing there, a tiny, knowing smile on her face as she set it down.

"Compliments of the chef," she said sweetly, eyes flicking toward Mydei, who was too busy dissecting a flower petal to pay attention.

Phainon's brows lifted.

She leaned in just enough, whispering, "Don't worry. I made sure you'll walk out of here solvent."

Before he could answer, she dropped a dessert plate at the far end of the table—a ridiculous, towering confection of spun sugar and something chocolate and gold-dusted.

Mydei glanced up, genuinely surprised. “I didn’t order this.”

Hyacine gave him a breezy smile. “Chef insisted. Said you’re a favorite.”

Phainon bit the inside of his cheek to keep from smiling. He already knew the man had a sweet tooth the size of a planet. Of course he wasn’t gonna turn it down.

Mydei, trying and failing to look unaffected, gave a casual nod and turned back to his plate.

As soon as his attention dropped, Hyacine subtly slid Phainon’s bill portion out from under the folded leather check holder and tucked it into her apron. No ceremony, no fuss.

Phainon caught it.

Their eyes met.

She mouthed: *You owe me.*

Phainon pressed a hand to his heart in silent gratitude.

Mydei, oblivious, murmured something appreciative about the citrus notes in his sauce.

Phainon just grabbed his glass and muttered to himself, “Fuckin’ city,” before taking a long drink.

By the time their plates were cleared and dessert reduced to a smear of chocolate and sugar crystals, the stress in Phainon’s shoulders had finally, blessedly, started to unknot. The food had been good—annoyingly so. And somehow the conversation, which had started sharp-edged and defensive, had settled into something easier. Not friendly, exactly, but tolerable.

The bill had come and gone without incident, Hyacine’s discreet miracle work keeping his soul firmly inside his body. And now, walking toward the front with that full, content kind of exhaustion in his bones, Phainon found himself glancing sidelong at Mydei’s hand as it lifted to adjust his cuff.

The bronze signet ring caught the warm lobby light, a simple thing, worn smooth at the edges.

“Nice ring,” Phainon muttered, the words slipping out before he’d really thought about them. “I had a friend back home who gave me something kinda like it, once. Not as clean-looking, though. Hers was this janky little thing—scratched all to hell. I wore it for, like… five years straight.” He gave a quick, sheepish huff of a laugh. “Haven’t thought about it in ages.”

The memory caught him sideways. Cyrene’s crooked grin, the way she used to tease him for getting attached to dumb little things. The nights out under busted streetlights, talking about what they’d do once they got out of their nowhere town. He didn’t realize how much he missed her face in person until just now, saying it out loud.

He shrugged it off. “Yours looks good, though. Suits you.”

For a second, there was no reply.

Phainon didn’t notice the way Mydei’s gaze dropped to his own hand, the ghost of something unreadable in his expression.

A soft, almost distracted “Huh.”

That was it.

The host was already holding the door open for them, the city’s chill night air pressing in. Phainon moved to get the door first on instinct—some stupid remnant of old manners his mama would’ve scolded him for forgetting—but Mydei was quicker.

He held the heavy glass open, the faintest flicker of a smirk tugging at his mouth.

Phainon glared, mostly at himself, and stepped out into the city's glow. The quiet, half-formed warmth of that conversation still lingered in the air between them, unspoken, unresolved, but not unpleasant.

Neither of them mentioned it.

The night went on.

Outside, the city was damp and cool, the pavement still gleaming from an earlier drizzle. The air smelled like rain-soaked concrete and exhaust, heavy with that electric, just-about-to-storm tang. Phainon stretched his arms over his head, shoulders cracking audibly as he exhaled a long breath.

"Well," he started, dragging the word out, hands dropping to his pockets, "guess I'll call it here. Try my luck with whatever's still open past midnight. Appreciate the… uh—" he gestured vaguely back toward the building, "—accidental five-star experience."

Mydei, who was half-checking his phone, hummed absently. "You getting a ride?"

Phainon snorted. "What, you think I can't handle a little rain?"

Mydei slid him a look. A very specific kind of side-eye—equal parts dry amusement and deadpan judgment. "That's not what I asked."

Phainon ignored it with the dedication of a man who'd spent his entire life dodging better advice. "I'll walk."

"The city's not that safe," Mydei said mildly, already pulling his phone back out and thumbing the screen.

"C'mon, I'm not gonna—"

But Mydei wasn't listening. Or rather, he was, but only enough to swat a hand in Phainon's direction as if brushing away a persistent bug. "It won't take long. Stay there. I'll wait with you till it comes."

Phainon groaned, head tipping back toward the sky. "You don't have to—"

“I’m not doing it for you,” Mydei replied, already typing. “I’m doing it because I’m not in the mood to hear about a dumbass getting stabbed two blocks from my dinner spot.”

Phainon grumbled something unintelligible, mostly to save face, but stayed put.

Mydei slipped his phone back into his pocket, posture unaffected as he leaned a shoulder against the wall nearby. Not leaving. Not making it a thing. Just… existing beside him for a while.

Neither of them spoke for a bit. The distant hum of traffic filled the space instead, and it wasn’t awful.

It was kind of nice actually.

Eventually, the car pulled up with a soft sweep of headlights across the damp street, tires hissing against wet pavement. Mydei straightened from where he’d been leaning against the wall, gesturing lazily toward the backseat.

“Your chariot,” he said, voice still that infuriatingly mild register, like none of this had been weird at all.

Phainon moved toward it, one hand on the door handle—and then hesitated. Some stupid part of him, probably the part raised by soft-spoken aunts and his grandmother’s relentless superstitions, tugged at his ribs.

Before his better judgment could stop him, Phainon dug into the front pocket of his beat-up bag and fished out a small, flattened something between the pages of a folded scrap of notebook paper. He unfolded it, a little crumpled from the night but still intact—a small, pressed wildflower, some hardy little thing with faded purple petals and stubborn edges.

“Hey—” Phainon called, and Mydei turned, brows lifting faintly.

Wordlessly, Phainon held it out, not quite meeting his eyes.

Mydei’s gaze flicked down, brow arching higher in surprise as he took it between two fingers, careful not to crush the fragile thing.

“It’s, uh…” Phainon cleared his throat, scratching the back of his neck. “A thing we do back home. For luck. Or, y’know, whatever.”

Mydei glanced between the flower and Phainon. “You just… carry this around?”

“Don’t read into it,” Phainon grumbled, already pulling open the car door.

Mydei didn’t reply right away, just let the silence settle like a warm thing between them. He turned the little paper between his fingers once, then tucked it into his pants pockets with a soft, contemplative sound.

Phainon coughed. “Anyway. See ya.”

And with that, he ducked into the car, slamming the door shut with a finality that belied the stupid, anxious flutter in his chest.

Through the dark tint of the car window, Phainon found his gaze pulling back toward the curb before he could stop himself.

Mydei still stood there, one hand perched on his hip, the other slipping into the pocket of his coat. The streetlight caught on the fine angles of his face, painting him in soft gold and shadow. The faint, amused curve to his lips was the kind of expression you couldn’t tell if it was for you, or for some private joke you weren’t in on—and it made something in Phainon’s throat catch.

Damn it.

He’d known the guy was good-looking. Annoyingly, objectively beautiful in that untouchable way some people carried without trying. But right then—the glow on his skin, hair catching in the night breeze, that small, crooked smile—it hit different. Like something out of an old song you never admitted you liked.

Phainon let himself stare for half a breath too long.

Then Mydei’s gaze flicked up—sharp, catching, dead-on.

They locked eyes.

And to Phainon’s utter horror, Mydei lifted his hand in a lazy, two-fingered wave, something almost teasing in the angle of his wrist. Casual. Like they weren’t two strangers who’d just spent a night toeing the line between biting remarks and weirdly easy company.

It might’ve killed him a little.

Heart stumbling in his chest, Phainon jerked his eyes away, shoving his elbow against the door and fixing his attention firmly on the passing city lights. His ears burned. He absolutely wasn’t blushing. It was the heat from the car vents. Probably.

The driver, an older guy with a thick Brooklyn accent and a mustache that looked like it could win awards, gave a knowing hum.

“That your situationship?” he asked, steering them through the slick streets with one hand. “Reminds me of my Jerry. Back in ’90… met him at a bar, told myself I hated him, wound up married six years later.”

Phainon groaned, scrubbing a hand down his face. “Oh god.”

But he was too polite—too country-raised, too damn Midwestern nice—to interrupt as the guy launched into a rambling, half-laughed story about Jerry and a broken jukebox.

Outside the window, the city kept moving. Neon bleeding into misty dark, shop signs flickering, the distant sound of a train rattling overhead.

And through it all, Phainon kept thinking about the way that pressed flower had looked in Mydei’s hand. Simple. Small. Out of place in a place like that—but held carefully, like it mattered.

He didn’t know what that meant.

Didn’t know if it meant anything.

But the thought followed him all the same as the car carried him deeper into the city night.

Chapter End Notes

Location is up to interpretation and change. Idk I’m getting Midwestern vibes but what do u guys think?? As in where tf would Aedes Elysiae be😭

Eh whatever, maybe I’m just thinking too deeply abt it. Ty for reading <3333

Chapter 3: Bar Fight Etiquette 101

Chapter Summary

> Phainon covers a shift at Cipher's, charms old ladies (again), referees an impromptu okra-eating contest, and punches a guy so hard the bar goes silent. Mydei watches, unimpressed but secretly touched. Cipher regrets leaving him in charge for five minutes. A good time was had by all.

Chapter Notes

> Heyy, finally done with chapter 3😍 Speaking of, sorry guys there might be some delayed chapters because I'm trying to finish a few more fanfics before Myphai week, so until that I'm probably gonna go incognito for a bit save for a detective au ff (Yeah I caved and decided to do that) and another Flame Reaver/Phainon/Mydei one

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon thought he knew the kind of bar he was walking into.

The sort of joint with a flickering neon sign advertising beer no one drank on purpose, duct-taped stools, and a jukebox older than God that only played sad country ballads. The kind of place Hyacine usually called in favors for—somewhere you kept your coat in the car and your expectations even lower.

But this wasn't that.

Warm, amber light spilled from inside, catching on exposed brick walls and polished oak counters worn smooth by years of elbows and spilled drinks. Bottles lined the shelves behind the bar, their glass catching the glow like stained glass in a Sunday chapel. The air carried a mix of wood polish, orange peel, and fryer oil in a way that wasn't unpleasant—like a family gathering that overstayed its welcome.

Framed photographs of dusty back roads hung crooked on the walls, nestled between vintage tins and old neon beer signs, one of them advertising a Peoria uncle's ill-fated brewing venture. Over the bar, a chalkboard menu listed cocktails with names like *Mamaw's Peach Cobbler Old Fashioned* and *Hot Buttered Rum Punch.* Beneath that, a line of snack specials written in hurried chalk: *Collard Green Bites, Fried Pickle Spears, Buttermilk Pie.*

It wasn't home, not exactly.

But it was close enough to fool him for a minute.

He let his gaze drift, catching brass plaques bolted to the walls: *Don't let your mouth write a check your ass can't cash.* Another read: *If you don't want to be gossiped about, don't sit in that corner booth.*

A couple of regulars sat at the far end of the bar, nursing drinks and swapping stories about somebody's disastrous second wedding. The low hum of conversation blended with the clink of glass and the soft shuffle of chairs.

Behind the bar, Cipher was holding court, laughing at something a stocky old man in a Cubs cap had said. She moved like she owned the place—which, to be fair, she did. Sleeves rolled, a towel slung over one shoulder, hair pulled back in a loose knot. There was an ease to her, the kind of confidence that came from years of knowing every face in the room and which stories were worth hearing twice.

It wasn't until her gaze slid toward the door that she spotted him.

Her grin came quick and sharp.

"Well, look at you."

Phainon arched a brow, the corner of his mouth tugging up as he crossed the room.

"Thought you'd be too big city now to sling drinks," Cipher teased, her Southern drawl pulling at the words like warm taffy.

He snorted. “You know damn well I still got that bartending license. It was either that or learn to butcher hogs for the family BBQ.”

Cipher let out a low, easy laugh. “Still got it, huh?”

“Got my bartender’s license before my driver’s,” he shot back, grinning.

They shared a look—one of those small, knowing things that only folks from the same nowhere could get away with—before Cipher reached under the bar and tossed him a folded work shirt.

“Change’s in the back,” she said, jerking her chin toward a hallway near the kitchen. “Beer taps haven’t changed. Tabs run through the register now, but don’t let the old-timers give you grief about cash.”

She turned to grab a bottle off the shelf, then paused, as if something just crossed her mind.

“Oh—someone’s supposed to drop by in about an hour. Got business with me. If they show up before I’m out here, tell ’em to hang tight.”

Phainon gave a lazy two-fingered salute. “Yes, ma’am.”

Cipher smirked, then turned back to her conversation without missing a beat.

The back room was a narrow little thing—not much more than a hallway with a coat rack, a busted record player leaning against the wall, and a shelf stacked with extra menus and backup liquor. The air was thick with the scent of fryer oil and old whiskey, with the floor creaking.

Phainon leaned back against the wall, rubbing a hand down his face.

He wasn’t supposed to be here tonight.

Hell, two days ago he’d been halfway settled into the kind of quiet evening that involved takeout and a bad crime doc when his phone lit up with Hyacine’s name. She’d opened with *“Hey, you remember that favor you owe me?”* and it’d been downhill from there.

Apparently, Cipher needed an extra set of hands. One of her bartenders called out last minute, and Hyacine, ever the meditator, cashed in that debt.

He'd been expecting a hole-in-the-wall in some back alley on the South Side. A place where Cipher would've been running a side hustle, maybe pickpocketing wallets off tourists too drunk to notice. Not this.

He shook his head, a crooked smile tugging at the corner of his mouth.

In Hyacine's exact words: *"Don't underestimate her, Phainon. Girl's versatile."*

And apparently, she wasn't wrong.

Phainon blew out a slow breath, feeling the weight of it leave his chest as he started to dress. The kind of heaviness that came from showing up to things you hadn't planned for but knowing you'd do it anyway. That old, stubborn sense of duty his grandma always said would get him killed one day.

He glanced down at his hand, flexed it once, then grabbed a rag off the shelf to wipe the dust off his palms. No sense hiding back here all night. He hadn't come this far to sulk by the mop buckets.

Time to earn his keep.

Pushing off the wall, Phainon rolled his shoulders and stepped back through the door, the sounds of the bar folding around him like a well-worn jacket.

A few hours later, the place had settled into a kind of easy hum.

Cipher had taken off about an hour back, leaving Phainon to run the bar solo. A couple of the regulars had clocked him as new, but so long as their drinks stayed full and poured right, no one much cared. The crowd was a comfortable mix—neighborhood folks easing into the tail end of their workday, a pair of college kids nursing a single whiskey between them, an

older couple slow-dancing to a Merle Haggard song bleeding out from the jukebox in the corner.

Phainon moved through it all like he'd been here for years.

It wasn't hard.

He still remembered how it went—the rhythm of a bar, the shorthand language of bottle clinks and raised brows. How to pace the pour when a story got good, how to cut someone off without making a scene, how to listen without really needing to answer.

He tossed a bar towel over his shoulder, wiped down the counter, and slid a refill in front of a stout woman in a Bears hoodie who'd been holding court at the far end all night.

"You keep this up," she said, giving him an appraising look, "and I'm gonna set you up with my niece. Girl needs a man with marriage hands."

Phainon huffed a laugh. "Marriage hands, huh?"

"Yeah," she grinned, jabbing a finger at him. "You know—strong, steady, good for fixing screen doors and carrying in the groceries. Not those flimsy city-boy hands that drop a damn casserole dish soon as it comes outta the oven."

"Well, hell," Phainon said, smiling as he topped off her glass. "Guess I better start working on my casserole technique."

A few of the other patrons chuckled, the easy kind of bar laughter that didn't ask too much of anyone. The kind born from shared space, good drinks, and just enough distance from whatever waited outside.

"Just sayin'," the woman added with a wink, raising her glass to him. "Wouldn't be the worst mistake she ever made."

Phainon leaned an elbow on the bar, smirking. "I'll take that as high praise."

The woman laughed again, turning back to her conversation, and Phainon moved down the counter to grab a fresh stack of coasters. The night was easy now—steady enough to stay busy, quiet enough not to feel like a chore.

He liked it.

More than he figured he would.

And for a few long, untroubled minutes, it was just him, the bar, and the warm buzz of voices carrying over from table to table.

Which was, of course, exactly when the door swung open and trouble walked in.

Phainon wiped down the bar one more time out of habit, the clock overhead ticking steadily toward ten. He threw a glance at it, brow ticking up.

Right. Cipher's business person.

He craned his neck, looking for Cipher—no sign of her. Probably in the back, taking inventory or cussing out a busted ice machine.

With a quiet sigh, he rounded the bar, weaving past a table of rowdy regulars who were deep into arguing about which of them could still outrun a cop at their age.

"Hey, barkeep!" one of them called. "Tell this fool I got more miles in these legs than he ever did."

Phainon grinned without breaking stride. "Buddy, I've seen fresher knees on a seventy-year-old bowling league. But you're all right."

Laughter followed him as he made his way toward the door.

A figure had just stepped in, silhouetted against the amber glow from the streetlamps outside. The bell over the door gave a soft clang.

Phainon moved into place, throwing on his easy charm without thinking. “Evenin’. Welcome to Cipher’s. What can I—”

He cut off mid-sentence.

His eyes finally settled on the person in front of him.

Tall. Sharp-cut frame. Well dressed. And those damn eyes again—gold, steady, and far too familiar.

Phainon’s stomach did a little annoyed flip.

“…You’ve gotta be kidding me,” he muttered, rubbing a hand down his face.

Mydei raised a brow, equally unamused. “You work here now?”

“No—I mean, yes—what the hell are you even doing here?” Phainon shot back, voice pitching up as the reality of it sank in. He pinched the bridge of his nose, already feeling a headache spark behind his eyes. “You don’t even drink.”

“I have business with the owner,” Mydei replied evenly, glancing past him toward the back.

That snagged Phainon for a second. “You know Cipher?”

“I’m surprised you know her,” Mydei countered.

A sharp, narrow silence stretched between them.

Phainon huffed a dry laugh, shaking his head. “God, Chicago’s small.”

Neither one moved.

Then, with a long-suffering sigh, Phainon gestured toward the bar. “Whatever. Sit down. She’s not out yet.”

Mydei gave him a look—something halfway between reluctant tolerance and resigned amusement—before crossing the room and dropping onto the barstool.

Phainon circled back behind the counter, grabbing a clean glass a little harder than necessary. The faint clink of it against the polished oak made a couple of nearby heads glance up, then shrug.

The world around them kept on in its lazy, amber-lit rhythm. A blues track hummed low from the phonograph. The old casserole lady down the bar was working through another whiskey, regaling anyone within earshot about her glory days in roller derby. Two regulars bickered over who still had better hair.

Phainon kept his eyes firmly on the glass, tossing a rag over his shoulder and muttering, “Could’ve gone my whole damn life without seeing your smug face again.”

Mydei didn’t rise to it. Just let out a quiet exhale and leaned his forearms on the counter.

Phainon glanced up to fire off another jab—and that’s when he caught it.

The faint slump to Mydei’s posture. The weary drag of his hand down his face. Eyes not sharp and hunting for an opening like usual, but duller, weighed down.

Well, damn.

Phainon scowled at himself, annoyed for noticing. Annoyed for caring. He tried to shake it off, reached for a bottle to polish for the sake of doing something with his hands.

He didn’t last thirty seconds.

“…Fine,” Phainon grumbled, slumping an elbow on the bar and squinting at him. “What do you even want?”

Mydei blinked, as if he hadn’t expected the offer. “Water.”

Phainon let out a dry, unimpressed snort. “Christ, you’re worse than a Baptist mom on poker night.”

He turned, grabbed a glass, then paused—something gnawing at the edge of him. He sighed.

“You know what? Screw it.” He leaned in a little, voice dropping just enough to sound like a confession he was already regretting. “I’ll make you something off-menu. What’ll it be?”

Mydei hesitated. A tiny crease formed between his brows. “Wait… seriously?”

“Yeah, I’m feeling reckless,” Phainon muttered. “Don’t let it go to your head.”

“I don’t wanna be a hassle.”

“Buddy, this whole interaction’s already a hassle. Might as well get a drink outta it.”

A longer pause this time. Then, reluctantly:

“…Pomegranate juice.”

Phainon smirked, already reaching for the juice bottle. “Yeah. You strike me as the broody antioxidant type.”

He poured it, expecting that to be the end of it—but then Mydei cleared his throat.

“With milk.”

Phainon blinked. Actually stopped mid-pour.

“…Come again?”

Mydei, suddenly defensive, cheeks just a shade redder than usual. “I like the color.”

Phainon stared a second longer—then laughed, a low, surprised thing that cracked through the crust of his snark. “Jesus. You’re a cartoon character.”

He shook his head, grabbing the milk carton. “Coming right up, sweetheart.”

The second the words left his mouth, a sharp whistle cut through the din of the bar.

“Well, damn,” the casserole lady drawled from down the counter, elbowing her friend. “Now we know why he’s not marrying my niece, Bonnie.”

“Sugar,” Bonnie snorted, grinning, “I’d trade him a whole casserole for that smile.”

Phainon coughed into his fist, the tips of his ears warming. Mydei looked between them, confused. “What…?”

“Don’t worry about it,” Phainon muttered, giving the glass a final swirl before sliding it across the bar.

He watched Mydei eye the drink like it might bite him.

“Try it, drama queen,” Phainon teased, though it came out softer than before.

And maybe it was the lighting, or the fact that Mydei’s lashes were stupidly long for a guy, but for a second Phainon caught himself thinking: *damn, he’s kinda cute when he’s not being an insufferable asshole.*

He shoved the thought aside with a mental curse and grabbed a new towel.

“Drink your weird-ass milk juice,” he grumbled. “I got better things to do than babysit you.”

But even as he turned away, his gaze flicked back once, just to see if Mydei would actually drink it.

He did.

Not even a flinch. Took a sip like it was the most normal thing in the world. And for reasons Phainon didn't particularly care to examine, that loosened something sharp in his chest.

He grabbed a rag, wiping down a section of the counter that didn't need it, when a familiar gravelly voice called out down the bar.

"Well, well, look at lover boy over there."

Phainon shot a glare toward the far corner where two of the bar's usual fixtures, Nikos and Theo, sat nursing whiskey and soda. Both well past retirement, both hell-bent on giving him grief since he clocked in.

"Mind your business, old man," Phainon fired back, not bothering to hide the smirk tugging at his mouth.

Theo snorted, leaning in with a conspiratorial stage-whisper to Nikos. "Kid's got it bad."

"Poor thing," Nikos wheezed, shaking his head like a disappointed uncle. "Boy needs hobbies."

"I have hobbies," Phainon shot back, grabbing a handful of coasters to stack just for something to do.

"Yeah, chasing off coyotes and breaking city boys' hearts apparently," Nikos chuckled, clinking his glass against Theo's.

Phainon rolled his eyes so hard it hurt. "God, you two are a menace."

"Go on," Theo waved a hand, grinning. "We'll hold down the fort."

"Like hell you will," Phainon muttered under his breath, but his feet were already carrying him toward the end of the bar where Mydei sat, half-slouched on the stool, nursing that bizarre drink.

He made a show of casually dropping a coaster in front of him, leaning an elbow on the bar like he hadn't just been publicly heckled by geriatrics.

“So,” Phainon started, aiming for offhand and not quite landing it. “What’re your hobbies?”

Mydei raised a brow, a slow blink like he couldn’t believe that was the line Phainon went with.

Phainon scowled. “Relax. Not tryna pick you up, princess. Just—” he waved a vague hand, “conversation. It’s a bar. People do that here.”

A beat passed. The corners of Mydei’s mouth twitched like he might smile, but he was too tired to commit to it.

“You first,” Mydei said.

Phainon perked up a little, grateful for the redirect. “Alright. Uh… fishing, when I can find a decent lake. Building stuff sometimes—tables, cabinets, fixed my grandma’s porch swing last fall. I’m a menace at a grill, too. Those hobbies.”

He shrugged, smiling.

“Call it a rural upbringing clause.”

Mydei snorted softly, looking back at his drink. “Figures.”

He let the silence sit for a moment, then quietly offered, “Reading. Sketching. Hiking if I can get out of the city.”

Phainon hummed, a half-smile curling his mouth. “Didn’t peg you for the tree-hugging type.”

Mydei’s gaze flicked up, a spark of amusement there now. “Also boxing.”

Phainon nearly dropped the rag he’d been fiddling with. He barked out a laugh, leaning his weight against the bar. “Seriously?”

“Good for stress,” Mydei deadpanned, lips quirking at the edges.

Phainon grinned, that crooked thing that made the older ladies coo at him and annoyed every one of his cousins back home. “Yeah, remind me to stay on your good side.”

“You’re not there yet,” Mydei shot back, but it lacked heat. If anything, the air between them felt less tense now.

Phainon tapped a knuckle against the counter. “Noted.”

A beat. Mydei took another sip of his ridiculous drink.

“Y’know,” Phainon said, dropping his voice just a notch, “for a guy who’s allegedly a massive pain in my ass, you’re not bad company tonight.”

Mydei smirked, this time letting it show. “It’s the milk.”

Phainon laughed, leaning back to glance toward Nikos and Theo, who were pretending not to watch but doing a piss-poor job of it. He flipped them off without turning his head.

Then back to Mydei, eyes catching on gold for a second too long before he cleared his throat.

“You’re exhausting,” Phainon muttered.

“Likewise,” Mydei murmured.

And neither of them moved.

Phainon tapped his knuckles against the counter again, glancing at Mydei like he was sizing him up for a second.

“Come to think of it,” he started, head cocking to the side, “what do you even do for work? I mean—technically this is my job for the night, tragic as it is. You know mine. What about you?”

Mydei looked like he might actually answer, one hand turning his glass absently on the bar.

But before he could open his mouth, a sharp clatter sounded from across the room—the telltale scrape of a stool toppling over, a voice rising a little too loud, too slurred.

Phainon sighed, already pushing off the bar. “Sorry. Looks like I gotta go cut someone off before Theo starts swinging a cane at ‘em.”

He pointed a finger at Mydei as he backed away. “Hold that thought, angel.”

And then he was gone, moving through the hum of the bar with that easy confidence again—the regulars parting just enough for him to slip through, already calling out, “Alright, who’s being a dumbass?”

Leaving Mydei behind, alone with his strange drink and whatever answer he’d been about to give.

The bar had settled into that golden stretch of night—the kind where conversation blurred into laughter, glasses clinked steady, and even the neon signs seemed to glow a little warmer.

At one battered corner table, two regulars were deep in a challenge. One, stocky with a mop of dark curls, was waving a pickled okra spear like a weapon. The other, lean and sharp-faced, lounged in his seat with the smugness of a man convinced he’d already won.

“I’m tellin’ you, Petros,” the curly-haired one slurred, “five, no problem. I won’t even blink.”

Petros scoffed, raising his glass. “Manos, you made a face last week when the souvlaki was too peppery.”

A ripple of laughter circled the table. Someone clapped Manos on the shoulder, nearly knocking him over.

“All right, all right,” Phainon called from behind the bar, grabbing the mason jar of Cipher’s infamous pickled okra. “Five apiece, no water, no

grimaces, and loser picks up a round for these freeloaders."

The bar whooped in approval.

"Hope your stomach's stronger than your hairline," someone teased, earning a roar of laughter.

Phainon chuckled. "Easy, Nico. One more shot and you'll be singing love songs to the fruit machine again."

The jar thunked onto the table. "On my count, lads."

The first okra went down easy, though Petros twitched just enough for someone to shout, "That's a face!"

"Wasn't," he grunted, reaching for another.

Phainon leaned against the bar, watching them, the pulse of the room threading through him.

And then he let his gaze drift back to the counter.

There was Mydei.

Same spot, elbow propped on the worn oak, eyes half-lidded as he watched the commotion. The faintest trace of a smile ghosted his lips. Not a full one, not the one Phainon was used to. This one was entertained, less guarded.

It made Phainon want to stroll over and say something dumb, maybe needle him about being too chicken to join in, see if he could coax that smile out just a little more.

He was halfway through setting down a glass when a flicker of movement caught his eye.

A young man had slipped up beside Mydei. Could've passed for any other night's stray patron—late twenties, dark hair mussed like it hadn't seen a comb all week, jacket slung carelessly over his shoulder. But there was

something off in the angle of his lean, the too-familiar ease with which he planted a hand on the counter.

Phainon's pulse tapped a little faster.

It wasn't anything obvious. No raised voices or threats.

But he saw the way Mydei's posture stiffened, how his fingers curled slightly against the wood. How his eyes, a breath quicker than before, flicked toward the door.

A low hum settled in Phainon's chest.

The okra contest carried on behind him—Manos gagging theatrically on his third spear as the crowd erupted—but the sound dulled, distant.

Phainon didn't move yet, he just watched

Trouble had a look, and it rarely announced itself. It slid in sideways, polite and quiet, like a wolf trying on a lamb's grin.

And something about this one smelled like teeth.

He clocked the exchange without meaning to. The guy was too familiar for someone who hadn't been invited. He said something, lost under the sound of the bar, but the tone carried enough to make Phainon's gut tighten.

Mydei didn't so much as blink. He tilted his head slightly, expression unreadable but edged sharp, like a warning dressed up as disinterest. Whatever he said back was cold and clipped, but it landed. You didn't need to hear the words to feel the way the air shifted around them.

The other man chuckled, a dry, humorless sound, like someone trying to needle a reaction.

Phainon's fingers twitched against the bar. He started to move—half a step, instinct tugging at him—then stopped himself.

He knew Mydei.

Knew the man would probably be more pissed if he jumped in like some well-meaning fool. Mydei wasn't one to need saving, and he sure as hell didn't like an audience.

Still, it sat wrong.

Across the room, the pickled okra contest reached its inevitable conclusion. One of them threw his hands up in triumph while the other gagged dramatically into a napkin. The crowd broke into cheers and jeers, and someone called for another round like it was the Fourth of July.

Phainon forced a smile and turned to pour, but his eyes flicked back toward the bar every other heartbeat. Not interfering. Just… keeping an eye on things.

It started small.

A hand on Mydei's shoulder. Phainon caught it mid-pour, brow ticking up. Mydei didn't flinch, but his jaw tightened—a warning if you knew how to see it.

The guy leaned in, saying something else. Phainon couldn't catch the words, but he didn't need to. The tone was easy to recognize.

Near the end of the bar, one of the old regulars gave a short snort, not bothering to turn his head. "That one's askin' for it."

Phainon set the bottle down, wiping his hands on a rag. For a second, he tried to talk himself out of it. Mydei wasn't the type to take charity, and from the look of it, he wasn't even rattled. If anything, he looked *annoyed*.

Their eyes met, just a quick glance—*I had it handled*—and Phainon answered it by moving anyway.

He came around the bar, voice sharp and easy. "Hey. You bothering my customer?"

The guy glanced over his shoulder, smirking like he thought he was funny. "Didn't know you hired bodyguards."

Phainon kept walking, stopping just beside them, his grin all teeth. “Didn’t know you were this desperate for company.”

The guy puffed up, straightening like he meant to start something. Mydei didn’t say a word, leaning back slightly with a look that said *this isn’t worth my time*.

Phainon met Mydei’s eyes again—this time a flat don’t intervene—and ignored it.

“You’re done,” Phainon said, calm as anything. “Walk.”

The bar had quieted just a notch, enough to feel the tension gathering.

The guy’s laugh came rough, sharp around the edges, like a nail dragged down glass. He started to step past, but couldn’t help himself—leaned in, breath close enough that Mydei tilted his head back a fraction, the barest sign of distance.

And then the words, pitched low, just for him.

“Bet you look a lot less mean when someone’s got their hands on you.”

A smirk, all teeth and cheap bravado.

The room didn’t catch it. No one at the tables noticed. But Phainon did.

He wasn’t even sure what told him first—maybe the faint twitch in Mydei’s jaw, or the way his fingers stayed wrapped around his glass, a little too tight, like the grip alone was keeping him from saying something sharp enough to cut. His expression didn’t crack, didn’t so much as twitch. But there was something cold and ancient in the way his gaze slid past the man, like he wasn’t worth even the flicker of acknowledgement.

Bigger man. Always had been.

But Phainon could feel it. The air stretched thin.

He spoke, voice level, the smile on his face the same sharp-edged thing he gave drunk creeps he was about to throw out.

“You need to leave.”

The guy snorted, playing the aggrieved innocent. Hands up, palms out. “Easy, bartender. Just saying hey.”

Phainon didn’t blink.

The man turned, heading for the door—but made sure to clip Mydei’s shoulder as he passed. Deliberate. Petty. Meant to be small enough to excuse, but sharp enough to sting.

And for the first time all night, Mydei’s mask faltered.

Not a flinch. Just a stiffening of his shoulders, a muscle jumping in his jaw. A glint of something ugly in those eyes.

Phainon didn’t need a second invitation.

The second Mydei’s shoulder tensed, Phainon moved.

Didn’t think.

His body just *went*—vaulting the bar like his grandmother had called his full damn name from the church steps and he knew better than to keep her waiting.

The room barely had time to register it.

The drunk turned, smug still curling his lip, starting to say something —“What, you gonna—”

Crack.

One clean, farm-raised haymaker. The kind born from hauling livestock gates and splitting cordwood.

Phainon’s fist collided with the man’s jaw so hard the sound snapped through the bar like a starter’s pistol. A sharp, vicious noise that silenced every voice, every clink of glass. Even the radio felt quieter.

The guy staggered back a step, surprise blooming across his face—for a single, stupid second—before his legs went out and he hit the floor like a sack of wet feed.

Dead weight. Out cold.

The silence after stretched long.

No one moved. No one breathed.

Not the old men in the corner, not the casserole ladiy halfway through a gossip, not the two okra competitors mid-chew.

And then—a voice, rough and pleased from the back.

“’Bout damn time.”

It broke the spell. A few snorts of laughter, muttered agreements. Nobody moved to help the prick on the floor.

Phainon flexed his hand, blood already welling up in split knuckles, and finally exhaled.

Only then did he look to Mydei.

Still at the bar. Glass in hand. Those sharp golden eyes wide—not scared, never that, just… caught off-guard. Like the last person in the room who expected *that* out of *him*.

For once, Mydei had nothing to say.

Phainon huffed a humorless snort, shaking out his hand.

“Should’ve done it two minutes ago,” he muttered, already turning toward the back to fetch ice.

Mydei shifted, like he might reach out—maybe to stop him, maybe to say something—but it was right then that Cipher burst through the back door with her usual flair.

“I’m back~ Hope you didn’t miss me too—”

She caught sight of Mydei first, halfway into a grin, then her eyes dropped to the crumpled body on the floor.

“Holy shit.”

Everyone stayed quiet, watching her.

Phainon, already behind the counter again, wrapping a clean towel around his knuckles, didn’t even glance up. “Handled it.”

Cipher’s gaze bounced from the knocked-out guy to Phainon, to Mydei, then back again. Her brow twitched.

Before she could ask, one of the men in the corner grunted, “Fool was gettin’ too handsy. Had it comin’.”

Another chimed in, “Guy was askin’ for it.”

Cipher let out a long, bone-deep sigh, scrubbing a hand over her face. “Knew I shouldn’t’ve let you near whiskey drinkers.”

Phainon shrugged, still tying off the towel around his split knuckles.

“You know what,” she muttered, waving it off. “Fine. I’ll deal with the rest of your shift. Go get that cleaned up before you bleed on my floor.”

She jerked her chin at the bouncer loitering by the jukebox. “Get this idiot outta here.”

The guy grunted and moved toward the dead weight on the ground.

A few murmurs floated up around the room. A lady whispered, “Didn’t think that one had it in him.”

Another one snorted. “Guess the quiet ones’ll do you in every time.”

As Phainon headed for the back, passing by a cluster of curious stares, he muttered just loud enough to be heard, “Surprise.”

The door swung shut behind him.

The muffled hum of the bar dropped away, replaced by the quiet drip of a leaky faucet and the sharp, metallic tang of blood on his knuckles.

He twisted the tap, cold water gushing out with a groan. The sting hit as soon as his skin touched it, but he let it wash over him, streaks of red swirling down the drain. He watched it go, jaw tight.

Did he regret it? Not one bit.

Causing Cipher a headache, though—yeah, that part gnawed at him. She ran a tight ship, and he wasn’t the type to leave a mess for someone else to clean up. He’d make it up to her. Another shift favor, a case of that weird cherry brandy she liked, hell, fixing that janky stool by the window she kept swearing she’d get to.

He flexed his hand under the water, watching blood mix with bruising already rising under the skin. A familiar ache. One he hadn’t felt in a while.

It pulled a memory up with it—Cyrene, back when they were kids. She used to get it bad from some little assholes in their neighborhood. Mean for no reason, the way kids could be. Phainon never even thought about it. He just started walking her everywhere, posted up by her side like a second shadow. The first time someone got brave and tried something with him around, he broke a kid’s nose before he knew he was moving.

That had been the end of that.

He reached for the medkit, the latch sticking like always. Popped it open with a thumb and grabbed a wad of gauze. The antiseptic stung like hell, but whatever. He’d taken worse.

This wasn’t the same though. Mydei wasn’t some kid who needed watching. Hell, if Phainon hadn’t stepped in, he half-wondered if Mydei would’ve handled it himself, maybe worse.

And yet, the look—that flicker, barely there—had hit something in him. Something ugly. He didn’t like seeing it. Not on Mydei. Not on anyone.

Phainon worked the gauze around his knuckles, flexed his fingers, winced. Should’ve hit the bastard harder.

He shut the kit, leaning against the counter for a second. The ache in his hand, the leftover pulse of adrenaline in his veins—it all left him restless.

But yeah—he’d square things with Cipher later.

For now, he needed air.

The back door groaned as Phainon shoved it open with his shoulder, the heavy night air rushing to meet him. Cool, a little damp, carrying the distant hum of traffic and the faint sour tang of garbage from the next alley over. But it was better than inside—quieter.

He let the door swing shut behind him with a dull thud and leaned his weight against the brick wall, tipping his head back to look at the sky. City stars—faint, blurred out by light pollution, but there if you knew where to look. He filled his lungs, the tension slowly uncoiling from his shoulders. His hand throbbed under the makeshift wrap, a dull, steady reminder of his temper.

A muscle jumped in his jaw.

He let out a breath.

The silence didn’t last long.

Footsteps. Light, even ones, shoes scuffing faintly against the cracked concrete. Phainon didn’t open his eyes, figured it was Cipher, maybe sending one of the bouncers to scold him or check he wasn’t bleeding out.

But then the scent hit him—clean, sharp, a little expensive. Sandalwood and something crisp, like bergamot.

He cracked one eye open.

Beige.

Of course.

Mydei stepped into the alley like he belonged there, hands in his pocket, eyes catching on Phainon with that same unreadable calm he wore like armor.

Phainon let his head thunk lightly against the brick behind him.

“Well,” he muttered, “figured you’d be halfway home by now.”

Mydei leaned against the opposite wall, a lazy sort of posture that still felt deliberate. “Didn’t feel like it.”

Phainon huffed a breath, something between a laugh and a sigh. “You alright?”

Mydei’s brow ticked up, like the question surprised him. “You should be asking yourself that.”

Phainon shrugged, glancing down at his hand, flexing stiff fingers against the bloodied towel. “I’ve been through worse.”

A beat passed. Mydei didn’t leave. Didn’t crack a joke or throw an insult. Just stood there, watching him like he was trying to puzzle out how someone so aggravating could also be so goddamn reckless.

“You didn’t have to do that,” Mydei said, careful.

Phainon gave a crooked smile. “Yeah, I know. I wanted to.”

Mydei sighed, rubbing a hand over his face. “You’re an idiot.”

“Getting that a lot tonight.”

“You could’ve waited. Cipher’s place is neutral. Deal with it outside the line.”

Phainon blinked, then squinted at him. “Wait… that’s what you were gonna —?”

“Handle it quietly with no witnesses, no trouble for Cipher.” Mydei’s tone was flat, but there was the faintest twitch of something amused in his expression. “Now you went and made it a thing.”

“Oh,” Phainon muttered, sheepish. “Guess I stepped on your moment, huh?”

Mydei didn’t answer. Just crossed the space between them in a few steps, stopping close enough to grab Phainon’s wrist and pry the towel loose. His fingers were cool, careful in a way that caught Phainon off guard.

“Dumbass,” Mydei muttered, inspecting the raw knuckles. “Messy punch. Bet your hand hurts worse than his face.”

“Hey, worked, didn’t it?”

Mydei rolled his eyes but didn’t let go. “Next time, keep your thumb outside your fist.”

Phainon smirked, leaning a little into the contact without thinking. “Look at you, giving me lessons now.”

“Somebody has to.”

Mydei let go of his hand, stepping back like nothing’d happened. The air felt heavier for it.

“Get that cleaned properly,” Mydei murmured, already tucking his hands back into his pockets.

“Yeah, yeah,” Phainon grumbled, managing a lopsided grin. “Next time, maybe carry some pepper spray on you.”

Mydei snorted, eyes catching on his like he wanted to say something else—didn’t. The two of them lingered there a beat longer than necessary, the distance between them thinning in the quiet, something unspoken but not uncomfortable hanging in the air.

Then—

“Oi, lover boy,” Cipher’s voice cracked sharp from the doorway. “If you’re done brooding in my alley, get your ass back inside.”

Phainon groaned, letting his head thump back against the wall. “Gods, kill me.”

Mydei chuckled under his breath, a rare, quiet thing, and with that, the moment scattered like dust.

They headed back in, no words needed.

And that was that.

Chapter End Notes

> Does Phainon give more Michigan or Missouri vibes? I wanna write more abt his hometown but I’m STUCK between those 2 unfortunately

Chapter 4: In Vino Veritas… Unfortunately

Chapter Summary

> Phainon drinks too much, accidentally charms Mydei's terrifying mother, gets pawned off on Mydei to drive him home, bites him, emotionally overshares, and somehow leaves the night with Mydei's number and a grumpy guardian angel watching till he gets inside.

Chapter Notes

> Alright I'm not sure if anyone is still interested in this??? But I'm gonna try my best to update it still🙃

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon stepped off the crowded bus and into a neighborhood that made his skin itch.

Everything here gleamed. The streets were spotless, the storefront windows polished to a shine so sharp it caught the last scraps of sunlight like cut glass. Even the trees looked like they'd been handpicked, shipped in, and arranged just so—branches manicured within an inch of their lives, leaves the same shade of green. He could practically hear the maintenance budget bleeding out for them.

The borrowed blazer hung heavy on his shoulders. Caelus was shorter by a couple inches, but he preferred oversized, and so the sleeves kept sliding down to swallow half his hands. Phainon tugged at the lapels and muttered, mostly to himself.

"Alright. Let's get this over with."

Ahead, the building rose up like something out of an architectural digest spread—all glass, pale stone, and sharp, modernist edges. Warm light spilled out through tall windows, amber and inviting, while the low pulse of

music drifted past the automatic doors. It barely carried over the steady hiss of traffic and the occasional slap of a car door closing.

Valets in tailored uniforms moved like clockwork along the curb, ushering guests into black sedans, murmuring into earpieces, vanishing through side entrances. Somewhere inside, laughter broke through the hum of conversation, a bright splash of sound quickly swallowed by the night.

Phainon stayed where he was for a beat longer than he should have. Hands in his pockets, shoulders hunched against the lake breeze that always came creeping up in the evenings, no matter how hot the day had been. The sun had already started to dip, but in this part of the city, it didn't matter. The streets never really went dark. Every window reflected the next, coins flashing under streetlights, the skyline turning to a mosaic of artificial gold.

He exhaled through his nose.

God, I hate these things.

He wasn't supposed to be here. Not really. The invitation—if you could call it that—had been for department heads, project leads, and "key integration personnel." A mixer. A networking event. A thin excuse to drink wine, feign goodwill, and let Castrum Kremnos plant their flag before the merger officially landed. A show of force dressed up as team-building.

And Phainon? He worked spreadsheets. That was it. His face wasn't on any company-wide memo. No one sent him priority emails or looped him into project calls. He was a warm body in a cubicle, one desk in a sea of them.

But the email had been clear: **attendance strongly encouraged.** And Phainon… well. He needed this job. Desperately. Cyrene's tuition wasn't going to pay itself, and there weren't a lot of openings back in Missouri for a kid who could juggle financial reports faster than most people could tie their shoes.

So here he was. In a neighborhood his bank account resented, wearing a jacket that didn't fit, after twelve hours of back-to-back outages, three

passive-aggressive Procurement tickets, and one HR training video that somehow managed to make the word *synergy* sound obscene.

Another breath, heavier this time.

It was going to be a long night.

A car door thunked shut nearby, crisp in the evening air. A man in a suit—phone pressed to his ear—brushed past without so much as a glance, deep in conversation, laughing at something Phainon didn't catch.

Everyone here had a place to be. A person to meet. A conversation to start. None of it involved the guy in the too-big blazer loitering at the curb.

He rolled his shoulders. Adjusted the jacket again. His feet ached. He smelled like the bus. But there was whiskey inside, and he could fake a smile for a couple hours.

Time to earn that tuition.

Phainon made himself move, crossing the pavement toward the doors.

Just inside the doors, a check-in podium stood like a customs station for the terminally overdressed. A young woman in a fitted black suit manned it, tablet in hand, her expression the kind of professionally polite that suggested she, too, was counting the hours until this was over.

Her eyes lifted as Phainon approached, flicking over the too-large blazer, the creased collar of his shirt, and the faint sheen of sweat still clinging to his skin from the bus ride. If she had an opinion about any of it, she kept it to herself. Maybe one eyebrow ticked upward, just a fraction, but the polite smile stayed in place.

"Name and department?" she asked, already tapping at the screen.

Phainon tugged at the front of his jacket, though it didn't help. His voice came out low, rough around the edges.

"Phainon. Okhema Tech."

Her fingers moved quickly, scrolling through the list. She repeated his name under her breath, a faint note of skepticism in it, like she wasn't sure she'd heard it right. Then, after a beat, she found it. A small nod.

"You're all set. Enjoy your evening."

He didn't bother with a reply. Just gave a tired, half-hearted smile and kept moving.

The space beyond the checkpoint opened up like the lobby of some luxury hotel, cavernous and overdesigned, every surface engineered to impress. Marble floors gleamed under the steady glow of amber lighting. Classical music drifted through the air, all strings and soft percussion—the kind of piece you wouldn't be able to name, but would instantly recognize as old. It sounded like movies about estate disputes and legal battles.

Catering staff in uniforms wove through the room, balancing trays of delicate, abstract hors d'oeuvres that looked like they'd been assembled with tweezers. No one actually seemed to be eating them. They were props. Texture for the room.

It wasn't hard to tell the Okhema staff from the Kremnos suits. Okhema people gathered along the perimeter, clustered near exits, walls, and conveniently placed potted plants. You could spot them by the way their eyes kept scanning the room, looking for allies, escape routes, or reasons to pretend they were checking a message. Most of them had the uneasy, braced-for-impact posture of people uncertain whether they were at a celebration or a culling.

The Kremnos crowd, on the other hand, moved like apex predators. Tailored suits, practiced smiles, and the kind of laughter that always landed half a decibel too loud. Groups shifted through the room in practiced orbits, speaking the language of ownership without having to say it out loud.

Phainon sighed quietly, stepping further in. He recognized a handful of faces—a few people from his floor, a couple of managers he vaguely remembered from company-wide emails—but none he was in any hurry to talk to. Nobody looked his way. Which was fine. Preferable, really.

A tray passed by, carrying tiny, symmetrical creations balanced on crackers and what looked like edible flowers. Phainon gave it a wide berth. The day he voluntarily ate something that cost more than his lunch was the day he tendered his resignation.

His eyes swept the room and landed on the bar.

It stretched along the far wall, all backlit gold and glass shelves stacked with bottles so spotless they practically sparkled. If there was one thing this city consistently got right, it was a good bar, even in places like this.

Well. When in Chicago.

He made his way through the crowd, weaving between clusters of Kremnos execs and a pair of Okhema engineers pretending to be deeply invested in the health of a decorative ficus. The music and chatter rolled around him in waves, all carefully modulated with the perfected the art of sounding affable while measuring social capital.

At the bar, a lean, nice-looking bartender greeted him with a small, professional nod.

“What can I get you?”

“Whiskey,” Phainon said, resting both hands on the bar’s edge. “Neat.”

The bartender didn’t ask which kind. He reached for a bottle with a label Phainon didn’t bother trying to read. The glass landed in front of him a moment later, the liquid catching the light like old brass.

Phainon knocked it back in one go. It hit hard, warmth unspooling in his chest and stomach, a steady burn that chased away the lingering edge of exhaustion. He set the glass down a little too firmly, earning a brief flick of a glance from the bartender.

“Another?” the man asked, already reaching for the bottle.

Phainon hesitated for half a second, then gave a nod.

“Better make it a double.”

He wasn’t sure how long he’d need to last here, but he already knew he was going to need it.

The second glass went down slower. Not by much. Phainon let the burn linger a little longer this time, rolling over his tongue before he tipped the last of it back. The glass made a soft clink as he set it down, and the bartender—ever watchful—reached for the bottle again.

Phainon waved him off with a small shake of his head.

He let out a breath through his nose, leaned forward onto the bar, and rested his forearms against the cool wood. His head dipped, forehead brushing the backs of his crossed arms. Eyes closed.

It wasn’t so bad, really.

Nobody was bothering him. He wasn’t expected to make conversation. There was decent liquor in his system and a seat with his name on it. For a guy who’d spent hours wrangling spreadsheets and rebooting servers that had no business still being in production, this counted as peace.

If his hometown friends could see him now—hair mussed, jacket borrowed and a size too big, hiding out in a high-rise ballroom while a string quartet murdered something in C minor—they’d have a field day.

He let the sound of the room dull around him. It was easy enough to tune out when you tried.

And then—

“Hey.”

The voice was soft. Close enough to his ear that it cut through the fog and made him jolt upright, heart giving a hard, startled thud against his ribs. He twisted in his seat, scowl already forming, some half-baked *You shouldn’t sneak up on people like that* on the tip of his tongue.

Until he saw her.

“Castorice,” he blinked, tension bleeding from his shoulders like a slow release valve. A sincere smile tugged at his mouth. “Well, hell. Didn’t expect to see you tonight.”

She gave a sheepish little smile, one corner of her mouth pulling higher than the other as if not sure whether to apologize. Her hands fidgeted with the sleeves of her blouse for a second before she slid onto the stool beside him.

“I was lurking,” she admitted. “Figured I should act social before someone from HR notices.”

Phainon huffed a tired, appreciative laugh. “Same here.”

They both fell quiet for a moment. The music shifted—something slower now, more somber.

Castorice leaned in a touch, lowering her voice. “Truth is, I was avoiding Caenis.”

That earned a wince from Phainon. “Yeah. Fair call.”

“Did you see her today?” Castorice asked, eyes flicking across the room like Caenis might materialize at any moment.

“I did,” Phainon muttered. “Made eye contact once. Think my soul tried to leave my body.”

That got a real laugh out of her, small, but there.

They lapsed into another easy silence, watching the room move around them. The catering staff, the clink of glass, the gentle glow of the backlit shelves behind the bar. Phainon caught himself studying the shine of a decanter and let his gaze drift.

“I wish Aglaea was here,” he said, quiet, almost to himself.

Castorice’s smile softened. “Yeah. Me too.”

Aglaea wasn’t the kind of person to show up at these things. She didn’t need to. Her presence was reserved for boardrooms and final calls, not glass-walled mixers with $30 crackers. But she’d taken care of them, both of them, in her way. Remembered names. Pulled strings when it counted.

Phainon turned his glass between his hands, watching the last of the amber liquid catch the light. “Figures. We get left with Caenis.”

“She’s on a warpath,” Castorice murmured, her gaze drifting toward a cluster of people at the far side of the room. “Has been for weeks.”

Phainon nodded grimly. Everyone at Okhema knew what that meant. Caenis, Regional Director and head of the Chicago branch, wasn’t the kind of woman to take losing ground lightly. Not after years spent trying to claw her way into the upper circle—buying favors, making noise, staking claims. And now, with Kremnos moving in, whatever power she had left was hanging by threads.

“Can’t blame her,” Phainon admitted. “I mean, losing half your control overnight? And now you’ve got these people rolling in like they already own the place. I’d be ready to bite throats too.”

“Yeah, well,” Castorice sighed, “she’s mostly biting middle management.”

“Story of corporate America,” Phainon muttered.

The bartender slid another drink toward him, unasked. Castorice reached for it before Phainon could, curling her fingers around the glass like it was a life preserver.

“God, please,” she whispered before taking a careful sip.

Phainon watched her with a smile, lifting his own drink in a half-hearted toast. “To mutual suffering.”

She clinked her glass to his.

A little island of quiet in a place built to be loud.

The din of the mixer had dulled some—or maybe it only felt that way with Castorice settled on the stool beside him. Phainon caught the way her hands stayed folded in her lap, her posture a touch too careful for an off-the-clock evening. Like she was waiting for someone to tell her she wasn't supposed to be here.

He gave her a small nudge with his elbow. "How's Pollux been? Haven't crossed paths with her in a while."

Castorice blinked, surprised by the question, though a pleased kind of surprise. Her face softened. "She's good. Busy, as always. But she likes it."

She hesitated, then let out a soft chuckle, glancing down at her drink. "Actually, she called me this morning. Said she's got a client's family insisting on a full Renaissance-themed wake this weekend. Velvet doublets, lute music, the whole thing."

Phainon's brow lifted. "You're serious?"

"Unfortunately." Castorice's smile turned faintly exasperated. "She's been trying to track down a harpist on short notice. And apparently three separate people have asked if they can bring a falcon."

That earned a laugh from him. "People, man. That's… I mean, part of me wants to call that ridiculous, but honestly? Kind of admire the commitment."

"She said if one more person mentions birds of prey, she's handing them the keys and walking out."

Phainon grinned, shaking his head. "I don't know how she does it. I get squeamish just swapping out the toner cartridge. Can't imagine dealing with…" he gestured vaguely, "…all that." Bodies.

Castorice's smile gentled, and she let out a soft breath, tucking a loose strand of hair behind her ear. "Most people get weird about it. Either grossed out or… I don't know, morbidly fascinated. But she's always been like that. Wants to help. Says grief's easier to carry when someone actually sees you."

Phainon nodded, the words settling in.

"Sounds like good work to me," he said quietly.

Castorice looked down, tracing the rim of her glass with a fingertip. "Yeah. It is. I just…" She hesitated. "Sometimes I worry she takes on too much. It wears on her. But she says it's worth it, so."

Phainon gave a small nod. "The world could use a few more like that."

She glanced up then, and for a moment their eyes met.

Castorice offered a genuine smile and took a sip of her drink.

Phainon finished off the last of his whiskey. His gaze drifted absently over the crowd. Same faces. Same suits and easy, hollow laughs. He was about to turn back to Castorice when—

A flicker of blonde cut through the crowd.

Something about it hit sharp and sudden, a clean, involuntary jolt. Phainon's throat caught on the last of his drink, the liquor burning the wrong way.

He coughed, nearly choking, glass clinking against the bar as his fingers twitched. His heart gave a sharp, unwelcome skip.

No. Way.

Phainon hadn't meant to stare.

One moment, he was idly scanning the crowd, half-listening to the music, and the next—there he was.

Leaning casually against one of those marble-topped cocktail tables, water glass in hand, hair catching the light like it had been arranged that way on purpose. It wasn't perfect, though. Slicked back, sure, but just a little messy near the crown, almost purposeful. The suit was tailored, somehow managing to look effortless in a room full of people trying far too hard.

And he was smiling.

Not the self-satisfied smirk Phainon had expected, either. This was easier. Unpolished. Whatever some man beside him had said made him laugh, his head tipping slightly, teeth flashing before he caught himself and settled back into something softer. He held the glass loosely in his fingers, completely at ease in a room that made Phainon feel like he'd come in through the freight elevator.

The sinking feeling in his stomach arrived right on cue.

He didn't even realize how long he'd been looking until Castorice shifted beside him, following his gaze.

"…What are you—?"

Phainon winced and reached out, guiding her gently down behind the oversized floral arrangement on the bar. "Don't look."

Castorice blinked at him, puzzled but compliant, lowering her voice. "Why? Who is it?"

"Just—hang on." He peered out again, careful. Castorice hesitated, then angled her head to get a better look. A flicker of recognition crossed her face, brows drawing together.

"I've seen him online before. That's Kremnos's—"

"—damn coffee thief," Phainon finished, his voice sharp with the kind of bitterness usually reserved for tax audits.

Castorice turned to him, confusion giving way to reluctant amusement. "Wait. That's the one you're always complaining about? The guy who

keeps taking your orders?”

“Yes,” Phainon muttered, slumping forward against the bar like he could disappear into it. “That’s him. I knew it. Of course he works for Kremnos. He looks like the kind of guy who gets a VP title just for having a family trust.”

He let out a quiet groan, scrubbing a hand over his face. “I swear, it’s like the city’s conspiring against me. First at the café, then at Cipher’s place, now here? There’s *three million* people in this city, Castorice.”

She watched him for a moment, something flickering behind her calm expression.

“You sure you’re not exaggerating?” she asked, brow lifted.

Phainon opened his mouth, a protest half-formed, but the words stalled.

“He’s…rude,” he managed, gesturing vaguely toward the far side of the room. “One of those people who acts like the whole world’s his living room. And look at him.” He shook his head, the irritation prickling under his skin. “I mean, come on. Nobody should be allowed to have a face like that and still make it worse by knowing it.”

He hesitated, his gaze drifting back.

“His figure too,” Phainon muttered, almost to himself. “Tall, narrow waist, broad-shouldered, but not in a loud way. Carries it well. And then there’s those eyes…”

He trailed off, frowning at his own words.

Castorice’s lips twitched.

“Phainon,” she said, eyes glinting with amusement.

“What?”

“You realize you’re describing someone you’d swipe right on so fast you’d sprain your wrist.”

He shot her a scowl, warmth creeping onto his face. “I hate him.”

She took a sip from her glass, her smirk barely contained. “Sure you do.”

“It’s not personal,” Phainon muttered. “I don’t care who people are. But it’s the principle of the thing. Who drinks someone else’s Americano with oat milk three times and has the nerve to act like *I’m* the problem for not grabbing it faster?”

Castorice made a sympathetic noise, though the corner of her mouth quirked up again.

“Sounds exhausting.”

“Oh, he’s a menace,” Phainon grumbled, peeking over the flowers once more.

Mydei—still standing by that table—was leaning back now as someone in a navy tie showed him something in a small leather notebook. Whatever it was, it pulled another unguarded smile from him.

And worse than that, people gravitated to him. Faces turned his way, conversations tilted to include him. He had that easy, magnetic pull, like a natural center of gravity in a room full of artificial ones.

Phainon’s stomach tightened in a way he pointedly refused to examine.

“You’re staring again,” Castorice murmured.

“I’m not.”

“You are.”

He made a face, knocking back the last of his drink. “Not my type,” he added, a little too fast.

Castorice bit her lip, fighting a grin, eyes glinting behind the rim of her glass.

Phainon was just about to tell her to wipe that look off her face when the room shifted. It was subtle at first—a ripple through the crowd as conversations stuttered, laughter stalled, and heads turned toward the broad staircase at the far side of the floor.

A voice cut through, bright and sharp as glass.

“Ladies and gentlemen.”

Phainon winced. He didn’t need to look to know.

Caenis.

There she stood, a step above the floor like a queen surveying lesser kingdoms. Her dress was a charcoal gray, cut to intimidate rather than flatter, and her silver hair was pinned back with the kind of precision that suggested weapons training. She held a champagne flute like it might double as a blade.

“If I could have your attention for a moment.”

The Kremnos people turned toward her politely. The Okhema employees stiffened in place, every one of them clocking the social temperature drop like deer catching a distant scent. Phainon felt his jaw tighten reflexively. He wasn’t even doing anything, and still half-expected to get written up for whatever reason.

Caenis smiled—or showed teeth. It was a fine line.

“I’d like to propose a toast,” she went on, voice polished to a dangerous shine. “To new partnerships, shared innovation, and the opportunities ahead as our two companies integrate.”

She said it like a battlefield report.

Servers slipped through the crowd with silver trays, tall, narrow flutes catching the light. Phainon grabbed one without hesitation—a muscle memory from years of office parties where the drinks were the only thing worth showing up for.

Beside him, Castorice reached for one too, then hesitated with a faint grimace.

“Hang on,” she murmured, nodding toward a passing tray carrying something non-alcoholic.

Phainon tipped his glass toward her. “Godspeed.”

She disappeared into the moving current of people, a soft flicker of lavender in a sea of black and navy.

Caenis was still talking. Legacy, market synergy, shared values. Phainon’s mind bailed at synergy, his stomach lurching in protest. He gave the champagne a slow swirl, watching the bubbles race to the surface like tiny, doomed escape attempts.

He was halfway through debating whether to bother drinking it when Castorice reappeared, eyeing him skeptically.

“Phainon…” she said, eyeing the flute in his hand, “you know whiskey and champagne don’t mix.”

He shrugged. “Neither do Okhema and Kremnos.”

Castorice made a face, because it wasn’t wrong.

“Be careful,” she said, softer now.

Before he could answer, someone behind her called her name—one of the HR reps, mouthing an apologetic sorry like it mattered.

Castorice sighed, tilting her head toward the sound. “Back in a minute.”

Phainon lifted his glass in a lazy salute. “I’ll be here.”

She smiled, then slipped back into the crowd.

Eventually, Caenis's voice fading back into the background hum. Phainon glanced down at the champagne in his hand.

He lifted it to eye level.

You know what?

Tipped the glass slightly.

I'm drinking until I tolerate these people… or forget them.

And downed it in one go.

He coughed once, snorted a laugh at himself, and reached for the whiskey he'd left abandoned nearby.

The night, he decided, still had room to get worse.

And for now, that felt fine.

Phainon had lost track of how long it had been since Castorice vanished into the crowd again, or how many flutes of champagne he'd pilfered off passing trays. The buzz had settled in comfortably, a warmth in his chest, a pleasant hum behind his eyes.

He stood, stretching a little, scanning the room for another drink and maybe a friendly face. A tray passed by and he reached for it—and missed.

"Shit—"

The tray wobbled. The server's eyes went wide.

Phainon caught it just in time, steadying the glasses with a half-apologetic gesture. "Easy, bud. My bad. I owe you one."

The server gave him a tight, grateful nod and hurried off. Phainon chuckled under his breath, turned—and nearly walked straight into someone.

He stumbled a step back. “Oh—sorry, ma’am. Didn’t see you there.”

The woman he’d almost bowled over regarded him with a cool, unreadable look. Pale eyes, the color of golden frost under glass. Not young, though it was hard to tell exactly how old. The kind of face ruthless genetics preserved.

Her dress was deep red, clean lines and fitter, a signet ring on one hand. Hair nearly white-blonde, swept back like it had taken hours to style.

An elegant brow arched.

“Ma’am?” she repeated, voice smooth as polished glass. There was the faintest glint of humor in it. “How old do you think I am?”

Phainon, buzzed but not a complete fool, gave a grin. “Couldn’t say, ma’am. My mama taught me better than to guess. ‘Ma’am’s just good manners where I come from. I call my niece ma’am when she’s got a butter knife.”

A flicker of something—amusement, maybe—tugged at the corner of her mouth.

Before either of them could say more, Castorice’s voice cut in, a little breathless as she hurried up.

“There you are—sorry, they needed me for—”

She stopped mid-sentence, her expression freezing.

Phainon glanced back at her, still grinning. “You missed it. I was about to charm this nice lady here—”

Castorice’s face drained of color. She flicked her gaze from the woman to Phainon. “Hi,” she said, brittle, dipping her head in a polite nod. “So sorry

to interrupt. They just—uh, needed me for something. Everything's fine now."

Phainon frowned, caught off guard by the sudden shift in her tone.

"What?"

Castorice slid up beside him, her elbow nudging his ribs, and leaned in close enough he could feel her breath against his ear.

"That's Gorgo," she murmured.

He blinked.

"The who?"

"The Gorgo. Chairwoman. Castrum Kremnos."

Phainon felt the blood drain from his face so fast it left his ears ringing.

"Oh," he said faintly.

Castorice pasted on a professional smile, directing it toward Gorgo like a peace offering.

"Wonderful celebration you're hosting, ma'am, right Phainon?"

She elbowed Phainon again, harder this time.

He cleared his throat, his earlier bravado shriveling under the weight of the realization.

"Right. Uh. Yep. Real… festive. Big fan of… uh. Mergers."

The words came out like a man digging his own grave with a dessert spoon.

Gorgo studied him, head tilted slightly, those pale eyes sharp and assessing. He had the distinct, certain feeling he was being filed, categorized, and judged in the space of a heartbeat.

And then—the smallest twitch of her mouth when she heard Castorice.

“*Phainon*, is it?”

He swallowed.

“Yes, ma’am.”

She made a quiet, thoughtful sound, almost to herself.

Castorice looked like she might faint.

“Well, we should probably—” she started, grabbing for Phainon’s sleeve.

But Gorgo lifted a hand, a small, absent gesture that stopped them cold.

“You and I,” she started. “We’ll have to catch up. I hear,” and here her voice dipped, more to herself than to them, “something about coffee?”

Phainon’s stomach sank somewhere near his knees.

Gorgo took another unhurried sip, gave him one final glance, then turned and walked away, her heels clicking against the marble like distant hammer strikes.

Phainon let out a slow, shaky breath.

“Castorice.”

She was already halfway to moving again. “Yeah?”

“I’m so, so fired.”

Castorice gave him a helpless look, sympathy clear in her expression, then muttered something about good luck before vanishing into the crowd.

Phainon took a steadying breath, ducked around a cluster of people, and picked up his pace.

“Hey—uh, ma’am,” he called softly as he caught up.

Gorgo didn’t stop right away. She slowed, then glanced over her shoulder, one brow lifting in faint, almost lazy curiosity.

He hesitated, then managed an apologetic smile. “Didn’t mean to be a pain earlier. Figured since I already made an ass of myself, might as well finish the job proper.”

That earned him a long look. But instead of the cool dismissal he half-expected, she turned to face him fully.

“You’ve got nerve.”

“Blame the champagne,” he shrugged. “Or my mother. Could go either way.”

A small sound escaped her, somewhere between a scoff and a laugh. But she stayed.

Gorgo studied him a moment longer, then asked, casual in tone, precise in intent:

“Where are you from?”

Phainon blinked at the bluntness. “Missouri. Farm town. Middle of nowhere.”

She gave a slight nod, filing it away. “And what do you do?”

“Numbers,” he said simply. “Finance division. Okhema.”

Her brow lifted, just a fraction. “And how did you land that?”

He huffed a laugh. “Honestly? Dumb luck. I was new in town, ran into Aglaea at this old diner a couple years back. Didn’t know who she was. She liked my attitude. Gave me a job.”

Both her brows rose this time, though she made no comment. *Aglaea*. That, he could tell, had landed somewhere important.

She took a slow sip from her glass, eyes never leaving him.

“And Chicago?”

His grin softened, a little sheepish. “Seemed like the kind of place you could either make something of yourself, or fall on your face so hard it left a crater. Figured either way, it’d be a story worth telling.”

The honesty of it hung there for a beat.

It disarmed her more than she expected.

“And why this work?” she asked, voice a touch quieter now, though still edged with a kind of test.

Phainon thought about hedging. Didn’t.

“I’m good at it,” he said. “Numbers make sense when people don’t. Guess that’s reason enough.”

A flicker of interest sharpened her gaze.

“And this room?” she asked, gesturing subtly to the expanse of people’s. “What’s your read?”

He hesitated. Not out of fear—more a quiet calculation. How much would get him fired, and how much was worth saying anyway.

“Too many people here think ambition makes cruelty clever,” he said after a moment. “Ambition’s fine. Necessary, even. But there’s a difference between being sharp and being a prick about it.”

He scratched the back of his neck. “World could use more people who don’t treat empathy like a weakness.”

For a quiet second, she didn’t answer.

Then, in a rare and unsettlingly moment, the hard line of her mouth sharpened.

She tipped her glass toward him. “You might survive here.”

Phainon raised his empty glass in return. “Wouldn’t bet on it.”

That earned a sharp, almost surprised breath of amusement from her. He still couldn’t tell whether she was entertained, impressed, or just enjoying the novelty of someone not breaking into a sweat under her gaze.

He cocked his head, testing the waters between them.

“Tell me,” he said, “is it always this much of a circus?”

A wry glint in her eye now.

“This is a quiet night.”

He groaned. “Christ.”

And for the first time, her smile reached the edges of her eyes.

For a few minutes, the conversation lingered there—a strange, easy sort of detente. The wheeling and dealing of the room carried on beyond their little corner, but it felt distant. A background hum neither of them particularly cared to join.

Then, her gaze flicked past him. Something shifted in her posture.

Phainon caught the change, followed her line of sight.

Across the room, Mydei stood half-turned, deep in conversation with one of the old guard from the Okhema board. The warm overhead light caught the angles of his face, the way he moved with grace.

Then Mydei’s gaze lifted.

Their eyes met.

A jolt—sharp, immediate. Like grabbing a live wire.

Phainon's stomach did an undignified somersault.

Mydei's expression flickered, something too fast to name. Surprise, maybe. Or irritation. Then his gaze dropped to Gorgo standing beside him.

The shift in his face was immediate. His mouth tightened. Eyes narrowing, calculating.

And then, without a word, Mydei started toward them.

A slow, deliberate pace.

Phainon felt his pulse kick up.

"Oh, for the love of—"

Gorgo smiled.

Phainon braced.

What the hell did he want now?

And then—

"Everything alright?" Mydei asked, his voice threaded through with a polite neutrality that didn't fool Phainon for a second.

Gorgo smiled, an elegant tilt of her head. "Of course. Why wouldn't it be?"

Mydei's expression didn't shift, but Phainon caught the faint narrowing of his eyes. There was something underneath it, a quiet *what the hell are you doing that.*

"I wasn't aware you were taking meetings tonight," Mydei said lightly.

"Who said this was a meeting?" Gorgo countered. "I'm perfectly capable of having a conversation without an agenda."

Mydei didn’t argue, though it was clear from his posture that he didn’t buy it. His gaze flicked once more to Phainon, and though his face remained polite, there was a weight to it.

Before Phainon could excuse himself, Gorgo glanced at the time on her watch. “Well,” she murmured, “I should be getting on.”

She took a step past Mydei, paused, and with a small, conspiratorial smile, murmured just for him, “I do like him, though.”

If Mydei’s eyes twitched at that, it was barely perceptible.

And then she was gone, heels clicking against the marble as she disappeared into the crowd.

The silence that settled in her wake was immediate.

Mydei turned back to him, gaze cool. “It’s you.”

Phainon, already knowing this was a terrible idea, grabbed a passing glass of something pale and sparkling, downing it in one go before answering.

“Who else?”

Mydei’s brow lifted, a fraction. The way his gaze lingered, the slight crease between his brows—a flicker of something like concern, showed before disappearing. He adjusted his cuff, looking the other man over like a puzzle piece that didn’t belong on his board.

“You work for Kremnos, then?” Phainon asked, managing to keep his tone casual, if a little tight.

“And you,” Mydei replied, “at Okhema.”

Phainon gave a humorless smile. “Lucky us.”

They stood there for a moment, neither willing to back down just yet.

“Are you following me?” Mydei asked idly, though there was a pointed edge to it.

Phainon snorted. “I should be the one asking you that.”

“Sure,” Mydei said mildly, though the glint in his eyes suggested he didn’t believe it for a second.

Another beat. A flicker of mutual irritation softened, just barely, into something that wasn’t quite hostility.

“I’m sure you have better people to talk to,” Mydei said finally.

Phainon raised a brow. “Same.”

A mutual, noncommittal sound passed between them—a clipped, amused huff on one side, a humorless grunt on the other. And then, without ceremony, they both turned and walked in opposite directions.

Phainon didn’t look back.

He cut through the throng of guests, eyes scanning for Castorice again. He spotted her a few feet away, caught in awkward conversation with a man who looked like he hadn’t noticed her discomfort or didn’t care to. She stood rigid, polite smile stretched too thin.

Without breaking stride, Phainon reached her, gently but firmly taking her by the arm.

“Let’s go,” he muttered.

The man started to protest, but Phainon shot him a look that made it clear he was done with pleasantries. “Move.”

It worked. The man’s mouth closed. He stepped aside.

Phainon steered Castorice away from the cluster of people and didn’t let go until they’d put several bodies between themselves and the rest of the room.

“Thanks,” Castorice said, blinking up at him, clearly surprised by the abrupt shift in his mood. “You okay?”

He ran a hand through his hair. “Define okay.”

She sighed, a little relieved. “Well, good news is we’ve got about an hour left before it’s socially acceptable to leave.”

“Fantastic,” Phainon muttered. “What now?”

Castorice gave him a sidelong look. “What do you think?”

“No,” she said preemptively, seeing the glint in his eye.

He raised a brow. “Got a better idea?”

She opened her mouth, hesitated, then grimaced. “Bar it is… again.”

“Thought so.”

It wasn’t like this was new.

Phainon and Castorice had a long, reliable history of nights like this—usually ending with one of them half-carrying the other out of some bar, navigating streets and subway stops by sheer muscle memory. It wasn’t something they planned so much as a system that had evolved naturally over time. Whoever sobered up first took the other home, no questions asked. Castorice, more often than not, was the lightweight. Not tonight.

Somewhere along the way, Phainon had passed the event horizon of drunk. He couldn’t remember how much he had. What he did remember was leaning heavily against Castorice now, head lolling a little toward her shoulder, content. She’d just finished saying something—something completely idiotic, though in the moment it had struck him as the most incisive wit imaginable.

“—and then I told him, buddy,” Castorice was crowing, brandishing her glass as she spoke, “if you’re gonna try flirting with me, at least learn what

a P/E ratio is first."

Phainon let out a laugh so loud it startled the people nearest them, nearly doubling over where he sat. "No. No, you didn't."

"Dead serious."

"Genius," he slurred, pointing a finger at her like she'd just delivered the greatest punchline in modern history. "That's—you should be giving seminars, Cast."

She giggled, cheeks flushed but still solidly in control of her faculties. "You're a mess."

"I'm peak performance," Phainon declared, lifting his empty glass in a grand, sloppy toast before realizing it was long since drained.

It might've gone on like that—harmlessly drunk, good-naturedly obnoxious, the two of them in their own little orbit—if not for the abrupt vibration of Castorice's phone against her palm.

She frowned, glanced down at the screen. A number she didn't recognize. "Hold on," she murmured, moving to answer.

Phainon didn't pay it any mind at first. He was still riding the high of their ridiculous joke, snickering to himself. But something about Castorice's posture changed. The slouch of tipsy comfort vanished, her shoulders going rigid. The color drained from her face by degrees, and her voice dropped to a hush.

He blinked, trying to focus.

"Hey," he slurred, reaching out to nudge her arm, "you good?"

She didn't answer at first, murmuring something low into the phone he couldn't catch. Then, all at once, she stiffened, setting her drink aside with a carelessness that sent it sloshing dangerously close to the rim.

Phainon's heart sank. "Castorice?"

She ended the call with a sharp exhale, scrubbing a hand over her face. “Shit.”

That cut through the fog. Castorice didn’t swear usually.

“What happened?”

“Family emergency,” she blurted, already fumbling for her bag. “I gotta go.”

“Oh… hell,” Phainon muttered. “Yeah, go. It’s fine.”

She hovered, biting her lip, eyes darting between him and the door, clearly torn. Her face said she didn’t want to leave him here, but whatever was happening on her end sounded serious.

Phainon, still too drunk for subtlety but a decent enough person underneath it, patted her shoulder. “Cas. Go,” he said gently. “I’m a grown man. I can handle myself.”

She hesitated a second longer, then scanned the room—looking for something, or someone. And when her gaze finally snagged on a particular figure, Phainon followed it lazily, not immediately making the connection.

Tall. Good looking. Talking to someone.

Mydeimos.

And his stomach dropped like a stone.

“Oh, fuck me,” Phainon groaned, slouching lower in his chair, but it was too late. Castorice was already cutting a path through the crowd, zeroed in.

“Wait—waitwaitwait,” Phainon hissed, scrambling upright and nearly overbalancing in the process.

But there was no stopping her now.

He watched, stomach churning, as Castorice caught Mydei's attention with a polite tap to the arm. The look on Mydei's face shifted in an instant, from vague surprise to practiced neutrality. He glanced at her, likely expecting some routine, polite party small talk.

"I'm sorry," Castorice began, her voice urgent. "I—I need a favor."

Even from a distance, Phainon could see the flicker of confusion cross Mydei's face. He said something in return, but whatever it was, Castorice was already gesturing for him to step aside with her.

Phainon's skin prickled. He didn't have to hear the words to fill in the blanks.

He watched the exact moment she told him. Watched as Mydei's face slipped from polite indulgence to flat skepticism.

Then came the name. *Aglaea*.

Whatever Castorice said about her made Mydei hesitate, just for a fraction of a second. His jaw tightened. The polite mask slipped back into place, but there was a hardness to it now.

"Why would I?" Phainon could almost hear it from here.

A fair question.

And it might've ended there—should've, really—if not for the universe's reliably bad timing. A guest, some overly friendly party kid Phainon only vaguely remembered seeing earlier, sidled up beside him. Laid a hand on his arm and leaned in a little too close.

"Hey, cutie."

Phainon blinked, bleary and confused. He offered them a sunny smile. "Howdy," he drawled, because manners were manners.

He didn't catch Castorice's expression of horror, nor the near-imperceptible shift in the room's temperature.

But he felt it, a second later. He turned just in time to catch the darkening of Mydei's gaze, the flicker of something unreadable beneath it.

Castorice gestured subtly toward the scene, her expression desperate, a silent *see what I mean?*

Mydei sighed, long and bone-deep, the sound of a man whose night had just taken a nosedive.

"Fine," he muttered, already pulling his phone from his pocket. "What's his address?"

And just like that, it was done.

Phainon stared, dazed, as the pieces fell into place around him. He barely had time to register Castorice's quick approach, the press of her lips to his cheek.

"Good luck," she whispered, and then she was gone, disappearing toward the door without another word.

He watched her leave, some distant, disbelieving part of him still hoping this was a stress-induced hallucination. But when he turned, Mydei was already there, looming at his side like some elegantly dressed harbinger of doom.

Phainon groaned softly, dragging a hand down his face.

What a day.

And so it ended like this.

Phainon, too drunk to protest properly being half-dragged across the flagstone drive by none other than Mydeimos. The cool night air hit them like a slap. Somewhere down the street, the faint sounds of traffic murmured. A breeze tugged at the edges of Phainon's jacket, and he shivered, though not enough to regain full sense.

He followed.

Docilely.

Well—mostly.

“Mydei,” Phainon chirped after a moment, stumbling a half-step to the side. He caught himself against the shorter man’s shoulder. “If you’re kidnapping me, you better at least feed me something.”

Mydei’s jaw twitched, a muscle feathering tight along the side of his face. He let out a steady exhale through his nose as if calming himself. “It’s not a kidnapping,” he muttered, pulling his keys from his pocket with a flick of his wrist. “Shut up.”

Phainon snorted, one of those loose, breathy laughs that came from deep in his chest. “Coulda fooled me,” he said, grinning like a drunk idiot.

They made it about three more steps before a voice called out behind them.

“Hey—hold up!”

Phainon squinted over his shoulder. A tall figure jogged toward them, hair a little wind-tossed, face familiar in that vague way most party acquaintances were. Took Phainon a second to place him—the guy from earlier, with the little leather book.

The man reached them, slightly out of breath but still smiling like they were all old friends. “Hey. Can you drop me too? Perdikkas ditched me.”

Mydei turned, fixing him with a flat, unimpressed stare that could’ve soured milk. “No.”

The guy’s grin only widened. His gaze shifted to Phainon, visibly noting the half-collapsed state of him slumped against Mydei’s side.

“Oh hey,” the man greeted cheerfully. “You okay, man?”

Phainon beamed, his cheeks flushed a rosy pink and his eyes just a touch too glassy. “Never better,” he declared, sounding so chipper it might’ve

been believable if he hadn’t looked like someone midway through losing a drinking contest with gravity.

Mydei sighed, thoroughly exhausted.

He was just about to shut the whole thing down when Phainon leaned in again without warning, his nose brushing lightly against the side of Mydei’s neck. It was so casual, so absentminded, that for a second Mydei’s brain failed to compute what was happening.

“You smell good,” Phainon mumbled, voice low and entirely pleased, as if imparting a particularly valuable secret.

Mydei went stock-still.

The man standing in front of them blinked, then his face split into a delighted, shit-eating grin. “Oooooh,” he drawled, practically vibrating with amusement.

Mydei’s expression darkened. His glare alone could’ve taken down a small government.

“Out, Ptolemy,” he said, voice lethal.

Ptolemy threw up his hands in mock surrender, the picture of easy, unbothered energy. “Alright, alright—toodles!” He gave them both a lazy wink, spun on his heel, and strolled back toward the building without a care in the world.

Phainon sighed, still half-clinging to Mydei like an affectionate, slightly inebriated barn cat. There was a content little hum from his throat, his head lolling briefly against the man’s shoulder again like it was a perfectly acceptable place to take a nap.

Mydei stood there for a long, resigned moment, lips pressed into a line, before gently prying him off and steering them both toward the sleek black car idling at the curb. It was a gorgeous machine, all polished curves and

chrome, the kind of car that practically broadcast its sticker price without needing to.

Phainon blinked blearily at it, lips parting in appreciation. “Nice car,” he mumbled, half to himself.

“Get in.”

There wasn’t a trace of warmth in it.

“Okay,” Phainon agreed easily, reaching for the handle.

His balance betrayed him immediately. His fingers missed the door entirely and he swayed forward, almost faceplanting into the pavement.

Mydei caught him without looking, one hand closing around his arm with the reflexes of someone who’d spent far too long managing other people’s disasters.

“Jesus Christ,” he muttered, hauling him upright.

Phainon, rather than steadying himself, took the opportunity to latch on again, leaning against Mydei with a pleased little hum. His head tipped toward him, resting against his shoulder in a way that felt entirely unearned.

“You’re warm,” Phainon noted, as though it were a rare, fascinating discovery.

Mydei’s sigh was long, and somehow managed to convey both deep weariness and a distant sort of patience. The tips of his ears, however, betrayed him—flushed a shade darker than the rest of him, though he pretended not to notice.

“If you throw up in this car,” Mydei said darkly, fishing for the keys again, “I’m mailing you the cleaning bill.”

Phainon grinned, a lazy, sun-soaked thing. “You’d have to get my address for that.”

“Unfortunately,” Mydei muttered as he unlocked the car, “I have it.”

Getting Phainon into the passenger seat turned out to be a rodeo.

He wriggled, laughed, slipped half out of Mydei’s grip as the man tried to angle him inside without cracking his skull against the doorframe.

“Sit,” Mydei ground out, teeth clenched.

Phainon snorted, slumping into the seat sideways like somebody had removed all his bones. “Bossy.”

Buckling him in was worse.

Mydei leaned over, reaching for the seatbelt, and Phainon’s head immediately lolled against his shoulder, cheek pressing against the fabric of his suit with a content sigh.

“You smell nice,” Phainon mumbled.

Mydei’s breath caught. Barely a hitch, but there.

He didn’t answer. Just muttered something under his breath, wrestled Phainon upright, and reached for the buckle again.

“Sit still.”

“No.”

And then, for reasons known only to whatever stray impulse fired off in Phainon’s drunk brain, he grabbed at Mydei’s waist. Not hard. Just a rough tug, like pulling a cousin into a river.

Unfortunately for everyone, Mydei was not built for this.

He made a sharp, startled noise, braced a hand on the door, and half-fell forward, practically landing in Phainon’s lap.

“Are you—” Mydei started, disbelieving.

And before anything else could happen, Phainon's brain coughed up a singular thought, and with zero filter, he bit him.

Right where neck met collar. Not hard, just firm enough to be unmistakable.

Mydei recoiled like he'd been electrocuted.

"Did you just fucking *bite* me?!"

Phainon blinked up at him, glassy-eyed and pink-cheeked. "No."

Mydei's stare could've peeled paint. His hands flexed like he was weighing the pros and cons of homicide.

For one drawn-out second, Phainon was almost sure he was about to get left on the curb.

But instead, Mydei muttered something that sounded like a curse, buckled him in with short, clipped motions, and just as he clicked the buckle home —Phainon laid a hand over his.

Mydei went completely still.

"What," he said, low and dangerous.

Phainon squinted down at their hands. Mydei's was long-fingered, steady, strong. For some reason, it struck him.

"You've got nice hands," Phainon murmured, and this time it came out sincere.

Silence.

The air went strange. A beat too long.

Then Mydei made a noise in his throat—halfway between a scoff and a strangled laugh—yanked his hand back, and slammed the door shut hard enough to rattle the frame.

Phainon slumped sideways in the seat, humming to himself.

Nice car.

Nice hands.

Nice neck.

Weird night.

Phainon let his head rest against the window, cheek pressed to the cool glass. Outside, the city slipped by in blurs of sodium light, streetlamps streaking past like slow-moving stars. He watched them, unfocused, the steady rhythm of it pulling at something in the back of his mind.

“Y’know…” he said eventually. “you’re not bad company.”

Silence.

Not unexpected.

Mydei didn’t respond, eyes fixed on the road ahead.

Figures.

They drove like that for a while. The city easing by around them. Phainon counted traffic lights in his head—three green, two red, one yellow. Pointless, but it kept his hands still.

After a while, he sighed, shifting in his seat. “No talking, huh?”

Nothing.

“Right.” Phainon straightened a little, wincing as the car hit a shallow pothole. “Fine. I’ll talk.”

And without waiting for permission, he did.

“I got three older cousins,” he began. “Bunch of stubborn idiots. Used to run around raising hell back home. Haven’t seen ‘em in a couple years. Miss them sometimes, though I’d probably punch them if I did.”

He risked a glance at Mydei. Nothing.

Unfazed, Phainon kept going. “My dad’s got hands like catcher’s mitts. Worked his whole life, tough as hell. But he’s soft, underneath. Pretends he’s not, but you can tell. And my mom’s sharp. Real sharp. She’s got this way of smiling at you until you realize you’re wrong about whatever dumb thing you thought you knew. Doesn’t even have to say anything. It’s kind of terrifying.”

The faintest snort, so quiet it barely registered.

But it was there.

Phainon beamed to himself. “See? Got a reaction.”

Mydei didn’t look over, but there was the barest flicker at the corner of his mouth. “Don’t get ahead of yourself,” he muttered.

Phainon hummed, leaning his head back against the seat. He was quiet for a moment, then added, “Could tell you about my first week here.”

This time, a slight tilt of Mydei’s head. Subtle. But present.

Phainon took it as permission. “Got lost in the L station trying to switch trains. Swore I was gonna end up in Milwaukee. Called my mom half in tears ‘cause I got stuck in this weird underground mall. Couldn’t find an exit for, like, an hour and a half. Bought four packs of discount socks just to feel like I accomplished something.”

A long beat.

And then—the faintest exhale. Barely a sound, but it was closer to a laugh than anything else.

Phainon turned his head, smiling. “Rude.”

“Don’t bite me again and maybe I’ll be nicer.”

Phainon chuckled before turning just enough to watch Mydei. “You probably already know my family owns a farm.”

A noncommittal sound from the driver’s side.

“It’s nice, most of the time. Good to help out, keep your hands busy. But when I didn’t wanna be bothered, I’d head out into the wheat fields. Just lay there, staring up at the sky. Could lose whole afternoons like that.”

His voice had settled, softer now.

A small, almost absent smile tugged at his mouth. “Course, Snowy always found me, no matter how quiet I was. Oh, that’s our fluffy white puppy. He’s always got a smile on his face, like this!”

Phainon tilted his head slightly, mimicking it—eyes bright, mouth crooked in a loose, open smile that caught in the dashboard light.

And something in Mydei’s chest went tight.

He gripped the wheel a little harder, jaw flexing as he pulled his gaze hard back to the road.

“Don’t do that,” he muttered.

Phainon blinked. “Do what?”

“Nothing.”

A soft laugh. Phainon let his head fall back against the headrest.

“Snowy’s a good dog,” he murmured.

Mydei said nothing.

After a while, without looking over, he spoke.

“Cyrene’d probably like you.”

Mydei’s brow edged up, a flick of curiosity in his voice. “Who’s that?”

“My best friend,” Phainon said, a fondness threading through the words. “We grew up together. She’s smart as hell, real good at reading people. Nicest person I’ve ever met also.”

There was an easy warmth in the way he said it, like the thought alone steadied something in him.

“She’s the reason I never took up boxing, actually,” Phainon added, glancing over. “I thought about joining this local club back home—figured it’d toughen me up, keep me out of trouble. But then Cyrene needed help with school, and math was always my thing. So, tutoring it was.”

He shrugged, like it wasn’t a story worth much, though his voice softened at the edges. “Guess I figured if one of us had a shot at getting out of there, it oughta count.”

Mydei’s hand flexed lightly on the wheel. He didn’t look over, but his voice cut through the quiet.

“I could teach you.”

Phainon blinked, sitting up a bit. “What, boxing?”

“I said what I said.”

A slow, amused grin spread across Phainon’s face. “Yeah? You any good?”

“You couldn’t keep up.”

That pulled a real laugh from Phainon, easy and bright in the dark. “Bet I could. Might surprise you.”

For the first time all night, the faintest smirk tugged at Mydei’s mouth, sharp and involuntary. “I’ll give you my number when I drop you off. Set a date.”

Phainon let out a soft, pleased whoop. “Look at that. We’re basically friends now.”

“Let’s not get ahead of ourselves.”

But the tease in Mydei’s voice undercut the words, a note lighter than before.

He was about to continue but then—casual but curious, “What about you? Got family?”

Mydei hesitated, his jaw working for a moment like he wasn’t sure if he’d answer.

Eventually, he did. “My mother. Taught me how to cook.”

Phainon perked up a little, turning toward him. “Yeah? Are you any good?”

“I am.”

“Damn,” Phainon whistled. “I only know how to keep myself alive. Scrambled eggs, boxed pasta. That’s about it. Bet it’s nice, knowing how to actually put a real meal together.”

Mydei’s gaze stayed forward, but his voice softened, almost despite himself. “I could show you sometime.”

Phainon blinked, a small, surprised smile creeping in. “Man,” he said, shaking his head with amusement, “you’re just full of surprises tonight.”

Mydei slightly chuckled that. The city slid past them in long, quiet streaks of light.

And for the first time all night, the silence between them felt easy.

At some point, Phainon went quiet. His head rested against the window, eyes half-lidded as the city slipped by in smudged streaks of color. Everything felt softened at the edges—the warmth of the car, the hush of

the road, the way the world outside blurred like an old lullaby you could almost remember.

Then—the car slowed, the engine easing into a low idle before cutting off with a quiet shudder.

A soft metallic click as the keys turned.

“We’re here.”

Phainon blinked, the sound tugging him from the comfortable fog. He lifted his head, squinting out at the familiar sprawl of the apartment complex lit by buzzing porch lamps. “Already?” He rubbed at his face. “Man, you drive fast.”

“I drive like a sane person,” Mydei muttered. “You just wouldn’t shut up.”

Phainon snorted, a rough laugh catching in his throat. “Touché.”

Mydei reached out, palm open. “Phone.”

Phainon blinked at him, sluggish. “What?”

“Your phone,” Mydei repeated, the kind of patience usually reserved for dealing with confused pets and small children.

Still a little slow on the uptake, Phainon fished the device from his pocket and handed it over. Mydei unlocked it with a few deft taps, scrolling through something.

It took a second, but then Phainon squinted. “Wait—hang on. What’re you doing?”

Mydei shot him a flat, unimpressed look. “Relax.”

A few seconds later, he passed it back. “There.”

Phainon glanced down. A new contact. Just *Mydei*, clean and unembellished. His stomach gave a ridiculous, unhelpful flip at the sight of

it.

“Oh,” he said, playing it off with a half-smile. “Yeah… yeah, cool.”

Mydei leaned back against the headrest, one hand scrubbing over his face, the faintest trace of a laugh in his exhale. “You owe me one.”

Phainon grinned, leaning an elbow on the door. “What, you want a goodnight kiss or something?”

The effect was immediate. Mydei’s eyes widened like he’d just been blindsided by a glass door, and for a heartbeat he seemed to short-circuit. “You—” he started, then cut himself off with a sharp breath, shaking his head. “You’re an idiot.”

A beat passed.

Then, a little quieter, not quite grudging, “You want me to walk you up?”

Phainon snorted, unbuckling his seatbelt with a soft click. “I’m six-one, man. Nobody’s messing with me.”

He paused, thoughtful. “Well… maybe Lygus. He’s weird.”

Mydei frowned. “Who the hell is Lygus?”

“Neighbor. Guy stares at me every time I leave my place, but I swear I’ve never actually seen him *in* the building.” Phainon shrugged like it wasn’t worth worrying about, though the corner of Mydei’s eye twitched.

Before he could say whatever cutting remark was already loaded in his brain, Phainon cracked the door open. Cool night air spilled into the car, brushing against warm skin and the scent of leather seats. He lingered a second, half-turning.

“Hey,” he said, voice softer now. “Thanks for the ride.”

There was something in the way he said it—a note of quiet sincerity that caught Mydei a little off guard. His shoulders stiffened before he could help

it.

Phainon either didn’t notice or chose not to, slipping out of the car with a thud of the door. The gravel lot crunched under his boots as he headed for the stairwell, keys jingling faintly in his hand.

At the door, he fumbled with the lock for a moment before glancing back.

The car was still there. Headlights on, engine idling, Mydei’s silhouette faintly visible behind the wheel.

Waiting.

Phainon’s chest went a little warm. He huffed a soft, crooked smile to himself and finally slipped inside.

Chapter End Notes

> God idk how I feel about this chapter. It doesn’t really fit my expectations in terms of pacing and comedy, but honestly my head hurts too much to edit it and it’s late so I’m going to sleep, toodles and thanks for reading😭
>
> Edit: Though before that, I’m having issues deciding whether I want an early or late reveal. Would you guys prefer a reveal in say, chapter 6 as opposed to 8 or vise versa? I’ve been stuck on that part and lowkey I’m just gonna go with what u guys say

Chapter 5: I Skipped Work for This (And I'd Do It Again)

Chapter Summary

> Phainon takes time off work, gets punched (romantically), eats a lunch he didn't pack, almost decides to kiss a man before getting interrupted, and ends the day narrowly avoiding unemployment via divine CEO intervention. Ice cream is acquired. Feelings are caught. Caenis leaves spiritually bruised.

Chapter Notes

> Late again sorry :')

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was, by all accounts, a beautiful morning in Chicago.

That rare kind of bright that made even the L look gentler than usual. Sunlight spilled in through the windows, laying long slats across rumpled suits, scuffed sneakers, the glossy edge of a thermos tucked into someone's side pocket. The train hummed steady beneath it all, wheels grinding along the curve of the track.

The car smelled like coffee and warm metal. Someone behind him was eating dry cereal out of a plastic container. There was a faint beat leaking from a teenager's headphones a few seats down, something tinny and fast. It was quiet otherwise—weekday quiet, tired quiet. The kind of calm that only really existed between rush hours.

And it would've been perfect. A normal Tuesday, even.

Except, of course, for Phainon.

He sat hunched near the back of the car, legs crossed, elbows resting on his knee, one hand gripping the strap of his old gym bag like it might try and

run off if he let go. The canvas had long since lost whatever structure it used to have—slumped now between his boots, frayed at the zipper, stained at the corners. His hoodie was zipped halfway, sleeves pushed to the elbows. A soft navy blue, or used to be. There was a splotch of faded bleach right over the stomach, round and blotchy like a sad little ghost.

He looked fine. Like any other guy on his way to the gym. Normal.

Except his phone screen had just lit up for the fifth time in three minutes. 10:07 AM.

He locked it. Unlocked it. Still 10:07.

He sighed. Pinched the bridge of his nose.

“Lord,” he murmured to himself, not quite under his breath.

He’d been holding it together all morning—barely, but still. Playing it cool. Doing his best to pretend this was just a regular day. Because technically, it was. Technically.

But Phainon had a problem. And it wasn’t one of those little ones, like rent being late or his water pressure being weak. No, this one was personal. Embarrassing, even. Possibly criminal, depending how you looked at it.

Because recently—very recently—he had bitten someone.

Bitten. Like full teeth. Like a drunk raccoon.

And not just anyone, either.

No. He’d bitten Mydei.

Phainon groaned quietly and dropped his head into the crook of his elbow. Stayed there, breathing against the fabric of his sleeve, stewing in his shame.

Mydei, with the marble face and voice like a locked door. Mydei, who smelled like dry cedar and pomegranate and always looked like he’d

stepped out of a magazine called “I’m Better Than You.” Mydei, who, by some miracle of the divine, hadn’t ghosted him entirely. Or sued. Or called animal control.

“Did I actually—?” Phainon whispered, eyes fixed on the grimy floor. “No. Nooo.”

But the memory was there. Clear as day.

“He let me?” He frowned. “He didn’t stop me?”

A pause.

“Lord above, I’m a feral dog.”

The man sitting next to him adjusted his briefcase and leaned slightly to the side.

Phainon didn’t notice. Or didn’t care.

“If my mama were here,” he muttered, low and distant, “she’d whoop me back to last Sunday and call the church to get me re-baptized.”

He ran a hand down his face. Slumped even further down the seat, spine curved like a melting popsicle stick.

Another sigh.

Because really, what was he supposed to think? He hadn’t seen Mydei since that night—hadn’t even heard his voice. Just silence. And in that silence, Phainon had gone through every possible emotional reaction a man could fit into a two-day period. Regret. Horror. Denial. Grief. Hope. And now, this. The anxious purgatory of not knowing what the hell came next.

He didn’t think Mydei was the forgiving type. Didn’t strike him as someone who let things slide. Especially not accidental bite marks.

But then.

There’d been a text.

[Tomorrow. 10AM. Wear proper gear.]

That was it.

Phainon had stared at it for a long time. Double-checked the contact. Read it three more times just to be sure it wasn’t some weird dream artifact his brain had cooked up to make him feel worse.

But it had been real. Still was. Sitting there on his lockscreen, plain as day.

And now, here he was. On the train. On the way.

To meet the guy he’d bitten. To box. Probably.

He wasn’t even sure if it was a setup. Maybe Mydei was just luring him into some private ring so he could get even. Or maybe—worse—he was serious. About the boxing lesson. About the promise he’d made that night. The one Phainon could barely remember between all the noise and the way he’d pressed his cheek against Mydei’s shoulder like a fool.

“He’s really gonna teach me?” he mumbled now, dazed. “Off a promise to a drunken guy?”

Then, quieter.

“Nah. But then again…”

He glanced down at the screen. At the text.

“…He texted me.”

And yeah. There it was. That dumb flutter in his chest again. That spark of something he didn’t wanna name. Something warm. Bright. A little shy.

He sat up a little straighter before he could stop himself. Then immediately caught his own reflection in the window and forced his shoulders back down.

He didn’t like the guy. Not really. Not like that. Mostly. But maybe, deep down, he wanted to be liked. And to like him too. Just a little. Just enough.

Not that it mattered. He’d keep it normal. Keep it cool. No touching. No biting. No nothing.

Just two guys. Boxing. Sweatin’. Making physical contact in a closed, humid space.

He paused. Closed his eyes.

“Just a normal boxing lesson,” he muttered. “Totally not weird.”

A second later—

“…Real tight. Real close—alright cowboy, let’s not pass out on public transit.”

He gave the side of his head a firm little nudge against the window. Cold glass. Metal rattle. A deep, full breath.

Outside, the skyline dipped as the train curved north.

And Phainon couldn’t wait for his stop.

By the time Phainon stepped off the train, the morning had grown into itself—full and golden, just shy of noon heat. Sunlight bounced off windshields and glass windows, and the sidewalk shimmered faintly with that almost-summer glow.

He tugged his gym bag higher on his shoulder, adjusted the strap twice, and stood still for a moment on the corner. Let the day settle around him.

The gym was only a few blocks out, and he’d left early on purpose—half out of nerves, half out of that irritatingly earnest impulse to never be late, especially when someone was doing him a favor. So he strolled. Humming something tuneless under his breath, just enough to keep himself from overthinking again.

The neighborhood was nice. Fancy in a not-unpleasant way. Modest brownstones pressed shoulder to shoulder with minimalist storefronts, their windows displaying candles and tiny succulents in handmade clay pots.

Phainon passed a juice bar with its menu scrawled in pastel cursive on the window: *7-Day Cellular Reset*. He gave it a once-over. Beside it, a café had half a dozen tiny tables lined up along the curb, each one perfectly spaced and cutesy. A green smoothie sat sweating on the farthest edge—abandoned or forgotten, hard to say.

He slowed as he passed it, squinting into the cup.

"…Is it still a smoothie if it's got kale in it?" he asked quietly, side-eying it.

Half a block later, he stopped again—this time beside another storefront with shelves stacked full of tiny succulents in ceramic pots the size of shot glasses. One had a handwritten tag looped around the base: *$34.*

"Y'all are outta your minds," he murmured, not unkindly, and moved on.

Every block had something else to look at, like a boutique with pyramid displays of hand-poured candles or a bookstore that only sold zines and hand-stitched journals. Phainon didn't try to catalog it all. He just let it wash over him, steady and strange in its own beautiful way.

Phainon pulled out his phone again just to double-check the number. He glanced around, frowning faintly, not seeing anything that screamed *gym*. He took another few steps, peering up at the signage.

Then he spotted it.

Tucked snugly between a sleek vegan café and a co-working space that looked like it came with its own NFT consultant, was a set of understated frosted glass doors with no sign above them. Only a small plaque beside the handle read:

MEMBERS ONLY.

Phainon came to a full stop, tilted his head.

Let out a low whistle. “Well,” he said, under his breath, “this ain’t no Planet Fitness.”

The doors didn’t budge. No bell. No buzz. He shifted his bag, thumbed the edge of his hoodie sleeve. Stared at the glass like it might blink first.

Then, steadying himself, he rolled his shoulders back.

And reached for the handle.

The moment Phainon stepped inside, the noise of the street folded neatly behind him like someone had closed a book. The lobby smelled faintly of eucalyptus and something even softer under it—linen, maybe. Whatever it was, it had clearly been picked out of a catalog with names like *Awaken* or *Serenity.*

The lighting was low and warm, diffused across pale oak floors and sleek metal trim. No front-facing dumbbells or treadmill lineups were in sight. Just clean open space, high ceilings, and a few leather benches arranged meticulously. Across from them, a pane of glass revealed a studio where a man in athletic shorts was stretching deep into a split.

Phainon blinked. Then politely looked away.

At the front desk, a woman scrolled through a tablet with one manicured finger. Her blonde hair was clipped up behind her head, and a pair of thin reading glasses sat perched in her hair like a decoration. She looked up just long enough to let him know she’d seen him.

“Hey, uh—morning,” Phainon said, his voice polite. “I think I’m on the list? I’ve got a session. Someone’s supposed to be showin’ me around.”

Her eyes flicked back down to the tablet, scrolling with quiet confidence. “You’re here for a private?”

“Yess’m,” he said automatically, then caught himself. “Yeah. Private. Name’s Phainon. P-H-A—I mean. I’m with Mydeimos.”

That seemed to help. She tapped once, then nodded without looking up. “He’s in Studio Three.”

Phainon gave a quick smile, then paused mid-step when she didn’t elaborate. He hovered awkwardly for half a second before she added, calm as anything, “Down the hallway to your right. You’ll need the code he sent. Studio doors don’t open without it.”

“Oh. Right. Yeah. Got it.” He dug his phone out again. The text was still there, tucked between two weather alerts and a work reminder he’d ignored this morning:

[Use this to get in.]

Then a random string of numbers.

“Appreciate it,” he said as he moved past the desk, thumb already hovering over his screen.

Beyond the lobby, the hallway stretched out clean and hushed. He only heard the muffled sounds drifting from behind closed doors—sharp exhalations, the steady pop of padwork, and the hiss of someone counting in sets of four.

He passed a vending wall stocked with pre-chilled eucalyptus towels and vacuum-sealed protein bars labeled *nootropic-enhanced*. One of the protein drinks had a name he couldn’t pronounce. Another had no name at all—just a logo shaped like a water droplet trapped in a triangle.

He gave it a vaguely respectful nod and kept walking.

A man came around the corner wearing a fitted set of matching slate-gray gear, everything tone-matched from shirt to shoes. His eyes scanned Phainon briefly—hoodie, frayed sleeve, gym bag slung low. Then lower, down to his boots.

Phainon didn’t break stride.

But as he passed, he murmured without turning, “You got a retail tag hanging off your sleeve, brother.”

The man faltered mid-step behind him. Phainon kept walking, the corner of his mouth twitching once, then smoothing again.

He tapped his fingers lightly against his thigh, scanning the hallway.

“Studio Three…” he said under his breath, half to himself.

Studio One came first. Then Studio Two—door closed, a faint rhythmic thump behind it. And just past it, tucked to the right in a corner that might’ve been missed if you weren’t looking, sat a door marked with a simple, elegant plaque:

STUDIO 3

The same muted tones and a soft black keypad mounted to the wall beside it, waiting.

Phainon exhaled, pulled up the text again, and carefully tapped in the numbers.

3-3-5-0-0-3-3-6.

The keypad beeped. A small green light blinked once. The lock gave a soft mechanical click.

He stood there for a second longer, hand still resting against the handle. His shoulders had crept up again without asking, half-tense like he didn’t know if he was about to enter a sparring ring or an interview.

He rolled his neck once. Flexed his hand around the strap of his bag.

Then he pushed the door open and stepped inside.

The door clicked shut behind Phainon, sealing the studio into quiet.

The air inside was calmer somehow, padded floors dulling each step, the walls insulated just enough to hush the distant rhythm of the rest of the gym. He moved in slowly, taking in the room—mirrored panels lining one side, a rack of gear stacked neatly in the corner, and the soft ambient thud of someone hitting pads two rooms over.

Near the far wall, seated on a low bench and lacing up his shoes, was Mydei.

He was bent forward, sleeves cut high, the matte wraps already on his hands. The compression tank clung to him in a way that made it impossible not to notice how compact he was—muscle over lines, frame efficient without being bulky. The red ink on his forearm caught the overhead lights, sharpened into crisp brushstroke arcs that looked almost ceremonial in this lighting.

Phainon blinked. Then again.

And then smiled like someone who'd just found something rare on a high shelf.

"Well, damn," he called out lightly. "Don't you look good."

Mydei didn't glance up. "You're late."

Phainon stepped fully in. "I'm three minutes early."

"You should've been five."

"Alright then, Captain Punctual," he muttered, setting his bag by the wall.

That earned him a glance—a brow raised like Phainon had just asked if stretching was optional. Then, without a word, Mydei picked up a pair of gloves from beside him and lobbed them across the room.

They hit Phainon's chest with a soft thump. He caught them a beat later.

"Boot camp rules already?" he said, adjusting his grip.

“No talking. Wrap up.”

Phainon lifted one glove and held it between two fingers. “Over or under?”

Mydei sighed. He stood and crossed the mat in three steps, stopping in front of him like he’d decided doing it himself was faster than explaining.

“Hold still,” he said, pulling a wrap loose from the roll.

“I *am* holding still,” Phainon replied, eyes amused. “I’m being a model of pliability.”

“You’re still talking.”

“Now that’s just unfair.”

The wrap slid across Phainon’s knuckles, pulled snug with an even pressure that spoke of repetition. The fabric whispered with each pass—over the knuckles, across the palm, back again.

Phainon watched his hands more than the wrap itself.

“You always do this for your clients?” Phainon asked, voice light, but curious. “Wrap them up yourself, all gentle-like?”

Mydei’s glance was brief. “Only the ones who can’t follow directions.”

“Lucky me,” Phainon said, not bothering to hide the smile.

He looked down again, watching as Mydei guided the wrap across his hand.

“You always this good with your hands?” Phainon asked quieter.

Mydei didn’t look up. But the corners of his mouth twitched. “You’re not the first person to ask me that.”

Phainon huffed a laugh. “Guess I walked right into that one.”

“You think?”

He finished the final loop and tucked the edge into place, thumb pressing it down smooth. Then he stepped back—not far, but enough to give Phainon space to flex his fingers.

“There,” Mydei said. “Passable.”

Phainon held one hand up, admiring it like he was judging craftmanship. “You always tie up your enemies this gentle?”

“I thought we weren’t enemies anymore.”

That made him pause, just a fraction too long.

“…We’re not,” Phainon said, and it came out softer than he meant it.

So he added, quickly, “But I’m still suspicious. You look like a man who owns at least one decorative sword.”

Mydei blinked once. “Only one?”

“See? That’s exactly what I mean. That’s a red flag.”

Mydei tilted his head, nodding toward the mat. “Then by all means. Punch it out of me.”

Phainon gave a short laugh and moved to the center. “You sure you’re ready for that?”

“I was born ready.”

“Of course, angel.”

“I don’t hear you denying it.”

Phainon bounced lightly on the tip of his feet, rolling one shoulder back, grin starting to creep. “You like a challenge, huh?”

“I like shutting people up.”

“Oh honey,” Phainon drawled, hands lifting. “You really don’t wanna open that door.”

And this time, Mydei smiled.

Just enough.

Mydei tipped his chin toward the heavy bag, arms crossed. “Let’s see what you’ve got.”

Phainon exhaled, rolling out his shoulders like that might somehow shake the nerves loose. “You’re not gonna be impressed, city boy.”

“I don’t impress easy.”

Then, after a beat—almost offhand:

“But I’m watching.”

And Phainon really wished he hadn’t said it like that.

To be fair, Phainon hadn’t expected to be great.

He wasn’t waiting for a movie moment. No underdog montage, no sudden unlock of hidden muscle memory. He knew he was rusty—okay, maybe worse than rusty. His fists had weight but no discipline. Like someone handed a sledgehammer to a kid and said go nuts.

Still, he hadn’t thought he was this bad.

“Too much shoulder,” Mydei said again, voice calm and frustratingly consistent. “You’re loading your whole upper body before the punch. That’s a tell.”

Phainon grunted, shoulders rising and falling with uneven breath. “You could just say I suck.”

“You suck.”

Phainon snorted. “God, finally. Affirmation.”

The last half hour had been a blur of warm-up drills, footwork, and corrections. They’d skipped past anything flashy—Mydei had insisted on basics: stance, breath, movement. And when Phainon fumbled, which he had, repeatedly, Mydei didn’t scold—he simply noted. Adjusted. Watched.

“Your stance is too wide again,” Mydei added. “You’re losing power in the follow-through.”

Phainon shifted, dragging his foot in without much grace. “Guess muscle memory don’t count for much when all the muscle’s in the wrong place.”

“You’ve got power,” Mydei said, stepping forward. “But power without control gets you winded and hit.”

He crouched slightly and rapped two knuckles lightly against Phainon’s back foot. “Bring this in. You want tension through the hips, not your knees.”

Phainon did as told, watching him. “How do you even know all this?”

“I told you I trained,” Mydei replied. “And I read.”

“Of course you do,” Phainon muttered, shifting his balance as Mydei hovered close again.

“Ball of your foot. Push from the ground. Tight core, loose shoulders.” He spoke as he moved—light contact here and there to guide alignment. A tap to Phainon’s hip. A brush behind his elbow. “Throw a jab, slow.”

Phainon tried—right form, wrong rhythm.

“Breathe out on impact,” Mydei said. “You’ll gas out otherwise.”

Phainon tried again, exhaling on the punch this time. It felt weird. But Mydei watched, quiet, arms crossed.

“Again.”

He did it again.

And again.

And then once more.

After the fourth repetition, Mydei nodded. “That’s the start of a good habit.”

Phainon swiped his forearm across his brow. “You’re actually pretty patient. Beginners always get this treatment?”

“No.”

That caught him off guard—enough to glance over.

“You’re listening,” Mydei said, like it was an explanation and a surprise all at once.

“I mean… yeah,” Phainon said. “You didn’t have to do this. Most people don’t help unless they’re getting something back.” He shrugged, then winced at the pull on his shoulder. “So. Y’know. I appreciate it.”

And besides, when else was someone like him gonna get a one-on-one boxing lesson from someone who actually knows what they’re doing?

Mydei stilled slightly.

Something flickered across his face subtly—like the sincerity had caught him off guard.

He looked away, hand flexing once where it rested on his arm. “You’re sweating on my floor,” he said flatly. “Try not to make a puddle.”

Phainon smiled, shoulders easing back into his usual rhythm. “Awww, so you’re the type to get all soft when people say thank you.”

“I get irritated when they stop punching.”

“That so?” Phainon flexed his fingers, settling back into stance. “You ready for me to knock the bag off the chain?”

“You’re still leading with your shoulder,” Mydei said without missing a beat.

Phainon groaned. “You’re relentless.”

“I’m efficient.”

“Same thing.”

He lined up for another set—form tighter now, breath steadier. Mydei stood a few paces off, arms folded again, watching like a quiet metronome.

Jab.

Cross.

Jab. Step.

Cross. Reset.

Each hit sounded cleaner now. Less splash, more snap. He was trying his best to apply Mydei’s instructions into it.

And after a string of half-decent hits, he heard it:

“Better.”

Just that.

Phainon almost ruined the next punch out of pure surprise.

He straightened slowly, sweat glinting off his jaw, then glanced over. “So,” he said, trying to play it casual. “We moving on to the pads, coach?”

Mydei’s gaze flicked toward the wall where the mitts hung. A slow nod.

“If you think you’re ready.”

Phainon smirked. “Only one way to find out.”

The pads hit back.

Not literally, but Mydei could feel every blow thunder through his forearms. Phainon wasn’t polished—not by a long shot—but there was force behind every strike. Enough to jolt his elbows and pull a wince out of him when a hook slipped too far inside.

Mydei winced as the angle jarred his wrist. “Jesus. You trying to crack bone?”

Phainon laughed. “Where were you when I was breaking noses at thirteen?”

“Hopefully nowhere near Missouri.”

“‘Bout three hours south of St. Louis, actually,” Phainon fired back, curls sweat-damp and clinging to his forehead. His collar was stretched, shirt plastered to his back, and still he stayed light on his feet, bouncing in rhythm. No real finesse yet, but there was something laser-focused in his eyes. He was listening. Trying.

Mydei raised the left mitt, angled off-center. “Jab. Let it land before the cross. Don’t rush.”

Phainon obeyed without comment, landing a fast, precise punch.

Another. Then a cross. He missed the alignment and rotated off-balance.

“Again,” Mydei said. “Tighter core this time. You’re twisting from your waist.”

Phainon nodded once, shook out his arms, and tried again.

Better. Still clumsy, but centered now.

“Where’d you learn this anyway?” Mydei asked, adjusting his footing to shift the pad angle for a lead hook.

“Hm?” Phainon didn’t quite catch it, shoulders still working. He threw another combo before registering the question. “Oh. Myself, I guess. I wouldn’t call it *learning*. More like… had to.”

Mydei didn’t push, just gave a nod and repositioned his stance. “Someone picked on you?”

Phainon’s next hit struck clean. He reset, then shrugged with one shoulder as he circled around. “Not me. I mean, look at me.” He paused long enough to adjust his footing before adding, “It was Cyrene. Real small, scrappy thing. Smart. Got picked on for it. I got tired of watching it happen, so I started getting in the way.”

Mydei paused. Blinked.

“You started boxing to take hits for someone else.”

Phainon grinned. “More or less.”

“…So you’re a brawler.”

“Born and raised.”

Mydei shook his head, muttering something under his breath that might’ve been *unbelievable*. Still, he lifted the mitts again, a new glint in his eye. “Alright, brawler. Try this—one-two-slip-hook. And keep your damn chin tucked.”

Phainon gave a sharp nod, lips pressed tight in focus.

Mydei adjusted the mitts higher, watching him carefully.

“You’ve got power,” he said at last. “But you can’t just throw punches and hope they land. That hook earlier nearly over-rotated your front knee. If I were an opponent and not holding mitts—”

“You’d be on the floor?” Phainon teased, ducking under the pads with a quick slip.

Then he quickly added, “What about you? What got you into boxing?”

The question came just as he pivoted and faked low. Mydei’s stance was mid-shift when Phainon ducked inside with a soft laugh and clipped the edge of the mitt—

The angle hit just right. Mydei stumbled. Only a half step, but it was enough.

Phainon’s face lit up like Christmas in July. *“Yes.”*

Mydei blinked, stunned. “…You little sh—”

He cut himself off, closed his eyes, and exhaled through his nose like a man choosing peace.

“Don’t gloat.”

“Who’s gloating?” Phainon beamed, extending a hand, cocky as hell. “C’mon, you didn’t answer me.”

Mydei glanced down at the offered hand like it was bait—then took it anyway, grip firm and warm even as he grumbled under his breath.

“My parents hired a trainer,” he admitted. “Wanted me to be able to defend myself. In case something… ever came up.”

Phainon hummed as he helped him up, stepping back again as Mydei reset. “Smart. Big city like this… I’d imagine there’s a lotta folks who think they’ve got the right to get their hands on someone else.”

He said it lightly—but the words turned over in his mouth afterward, just a little heavier.

His eyes flicked toward Mydei. Watched the way his shoulders rolled back into stance.

Something in Phainon clenched—sour and unfamiliar at the sudden thought of Mydei getting hurt.

He looked away.

“So…” he drawled, “no praise for flooring your coach?”

“You *cheated*,” Mydei said flatly, still adjusting the mitts. “Absolutely not.”

“Excuses, excuses,” Phainon sang.

Mydei gave him a look. The kind of long, soul-deep stare that could flatten a less shameless man. It only made Phainon smile harder.

“You’re impossible.”

“And yet,” Phainon said brightly, “here you are.”

Mydei didn’t dignify that with a reply.

But as he lowered the mitts, Phainon caught it. Barely.

His lips pressed together in what was definitely *meant* to be irritation—except it crept just a little too close to a pout. The kind you’d never catch him admitting to, not even under oath.

Cute.

He’d never admit it—not in this life, or the next—but Phainon was absolutely going to remember that look. And chase it again.

Mydei stepped closer, close enough that Phainon felt it first in the shift of the air between them. His stance barely changed, but it still managed to feel like a push.

“Keep your guard up,” Mydei said. “I’m testing your shell—if I get in clean, that’s a point lost.”

Phainon nodded, adjusting without thinking. He pulled his gloves in tighter, forearms tucked in, elbows angled down. “You mean like this?”

“Almost,” Mydei said. Then, “Not quite.”

He stepped in with purpose, and they moved together—Mydei subtly guiding him with one hand at the small of his back until Phainon’s shoulders adjusted. The tension along the line made his spine straighten on instinct.

Tap. Tap.

Left rib, right rib.

Phainon twitched both times.

“Too stiff,” Mydei said. “Too reactive. Settle into it.”

“Easy for you to say,” Phainon muttered, shifting his weight. “Isn’t your sides getting flicked like that.”

“Don’t flinch.”

And then Mydei didn’t wait—he just reached out, took Phainon’s glove by the wrist, and shifted it across his torso.

It was all instructional. Just one guy correcting another guy’s form.

But they were chest-to-chest now. And when Mydei adjusted his footing to square them up, his thigh bumped lightly against Phainon’s knee, his hand sliding down from glove to forearm effortlessly.

“You’re tense,” Mydei said, glancing down, then up. “Relax your back foot. Rotate from the core.”

“Sure,” Phainon said, though his voice came out thinner than he meant. “Real relaxed here.”

He didn’t know what registered first—the heat of Mydei’s palm at his side, or the way Mydei braced one arm just above his shoulder, pressing in close without crowding. A fraction too near.

And Phainon, loud as he was, didn’t move.

Because Mydei hadn’t asked.

Then the hand at his hip shifted again. Thumb to waistband. A soft pressure.

Adjusting stance, yeah. Just more form-checking. That’s all.

But—

Right there.

A curve of muscle through his shirt. The sharp line of a collarbone, faint but obvious where the collar dipped wide. Not overly bulked out, but carved in.

And strong.

Really strong.

Phainon blinked hard. *What the—?*

That shouldn’t be catching his eye. That shouldn’t even be on the radar. He wasn’t—

No. Nope.

This was not the time to suddenly realize that Mydei—sugary coffee drinker, probably never touched a tractor in his life—was, objectively, more than capable of manhandling a guy like Phainon into proper form.

Which he was currently doing.

Casually.

With one hand.

How in the *hell* was that allowed?

Phainon could take a hit. He'd scrapped behind bleachers and rolled down hills and hauled livestock with a bum wrist. He was solid—nobody moved him unless he let them.

And yet here he was. Being shifted. Guided. Set like a damn prop.

And he *felt* it.

Felt it in the buzz under his ribs, in the brief flex at his core when Mydei's hand skimmed down to correct his hip angle again. Felt it in the quiet voice in the back of his head whispering something ridiculous like: *okay, cool, yeah, maybe you're into this now, congrats.*

Internally: blank panic.

Externally: still.

Too still.

Mydei said something—probably another cue about stance—but it passed through Phainon's brain like water through a sieve.

Since when do people born in a skyline end up this built? This steady?

He'd figured Mydei for the sharp-tongued type—quick with a jab, but more bark than brawn. The kind of guy who leaned on attitude, not muscle. Not someone who could square up and make it stick.

It didn't add up.

And yet, here they were. Him, pinned by eye contact and a single hand on his hip. Mydei, cool as ever, still adjusting his posture like this wasn't illegal levels of close.

Okay, Phainon thought, mouth dry. *Okay cool great awesome I think I just developed a kink. Excellent. Love that for me.*

He went a little red.

Then very red.

Then snapped upright so fast he nearly clocked Mydei with his own glove.

“So!” he chirped, far too brightly. “How’m I doing now, coach? Still pivoting like a deer on moonshine, or am I up to a mildly sober elk?”

He facepalmed internally. *How’m? Sober elk???*

Mydei, halfway through re-strapping the mitts, paused.

He looked up.

“…Are you okay?”

“Peachy.” Phainon nodded fast. Too fast. “Better than peachy. Plum good, even.”

Mydei squinted. “Did you hit your head.”

“Not that I noticed. Unless this is one of those shady tactics where you elbowed me when I wasn’t looking.”

“I would’ve aimed higher.”

“See? Shady.”

A long, flat stare.

Phainon grinned, all teeth.

“Alright,” Mydei muttered. “Get back in stance.”

Phainon bounced back like an overexcited retriever who knew he'd done something wrong but didn't want to admit it.

Because yeah—he felt weirdly guilty.

He wasn't supposed to be noticing things. Not like that. Not here. Mydei was just trying to help. Just being professional. And Phainon—

Mydei stepped back, arms lowering as he studied Phainon—eyes too wide, stance too springy for someone who'd just been drilled. Too much energy. Not enough guard.

Then, without a word, he stripped off the pads and tossed them aside with a lazy flick of the wrist. "Wanna spar?"

Phainon blinked. "Wait—seriously?"

Mydei's mouth ticked, just slightly. "Might be the only way to get you to focus."

Phainon lit up, grinning as he pointed a gloved finger toward him. "You're feeling real confident for someone about to eat canvas."

"Keep talking," Mydei said, already turning. "I'll knock the vowels outta that accent."

Phainon laughed, quick on his heels. "Good luck. Dad raised me too damn proud to quit on a consonant."

The rules were simple.

Thirty percent strength, nothing stupid.

Phainon stretched his arms, beaming. Mydei just rolled his shoulders. His stance was economical—tight guard, chin tucked, elbows in. He tilted his head slightly.

Phainon mirrored him, looser, more relaxed.

They started slow. Footwork first. Just the shuffle and slide of sneakers on canvas. Mydei circled tight, forcing Phainon to pivot, to follow—testing his balance. His gaze swept sharp over Phainon's form, calculating.

Phainon adjusted quickly. Saw the look, narrowed his eyes, and drew his guard up. "That all you got?"

Mydei didn't answer.

He just hit.

It was fast—more a flick than a punch, snapping clean toward Phainon's lead shoulder. Phainon blocked, stumbled a half-step, and caught himself with a grunt.

They reset. Circled again. The rhythm building, small and tense.

Phainon fainted a hook and chuckled when Mydei didn't bite. "Am I making you show off?"

"Focus."

Then Mydei tested him again—a lead punch, low cross toward the ribs. Not hard, but precise. Phainon caught one, missed the other.

"Shit—"

"Eyes up. You're telegraphing with your weight."

"Bossy today," Phainon muttered.

He launched a quick combo—two light jabs and a hook that just skimmed Mydei's shoulder. *"Gotcha!"*

Mydei didn't flinch. He dipped his frame low, pivoted his hips, and drove a tight counter into Phainon's ribs. Not hard—but a compact shot that knocked the air out of him.

"So did I," Mydei said.

Phainon wheezed. “Damn. Okay.”

Their movement quickened. Phainon’s footwork started to clean up, weight moving more naturally across the his feet. Mydei adjusted his rhythm in response, his body angling closed, forcing tighter turns. A new layer of sweat bloomed across their skin.

Mydei pressed in with more hits and Phainon blocked most of them, though one clipped his side again. He circled, breathing hard, and caught Mydei off-guard with a low body feint and tight inside hook.

Mydei ducked, caught it with a tucked elbow, and came back in close.

Too close.

They bumped. Glove to glove, shoulder to chest. Neither backed off.

“Y’know,” Phainon said, “for thirty percent, you hit like you holdin’ a grudge.”

“Move your damn feet.”

They collided again on the next turn. Mydei’s hand came up to adjust Phainon’s elbow—again—and Phainon found himself swallowing hard.

The rhythm was starting to fray.

Phainon slipped in confidently, launched a cross—and then his back foot slid out from under him.

Sweat. Canvas. Bad luck.

“Fu—”

He pitched forward, flailing for balance—and reflexively grabbed the closest thing to him.

Which happened to be Mydei’s arm.

Who was *not* expecting to be full-body yanked by a man with the center of gravity of a linebacker.

They crashed hard. A messy, tangled sprawl of limbs, gloves, and noise.

THUD.

Mydei barely caught himself, one arm braced firm above Phainon's head. Their gloves ended up squished between them. Phainon's knee was somewhere near Mydei's hip. Someone's foot might've been under someone's thigh. It didn't matter. They were *close*.

Close in the kind of way that made time get weird.

Phainon blinked up at him, dazed.

"…Hi," he breathed.

Mydei blinked back. Like he was rapidly updating several mental spreadsheets.

Phainon smiled, sweat-stupid. "So. You come here often?"

A beat. Mydei made a noise—tight, like a laugh jammed between his teeth—and shoved himself up in one smooth, *aggressively* neutral motion.

He turned so fast Phainon didn't catch his face. But his ears?

Yeah. Red.

Phainon sat up a second later, slower, rubbing at the back of his neck. "You okay? That was kinda a trust fall, but like, with malice."

No answer.

Just the echo of their breath. The soft pad of Mydei's footsteps. The thump of a glove hitting the bench.

Phainon exhaled, still smiling faintly—right up until—

His stomach let out a full-bodied, open-mouth scream. Like it had been personally wronged.

“…Oh, come *on*.”

Mydei turned. Slowly. With the full weight of judgment on his face.

“…You didn’t eat?”

Phainon paused. “I—uh. I don’t usually do breakfast?”

That wasn’t the right answer.

Mydei stared. Silent.

“…Are you an idiot?”

Phainon blinked. “Wh—I mean, probably?”

Mydei dragged a hand through his hair, eyes briefly closing like someone mentally updating a file titled *Stupid Things Phainon Has Done*. “You can’t spar without eating.”

“I didn’t know we were gonna spar!”

“I *did*.”

“You escalated!”

“We’re done.”

“What—but—”

“*Shower*.” Mydei’s voice cut like glass. He was already stripping his gloves. “Then food.”

Phainon mumbled, “fine,” and peeled himself off the mat, stomach still muttering threats. His face was pink, his ribs ached, and his hair was sticking to the side of his head.

Mydei was already walking away. Too fast. Too rigid.

Phainon followed—warm, sore, and still deeply, *deeply* confused.

And maybe just a little bit smug.

Because he might've lost, but at least he got to watch Mydei flustered.

The showers were private. Marble-walled, echo-soft, and so spotless Phainon felt like he was gonna get fined just for tracking water on the tile. He'd whistled low under his breath the second the door swung shut behind him.

Down the row, Mydei's stall had shut with a firm, definitive thunk.

Now, fresh out and changed into a fitted tee and the least-wrinkled pair of jeans he'd managed to fold into his bag, Phainon stretched until his spine cracked, then flopped down onto one of the wooden benches lining the back of the locker room.

Real wood, too.

He leaned forward, elbows braced on his knees, and let his head tip back with a quiet exhale. His skin still felt warm from the steam. He blinked at the ceiling. Waited.

Totally normal thoughts.

Like how nice the water pressure was. Or how the shampoo didn't smell like pennies. Or how—

Yeah okay, he'd absolutely seen Mydei toweling off on the way out. Brief glance, totally accidental, totally unimportant. It wasn't like his brain had short-circuited at the sight of that towel hanging too low on his hips, or the long slope of his back, or the—

Phainon groaned and dropped his face into both hands. His voice came out muffled. "Lord, take me now."

His hands slid down to his jaw. His eyes were fixed dead ahead.

And the worst part? That bite mark. Still there, faded into the side of Mydei's neck. That little bruise he'd left behind like a damn calling card.

What the hell was he even supposed to say? *Sorry I treated your shoulder like a chew toy while you were doing me a favor? My bad, thanks for the ride dude?*

Maybe it was fine. Maybe he could just pretend he hadn't seen it. Mydei hadn't said a word about it, after all—

"Hey."

Phainon flinched so hard he nearly fell off the bench.

He turned fast. Mydei stood a few paces away, toweling his damp hair one last time before slinging it around his neck. He was wearing loose joggers and a soft colored crewneck. His long hair curled around his collar and temples in damp waves.

Honestly, he looked… stupidly cute. Catlike. Tired but sleek, soft-edged, domestic in a way Phainon wasn't emotionally prepared for.

"Hey," Phainon said back.

Mydei walked over and sat beside him. Not close, but not far either.

Phainon started to say something, then paused as Mydei bent over his bag.

He rummaged for a second. Then pulled something out—a large bento box. He didn't look at Phainon, just held it between them for a beat.

Phainon tilted his head, brows lifting. Still smiling, faint and puppy-eyed.

A few seconds passed.

Then Mydei sighed through his nose. "…Well?" he muttered. "Are you gonna take it or not?"

Phainon blinked. “Wait—this for *me*?”

Mydei’s only answer was to push the box gently into his hands, then turn his face away like he hadn’t just gifted him the Holy Grail.

Phainon blinked down at it. “Uh. Thanks?”

He popped the lid.

Immediately the scent hit him—fresh and warm and herby. There were grilled chicken skewers nestled over lemon rice, roasted red peppers drizzled with olive oil, a little side of cucumber-tomato salad, and a neat container of soft, folded pita with hummus on the side. Still faintly warm. Homemade, but practical. Packed to travel. Thoughtful.

Phainon’s stomach let out a traitorous growl again.

“This smells amazing,” he murmured, wide-eyed. “Where’d you get it?”

“I made it,” Mydei said simply.

Phainon looked up, stunned. “Really?”

His face practically lit up. Like someone’d just handed him a puppy and told him it was his.

Mydei didn’t meet his eyes. Just adjusted his sleeve. “Eat.”

“Right,” Phainon said, grinning now. “Yes sir.”

He picked up a skewer and bit in. A little hum left him before he could stop it. “Oh man. That’s so good. Like, restaurant good. You sure you ain’t hiding a second job?”

Mydei gave him a side glance, dry. “I barely have time for the first.”

Phainon snorted—and paused. Then carefully shifted some of the food onto the lid and set it in Mydei’s lap.

“I’m not hungry.”

“Sure you aren’t,” Phainon said.

Mydei gave him a look that should’ve been withering. Should’ve.

Phainon met it head-on. Then leaned over, picked up a piece of pita, and held it out. Just hovering, deliberate.

Mydei squinted. “Don’t.”

Phainon tilted his head. “You sure?”

Mydei opened his mouth—to argue, probably—but in that exact second Phainon popped the bite in.

It landed. Right in his mouth.

Mydei froze.

Chewed. Slowly.

Then narrowed his eyes, murderous. “You—”

“You *what*?” Phainon provoked.

“That was ambush by carb.”

Phainon gave him a bright, innocent look. “Food tastes better when it’s shared.”

“That’s not how you share.”

“Mm. Sounds like someone’s scared of losing.”

Mydei stiffened like someone had struck a nerve. “Scared?”

Phainon’s smile deepened. “Bullseye.”

There was a pause. And then, flatly: “Who the hell do you think you’re talking to?”

Phainon just shrugged, lips twitching. “Guess we’ll find out.”

He popped another bite into his own mouth. “Whoever finishes their half first wins.”

“Wins *what*?”

Phainon beamed. “Bragging rights. Eternal glory. My undying admiration.”

Mydei narrowed his eyes. Then, without a word, picked up a skewer and started eating.

Phainon watched him.

Yeah. He’d baited him clean.

Mydei was too easy sometimes.

Internally? He was cackling.

Externally?

He offered Mydei the last piece of pita like a peace treaty.

“You’re an idiot,” Mydei muttered.

But he took it anyway.

Phainon had won their little food competition.

He’d been extremely humble about it.

Which meant, of course, that he threw both arms in the air like he’d just clinched Olympic gold, then offered Mydei a victory handshake with the

kind of smirk that made it very clear he was trying not to wiggle his eyebrows.

To his credit, Mydei only rolled his eyes once before muttering, “Shut up and finish chewing.”

Phainon did—happily, hungrily, and with absolutely no further commentary except for the occasional satisfied hum.

Later, when the bento was packed away and their water bottles sat half-drained between them, Mydei checked the time. He said it casually, like it was nothing. “There’s a library a few blocks from here. I need to return something.”

Phainon looked up, eyes wide. “Wait—you can *read*?”

Mydei froze mid-motion like someone had just slapped the book out of his hand. He turned slowly, expression still with offense.

“I graduated top of my class,” he said, voice deadly calm. “In *three* languages.”

“Yeah, yeah,” Phainon waved him off. “But like—reading for fun?”

“I *own* a library card.”

“Oh, so you’re a nerd *on purpose*.”

Mydei stared at him. “Do you want to get hit again?”

“What, with a book? Go on then, Shakespeare, make it hurt.”

Mydei glared.

Phainon cracked—doubling over with laughter, nearly falling off the bench in the process.

So now they were walking.

The sidewalk shimmered faintly in the late-summer heat. Sunlight pooled gold along the edges of the road, filtered through the soft haze of trees and mid-rise buildings. A lazy breeze stirred Mydei's hair as they turned down a quieter block—less traffic, more dog walkers. Phainon had picked up another story somewhere along the way and was mid-recital, his hands carving through the air with a kind of full-body enthusiasm that suggested he'd been waiting all day for someone to listen.

Every few steps, he drifted too close—shoulder brushing, sleeves grazing, a gesturing arm bumping Mydei's side before flinching back with a sheepish "my bad."

If it bothered Mydei, he didn't show it.

They passed under a row of sycamores shedding early leaves, past a hot dog cart steaming on a corner, past a window full of handmade earrings shaped like frogs. The scent of fresh mulch and burnt sugar wafted from somewhere—maybe a food truck or someone's backyard grill.

"So anyway," Phainon was saying, "I dared Caelus to eat a raw egg like a shot, and he did, but then Stelle got mad 'cause it was her egg and she wanted to throw it at a goose. Long story."

Mydei blinked at him. "…That was the trimmed version?"

Phainon pointed a finger. "Hey. The long version involves raccoons and a porch swing. I'm doing you a kindness."

"I'm not convinced."

"Listen, it was a tense time. Emotions were high."

"…Why was she throwing eggs at geese?"

"I think one hissed at her wrong. Girl's got vendettas."

Mydei made a quiet sound that might've been a laugh—just barely there.

“They’re twins,” Phainon added as they crossed at a sleepy intersection. “Caelus and Stelle. Grew up with them. Used to call them my partners in crime, but they kinda dropped the ‘partner’ part once I left town.”

He didn’t say it with any sadness—but there was something softer in the way he smiled. Something a little homesick around the corners.

“Any stories like that from when you were a kid?” he asked as they passed beneath a canopy of rustling leaves. “Y’know. Dumb stuff.”

Mydei tilted his head, thinking.

Then: “I once broke my cousin’s nose at a wedding.”

Phainon’s eyebrows flew up. “Oh.”

“It was an accident,” Mydei added. “Mostly.”

“…Mostly??”

“He tried to put cake down the back of my shirt.”

“That warrants a felony?”

“It was reflex. He learned about consequences.”

Phainon squinted at him. “You were the kid who decked grown men in dodgeball, weren’t you.”

Mydei’s silence said everything.

Up ahead, nestled between ivy-covered buildings and a crooked fence lined with overgrown basil, sat a cozy brick library with tall windows and a wooden door worn smooth by years of use. Sycamores lined the front walk. A rusted bike rack stood crooked near the curb. The sign above the door read: **GARBANIPHORO LIBRARY** in hand-painted letters, half-faded by sun.

Phainon slowed, eyes lighting up. “Well *damn*. This is cute.”

He reached for the door and swung it open with a small flourish, then stepped aside, sweeping his arm low in an exaggerated half-bow.

“After you, sire.”

Mydei raised a brow. “You’re joking.”

“Never.”

Still dry as ever, Mydei stepped past him and into the cool, quiet hush of polished wood and old paper.

Phainon followed, smile still lingering as the door clicked shut behind them.

The library looked smaller from the outside.

Red brick, ivy trailing down its edges, and an old hanging lantern above the door made it seem more like a neighborhood bookshop than anything else—something half-forgotten, wedged between a pastry café and an insurance office on a side street no one meant to walk down. You’d miss it if you weren’t looking for it. That felt intentional.

The kind of place you didn’t find unless someone told you where to look.

Inside, though, it stretched open in a way that didn’t match the modest exterior. Cool air greeted them—tinged with old wood, tea leaves, and maybe something floral tucked into a corner somewhere. Rows of narrow bookshelves unfolded ahead like ribs, vanishing beneath vaulted ceilings ribbed with beams. Dust swam through sunlight from high-set windows. Ancient ceiling fans turned in slow, creaky rhythm. Wooden ladders leaned against shelves like they’d grown roots there.

Phainon stood still for a moment, just… taking it in.

He’d expected cozy. But this wasn’t just cozy. It was lived-in. Safe in a way most places in the city weren’t.

A silver-haired woman looked up from behind a tall desk, a thick book spread open in front of her. Round glasses perched low on her nose. Her

braid was streaked with gray and curled at the end. She wore a faded cardigan and a look that knew everything without asking.

She smiled.

“Well,” she said, voice soft and amused. “Look who actually brought it back on time.”

“I always do,” Mydei replied, defensive.

“Sure you do.” She glanced over at Phainon, eyes twinkling. “And what’s this? You bringing home strays now?”

Mydei said nothing. But Phainon beamed.

“Yes, ma’am. He feeds me and everything,” he said cheerfully, tipping his imaginary hat.

The woman laughed under her breath and turned back to her book.

Mydei walked toward the desk, pulling a slim volume from the crook of his arm. Phainon trailed behind a little slower, eyes skating over the tall bookshelves and faded rugs, the tucked-away nooks with mismatched chairs, the chalkboard sign above the tea cart that read *No cell phones, No noise, Yes baklava.*

He liked it here.

There was something gentle about the way the place breathed.

He found a narrow bench near the front and sat while Mydei returned his book. When he circled back around, he didn’t look in a rush to leave.

“I’m gonna stay a while,” Mydei said. “You don’t have to—if you’ve got things.”

Phainon blinked. “And miss you willingly interacting with printed words? Nah, I’m good.”

Mydei gave him a faintly unimpressed glance but said nothing.

They drifted in deeper together, past rows labeled *“Modern Fiction”* and *“Translated Works,”* until the shelves grew older and the wood underfoot shifted from bright pine to a darker, more honeyed oak.

Eventually, they split without needing to say anything.

Mydei peeled off toward the back corner where *“History/Cultural Studies”* stretched in tall, slender shelves.

Phainon meandered slower.

He paused near a squat display stand and tilted his head.

Dogs of the World.

“Well don’t mind if I do,” he murmured, flipping the cover open.

He wandered slowly as he read. It was mostly pictures—big-eyed shaggy things and majestic breeds with names he couldn’t pronounce. Somewhere in there was a Samoyed that looked like Snowy, which made him smile a little too fondly.

He was halfway through a spread on herding dogs when something in his peripheral vision tugged him sideways.

Mydei. Settled into a corner armchair beneath one of the taller lamps. Book open, legs stretched out comfortably, already deep in whatever page he’d flipped to.

Phainon wandered over. Tucked the dog book under his arm.

“Hey,” he said. “Scoot.”

Mydei didn’t look up. “Seriously?”

Phainon leaned a little closer, nudging his elbow. “The chair’s wide enough if you don’t manspread.”

“It’s not wide enough for you,” Mydei muttered. But he shifted over. Barely. Begrudgingly.

That was all the invitation Phainon needed.

He wedged himself in with a little laugh, shoulder bumping against Mydei’s. Their thighs touched. He let out a slow exhale, flipping open his book again like this was a normal, reasonable arrangement.

Mydei finally glanced sideways. Faintly long-suffering.

Phainon stifled a yawn. “Told you I was staying.”

Mydei, after the interruption, seemed content to retreat behind his book like nothing had happened.

Phainon gave it thirty seconds.

Then he bumped his shoulder. Light, at first.

“Whatcha reading?”

Nothing.

He bumped him again, a little firmer this time. “Hey. You gonna be like that?”

Still no reaction.

“Alright,” he murmured, leaning in until their arms touched fully. “Now I gotta see what’s got you so enthralled.”

He peered over the pages.

The text was dense—black ink on thin paper, written in sharp strokes. A few of the letters looked Greek. Others didn’t. It was structured but unfamiliar, like something regionally specific.

“…What’s that?”

Mydei turned the page slowly. “Kremnoan dialect.”

Phainon blinked. “Kremnoan?”

A pause. Then his face brightened in recognition. “Ohh, like your company. Castrum Kremnos. That’s where the name comes from, right?”

“Roughly,” Mydei said. “The dialect’s older than the company. Older than the state, even.”

Phainon whistled under his breath. “So you’re not just into history,” he said, leaning back a little. “You’re into your history.”

Mydei’s fingers hovered over the edge of the page.

“…Heritage,” he corrected eventually. “Not history.”

Phainon blinked again, the distinction settling around him. He tilted his head, brow furrowed.

“Huh,” he said. “That’s actually kinda— I mean. That’s cool. Like, really cool.”

He rubbed the back of his neck. “Kremnoans, huh? That’s some lineage. Weren’t they the mountain types? Spartan-adjacent? Real quiet, real tough?”

Mydei’s mouth twitched like he was trying not to smile. “Something like that.”

“Damn.” Phainon chuckled. “You don’t do anything halfway, do you.”

Something in Mydei’s tone must’ve cracked something open—because before Phainon could think twice, he was saying:

“My folks came from Arcadia,” he said. “Long time ago. It’s more sheep pastures and shepherd’s flutes than tactical warfare, but—” He shrugged. “There’s pride in it, I guess. We always said that’s where the garden gene came from. Growing things. Sticking close to the land.”

“…Arcadia,” Mydei repeated, like he was turning it over in his mouth.

“Yeah. All the old paintings make it look like some peaceful paradise—green hills, fig trees, people laying around playing music. Real life probably meant dirt and chasing goats. Still.” He smiled faintly. “There’s worse things to come from.”

Mydei glanced back down at his page—but only for a moment. “You don’t talk like someone who knows old dialects.”

“Well,” Phainon said, bumping him again, this time more affection than teasing, “I got outvoted. None of the Greek stuck past my papou’s generation. Just the food and the guilt.”

That earned him a quiet laugh.

Phainon tilted his head toward the book again. “You think you could teach me a little?”

Mydei looked over at him.

Phainon wasn’t being rude. His eyes were curious. There was no mockery, no false play at being impressed. Just a kind of eagerness that snuck under your skin.

Mydei studied him for a long moment, then shut the book halfway.

“Fine,” he said. “But don’t waste my time.”

Phainon lit up. “Yes, sir.”

They’d had too good a time in that damn library.

What started as a joke—a single word Phainon had mispronounced so badly it made Mydei pause and visibly reconsider his life—had unraveled into a full-on, half-messy, half-earnest study session tucked between the warm, worn stacks of books. The quiet was filled with whisper-fighting and muffled laughter, Phainon’s increasingly flustered “I *am* saying it right”

clashing against Mydei's muttered corrections and exasperated sighs that somehow carried the weight of fondness.

It was, to Phainon's surprise, kind of magical.

The library light had shifted slowly as they spoke, the late afternoon sun slipping gold through the dusty high windows. Neither of them noticed the hour until the librarian passed by again with the gentlest throat clear in the world. They both paused then, blinking like they'd just come up for air.

Still, neither quite moved.

Eventually, Mydei closed his book—fingers lingering a beat too long on the edge of the page—and Phainon tucked his dog encyclopedia under his arm. They returned their borrowed items, waved the librarian a quiet goodbye (Mydei with a polite nod, Phainon with a bright, dimpled smile), and stepped out into the hum of a Chicago evening.

It was warm and breezy, the sky going soft at the edges.

They walked without a real destination.

"Meant to show you this earlier," Phainon said after a few steps, tugging his phone from his pocket.

He swiped a few times, then turned the screen toward Mydei. "Here. One of the few good pics I've actually got."

It was a sunlit photo, taken on a field somewhere—wild grass up to their knees. Three figures. A girl in scuffed boots, lean and smiling; a younger Phainon with an unfortunate haircut and both arms outstretched; and a blur of white fur in the middle, tongue out, tail mid-wag.

"That's Cyrene," Phainon said proudly, tapping the left side. "And that's me, obviously, before I had the sense to get a proper trim. And *that's* Snowy." He zoomed in on the dog's fuzzy face. "Tell me he ain't the cutest damn thing you've ever seen."

Mydei didn't answer.

Phainon glanced over. “What?”

Mydei’s eyes hadn’t moved from the screen. When he spoke, his voice was quiet. “Yeah,” he said. “Cute.”

Phainon beamed. “Right?? Look at those dumb little paws. He used to sneak into the barn and try to herd the goats. No fear, all floof.”

Mydei huffed. Phainon caught it.

But then the moment slowed. They kept walking, quieter now.

Phainon hesitated. His voice dropped, not dramatic, just suddenly sincere. “Hey… thanks.”

Mydei glanced at him.

Phainon rubbed the back of his neck. “For hanging out with me today. I know I kinda… crashed your morning with the whole boxing thing. And I talk a lot. And I’m real good at making everything take three times as long.”

“You’re also terrible at pronunciation,” Mydei added helpfully.

Phainon laughed. “That too.”

A pause. Then softer: “But I had a good time. It meant a lot. So. Yeah.”

They came to a stop at the corner, waiting for the crosswalk to change. The sun had dipped lower now, turning the sidewalk golden. A light breeze blew past, brushing warm air against their arms and hair.

Mydei turned slightly to face him. His expression was strange—but he was looking.

Really looking.

And Phainon felt it—like heat humming under his skin. He stepped a little closer without meaning to.

They didn’t say anything. Didn’t have to.

And maybe, if nothing had interrupted them, one of them might have done something about it.

But—

“Oh fuck,” Phainon whispered.

He yanked Mydei back by the wrist like a man trying to dodge a sniper. “Quick—bus stop—hide—now.”

Mydei, entirely off-balance, stumbled behind him. “What the hell—?”

“It’s Caenis,” Phainon hissed, flattening himself against the side of the shelter. “Hide. Pretend to be dead. Be the wind.”

Mydei blinked. “Who the hell is Caenis?”

“My boss,” Phainon groaned. “And today, I may have taken off work to frolic through Chicago with you. And by *may*, I mean I did. Even though she said all hands on deck because of some big Kremnoan exec drop-in.”

“You didn’t check the calendar?”

“I don’t live by a calendar, I live by the sun and consequences—*move*—”

They ducked out again, zig-zagging past a man with a double stroller and around a food cart selling mango slices. Mydei’s phone nearly flew from his hand as Phainon pulled him along with purpose and the silent desperation of a hunted animal.

Which was exactly why he didn’t see the woman with the stack of cardboard boxes until she stepped right into his path.

“Oh ma’am—*I am so sorry*—”

The impact was light, but enough to topple the uppermost box. Phainon’s grip slipped from Mydei as he immediately dropped to a crouch.

“Lemme help—shoot, you okay?” He was already scooping up the papers scattered across the sidewalk.

The woman blinked in surprise, then smiled. “Sorry—I’m fine, don’t worry.”

“Still, I should’ve been watching where I was going—wasn’t your fault at all, ma’am, promise.” Phainon handed her the final sheet of printed graphs and smiled sheepishly.

And then he looked up.

And over the top of her shoulder—

Caenis.

Impeccable black heels. Silhouetted suit. Cold, stunning expression. Cutting across the sidewalk like a glacier in Louboutin.

Staring straight at him.

Phainon froze like a deer on an open highway.

Then he blinked fast, crammed the last binder into the woman’s stack, and patted it like it was a horse being sent off to pasture. “You have a real lovely evening now,” he said in a single breath, already turning.

He walked stiffly back to Mydei, who was waiting with his arms crossed and one unimpressed brow raised.

“Maybe she didn’t see me,” Phainon muttered.

“She looked directly at you.”

“Yeah, but like, *looked*, or *recognized*?”

“You are the only person in a three-block radius dressed like a rancher going to a PTA meeting.”

“Rude.”

And then—

click. click. click.

The sound of Caenis’s heels, echoing closer.

Phainon closed his eyes and looked up. “I once skipped Uncle Davis’s funeral to avoid a land dispute with my aunt over fifty feet of pig-barn siding,” he muttered grimly. “If the Good Lord didn’t smite me then, this might finally be it.”

Mydei side-eyed him. “What the hell is wrong with you?”

“Silence, fiend.”

Phainon didn’t want to turn.

He stood still, half a breath longer.

He exhaled, smoothed down his shirt with one palm, and finally turned.

“…Miss. Hello,” he said, forcing the corners of his mouth up into something polite.

Caenis stood before him in a tailored cream blazer and pointed heels that clicked far too quietly.

“Phainon,” she said, like she’d discovered a toy she forgot she owned. “Small city.”

“Heh,” he chuckled, a little breathless. “Real small.”

Her eyes dipped down his frame—his creased gym tee, the empty duffel bag slung over one shoulder—then flicked back up, the same smile still in place.

“You’ve been keeping busy, I see.”

Phainon shifted his weight. “Just squeezing in a little training. Trying to stay active. You know how it goes.”

“I do,” she said pleasantly. “I just didn’t expect you to.”

He faltered, smile hitching.

“But it’s good you’re getting out,” she went on. “That’s healthy. I always say a strong body helps with a clear head.” She gestured idly to his duffel. “Of course, not everyone needs a clear head at work.”

Phainon blinked. “Sorry?”

She waved it off. “Oh, don’t worry. It’s just—we’ve all been adjusting, I know. Some of us faster than others.”

He tried not to bristle. He was still smiling. Still holding the bag strap. “I really didn’t mean to miss the in-person,” he said. “Thought the exec wasn’t coming until later—guess I got the wrong message.”

Her brows rose. “Did you?”

The pause hung.

“I suppose that explains the two emails you missed. And the dashboard ticket that still hasn’t moved since last Thursday.”

He opened his mouth. Then shut it again.

Caenis just smiled, like she hadn’t said anything at all.

She tilted her head. “We’ve always appreciated your… charisma, Phainon. You’ve got a nice way of putting people at ease. People like that—until they need results.”

Phainon’s gut twisted. “I’m—sorry, I didn’t mean to let anybody down.”

“Of course not,” she replied quickly. “You wouldn’t. You just… don’t really know what’s expected of you yet.”

His mouth went dry.

“You’ve got heart,” she continued, lightly. “And that’s rare. But that’s not always enough. Not when you don’t quite have the instincts yet. Or the polish.”

It hit like a compliment. Sounded like advice.

Felt like a kick.

Phainon swallowed. “I’m trying to learn. Fast as I can.”

“I’m sure you are. But there’s learning,” she said gently, “and there’s keeping up. Most of the team doesn’t have time to hold hands. Especially with all the structural things you’ve missed—well. I know it’s a lot. You didn’t grow up with this kind of pace.”

She smiled again. No malice in sight. Just concern.

“Back home, I’m sure you did great. But here, in the real world, the market’s a little sharper. People don’t wait.”

He flinched, barely.

A quiet heat was curling up behind his ribs. Shame. And something worse.

She doesn’t know me.

But he didn’t say it. Because what would be the point?

She wouldn’t understand the hours he worked scraping paint off barns in ninety-degree heat. The time he slept on a friend’s floor to save for rent. How he patched up Cyrene’s FAFSA forms by hand and sat on hold with health insurance for three hours last week just to get an ID reissued.

How he *had* ambition. She just couldn’t see it past his accent.

He clenched his jaw. He was smiling. He was *still* smiling.

“I’m just trying to do my best,” he muttered, eyes on the sidewalk.

“And we appreciate that,” Caenis said brightly. “It’s just—if your best is what we’ve seen, then maybe we should talk about setting more realistic goals.”

Phainon didn’t respond. He couldn’t.

He was angry.

Hot with it, under the collar, in the chest. But there was nothing to do with it. Nowhere to put it. He needed this job. He needed next month’s paycheck, and the one after that. He needed the insurance, the network. He needed not to piss off a woman who could quietly get him reassigned into obscurity.

But God, it stung.

And it stung worse because Mydei was here.

Because he’d seen it.

Because Phainon was standing in front of him looking like some dumbass hayseed who didn’t know how to answer emails. Like he was soft. Small. Like a child trying to dress up for an interview he didn’t deserve.

“I’m only saying this,” Caenis said, as if wrapping a bow on it, “because I know you mean well. And I want you to grow.”

“Right,” Phainon muttered. “Thanks.”

She adjusted the strap on her purse, preparing to pivot with some final, gracious remark—and then:

“Is there a problem?”

The voice was a blade.

Phainon blinked. His head turned slowly.

Mydei had stepped forward—shoulders set, back straight, expression unreadable.

Like stone. Or something sharper.

Phainon immediately waved him off. “No—no, he’s fine, really, just a little workplace talk—”

Caenis turned, irritated, already gearing up to dismiss the interruption.

“Excuse me, this is a private—”

Then saw his face.

And stopped.

Her gaze swept over him—once, carefully, like she was trying to make sense of him.

Recognition hit like a slap. Her mouth parted.

She blinked.

Phainon looked between them, confused. “Uh… what’s going on?”

Mydei didn’t respond. Didn’t glance at him. His gaze stayed on Caenis, slow and level and glacial.

Caenis gathered herself in a blink too fast. Her voice jumped half an octave. “Oh—I didn’t realize you two were—”

“Acquainted?” Phainon filled in, sheepishly and slightly red. “He’s the one who brought me here, actually. Great spot.”

Caenis turned back to Mydei with something *very* close to disbelief flashing behind her eyes.

He didn’t look away. His silence crackled like frost.

Then he spoke.

Absolutely unsympathetic.

“I believe your schedule is full. Don’t waste your time here.”

That was all.

Phainon gawked. “Whoa—hey, y’all, it’s not a—”

Caenis’s breath hitched. Her mouth opened—closed again.

She tried a laugh.

It came out brittle.

“Of course,” she said, voice thinner than before. “You’re absolutely right. Just passing through.”

She took a step back. Adjusted her bag. Nodded too quickly. Her smile still hadn’t fully recovered.

Then she turned. Heels clicking, strides too fast to seem casual.

Phainon stared after her, dumbstruck.

A long silence followed.

He looked over at Mydei.

“…What the hell was that?”

Phainon was still watching Caenis disappear down the block when he realized—

Mydei still hadn’t moved.

He turned, slowly. “Seriously. What was—”

“Is she always like that?”

The question came even. But sharp enough to cut.

Phainon blinked. “Caenis?”

Mydei didn’t answer. Just waited.

“…Yeah,” Phainon said finally, rubbing at the back of his neck. “I mean. Kinda. Not all the time. She’s just—real polished. Real… driven. That’s just how she is with me, I guess.”

Mydei’s eyes narrowed, just slightly.

Phainon caught the shift and veered fast. “Uh—anyway. Thanks. Back there.”

“Don’t mention it.”

“No, but—seriously.” He glanced over. “What even was that?”

“You ask too many questions.”

Phainon snorted. “You say that like you’re not used to it by now.”

Something in Mydei’s mouth twitched. Not a smile, not quite. But the edge of something softer.

Still, the tension hadn’t left his shoulders.

Phainon studied him a second.

Mydei wasn’t just annoyed.

He was angry.

Still coiled up under the surface, too careful, too still. And not for his own sake.

He was angry… for *him?*

That realization landed suddenly, somewhere between Phainon's ribs.

He cleared his throat. Lightened his voice. "Wanna get ice cream?"

Mydei blinked. "…It's sixty-five degrees."

Phainon coughed. "So that's not a no."

There was a pause. Then:

"…Lead the way."

Phainon smiled—this time, for real.

He nudged Mydei's shoulder as they fell into step, the two of them blending back into the late-afternoon flow. The sky had started to stretch golden, clouds streaked like soft brushstrokes across the rooftops. Downtown shimmered ahead, glass and steel catching the sun.

They walked in rhythm. Close, but not touching.

Until—somewhere between one step and the next—Phainon's pinky brushed against Mydei's.

And Mydei's curled back.

No words. Just the quiet press of skin. Gentle. Intentional.

They kept walking.

Phainon didn't say anything about it. He just smiled—and didn't move his hand.

Chapter End Notes

> Quick question I'm probably gonna do a jealousy scene with jealous Phainon at some point but who exactly should be the object of

jealousy? As in the person with Mydei to get Phainon jealous, I’m stuck on that😭

Oh and CEO reveal is next chapter btw, brace yourself

Chapter 6: The CEO of My Heart (Unfortunately)

Chapter Summary

> Phainon starts his evening dodging calls, ends it dodging (unsuccessfully) emotional trauma. Somewhere in between, there's Caelus being Caelus, mutual trauma dumping, Aglaea running a corporate sermon, and the soul-crushing realization that the guy he just kissed is actually the CEO everyone's been waiting for.
>
> What a night.

Chapter Notes

> Finally back to this!!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Nothing about today felt special at first.

Phainon sat in his recliner, half-awake, staring at a muted Cubs game limping through another loss on his beat-up TV. The Red Line rattled past his window, steady as a heartbeat. His fridge hummed along, its door a scrapbook of his whole damn life—crooked pizza coupons, a church festival calendar with Snowy stealing a bratwurst in the photo, a second-grade Polaroid of Cyrene throwing a peace sign, and the old cow magnet still holding up his bills like it was pulling duty.

His phone buzzed, loudspeaker crackling, and then—

HOOOOOOONK!

Phainon flinched.

"If I get T-boned by a Ford F-150 mid-call," Stelle bellowed, Kansas wind and road noise roaring around her, "you're putting flowers on my grave at Arrowhead and reading my eulogy on the fifty-yard line!"

“Jesus Christ, Stelle.” He dragged a hand down his face. “Focus on the damn road before you distract yourself into a casket.”

A softer laugh cut through the chaos. “Don’t worry,” Cyrene said from her dorm room, her mic catching faint pop music—one of those bright, overproduced choruses Phainon couldn’t name if his life depended on it. He remembered Caelus mentioning Cyrene’s roommate once, March, said she was always singing. Seemed true if the background noise was something to go by. “I’ll write the eulogy,” Cyrene teased. “Phainon would just cry through it.”

“I ain’t crying through nothing,” he muttered, sinking deeper into the recliner. “Anyway. Cubs lost again.”

“Again?” Cyrene perked up.

“Fifth in a row,” Phainon said, reaching for the Coke can on his coffee table.

“Tragic,” Stelle’s voice shot back, flat as a cornfield. A second later: “WHO GAVE YOU A LICENSE, MA’AM?!”

The phone filled with more honking, muffled cussing, then the slam of her open window.

Phainon shook his head. “Don’t act like you care. You don’t even know what city the Cubs play in.”

“I know they’re not in Kansas,” Stelle retorted. “Can’t say that about your *mystery man*, though.”

Phainon narrowed his eyes, but let that one slide. “So, Cyrene. How’re classes? You sound tired.”

On the other end, he heard paper shuffle, a pen clatter. Her voice came more tired, the smile thinning. “Midterms. Two down, three to go.”

Phainon sat up a little. “That’s a hell of a week.”

“It’s fine,” she said quickly.

“You eating? Sleeping? I can come down this weekend, stock your fridge —”

“Phainon.” She laughed under her breath. “I’m okay.”

He caught the tail end of the song in her dorm, someone belting a high note, and for a moment it stung—how far away she sounded, like she was building her own life all alone while he sat uselessly in this apartment with the same rattling train outside. He chuckled once, awkward. “Sorry. Don’t mean to hover. Just… my little sister, in university.” He shook his head. “Something I never even came close to. Makes a guy proud, y’know?”

He rubbed at the back of his neck, realizing he’d gone soft. “First one of us to get out. First one to—”

“Oh my God.” Stelle’s voice cracked in, exasperated. “Sappy. He’s getting sappy.”

Phainon straightened. “Don’t you start, Miss Fancy Pants with your car payments and your GPS. Aren’t you proud too?”

“Of course I’m proud—HEY! HEY! USE YOUR BLINKER! YOU SON OF A—” Her voice cut off mid-curse, followed by another blaring horn and the sharp click of a mute button.

Silence.

Phainon raised his brows at Cyrene’s video square.

“Uh…” he ventured.

“Yeah,” Cyrene agreed. “We don’t ask.”

“Right.”

For a second it almost felt like the call would wind down. Cyrene leaned forward into her webcam, chin in her palm, eyes sly.

“So, Phainon…” she began, dragging it out. A little smile tugged at her lips. “Don’t you have anything you wanna tell us, too?”

The question landed like a weight in his chest.

He laughed, too fast, shaking his head. “N-no? What’s that supposed to mean?”

Cyrene tilted her head, the grin growing. “Mhm.”

A bead of sweat rolled down his temple. Phainon had a gut-deep certainty that whatever came next, he wasn’t gonna like it.

“So, Phainon…” Cyrene’s voice lilted in that suspicious way only little sisters could manage, each syllable dragged out like a net she was about to throw over him. Her face was propped in her palm on the video square, eyes sharp with mischief. “You been hanging out with that guy again? What’s his name—the one you kept calling your nemesis?”

Phainon made the mistake of taking a sip of water right then and nearly choked. He coughed into his sleeve, eyes narrowing. “Nemesis—what kinda—yeah, I mean… Mydeimos. But what’s he got to do with anything right now?”

Cyrene leaned back, flipping her pen between her fingers like she wasn’t watching his every twitch. “Oh, nothing. Just asking. Funny, though, you do bring him up a lot. More than anyone else lately.”

“Funny how you’re suddenly the FBI,” Phainon muttered, shifting in his recliner. “What, you keeping a case file on me now?”

“Don’t need a case file,” she said sweetly. “It’s just patterns. And the pattern is you getting all defensive every time his name comes up.”

“I don’t get defensive,” he said—way too quick. “I just don’t see why my social life’s on trial when you should be—” He caught himself just in time before saying studying, realizing he was about to veer back into midterm territory.

Grumbling, he stood and wandered toward the kitchen. The fridge gave a tired groan when he yanked it open, rummaging for a bottle of water. Cyrene leaned closer to her screen, sharp-eyed as always.

“You *still* have the cow magnet?” she said suddenly, laughing. “Oh my God. That thing’s ancient. I think it’s older than me.”

Phainon glanced over his shoulder, offended. “What, I ain’t supposed to keep a piece of home? That cow’s holding up my bills. She’s a working gal. Don’t disrespect her.”

Cyrene cracked up, shaking her head. “Only you would get sentimental about a fridge magnet.” She wagged her finger at the camera. “And don’t think that little detour saved you. We’re still on the subject of your nemesis.”

“You don’t let a guy breathe,” Phainon groaned, filling his glass. “It ain’t even—”

Before he could finish, Stelle’s line suddenly crackled alive again, exploding into chaos. The tinny twang of a country radio fought against honking horns, a man somewhere outside screamed *“PULL UP, YOU JACKASS,”* and the distinct crinkle of a fast-food bag made it clear she had somehow acquired fries mid-road rage.

Phainon and Cyrene both froze, staring at their screens in the same flat disbelief.

“…Was that a goat?” Cyrene asked finally, brow arched.

Phainon squinted at the phone like it might provide an answer. “That was *definitely* a goat.”

“Sorry, sorry—what’d I miss?” Stelle’s voice shouted through the yelling, totally unfazed.

Cyrene smirked, seizing her chance. “Oh, just Phainon’s little crush.”

“HEY!” He spun around so fast his water sloshed, nearly spilling down his shirt. “Not a crush—”

Stelle perked right up. “Wait—ohhh. You mean that dude he’s been ranting about unprompted? The one with the name that sounds like a Greek god? Yeah, yeah, you’re right—he never shuts up about him.”

“Bro,” she added, not missing a beat, “you sound like a middle-aged book club lady who clutches her wine glass while swooning over the mysterious man at the coffee shop.”

Cyrene gasped with glee, covering her mouth. “No, no—that’s not it. He sounds like Dad. Remember when he first started courting Mom? Same tone, same look. Down so bad.”

Phainon groaned, half-whining as he dragged a hand down his face. “He’s just a guy, alright? Just a guy. Quit making it weird.”

But both of them were already grinning at him like cats who’d cornered a mouse, and Phainon knew there was no way in hell he was escaping this conversation.

Stelle let out a sigh so dramatic it rattled through the tinny speakers. “Fine, fine, I’ll shut up about your… *little situation*.” She even made air quotes. “I’m done. Totally done. Dropping it. Gone, poof.”

Phainon narrowed his eyes. “Good.”

A pause. Just long enough for him to start settling into the quiet.

Then Stelle leaned in with a look that spelled doom. “But respect the hustle, though. You casually dating in the city now? What is this, like Hinge but with worse sidewalks? Swipe left, swipe right, suddenly you’re at some dive bar eating mozzarella sticks with a stranger?”

“Stelle—”

“I’m serious!” she cut in, voice going muffled as she clearly shoved another fry in her mouth. “You’ve been in Chicago for a year or two, right? You’re

telling me you never tested the waters? Not even a coffee shop flirtation? The old ‘oops we both reached for the same biscotti’ move?”

Cyrene perked up, amused. “Or the grocery store cart crash. Classic.”

“Exactly,” Stelle said, clapping her hands like she’d found a partner in crime. “Or dog parks, that’s the number one hot zone. You bring Snowy to the city, boom, instant dates lined up. Dogs are like wingmen with fur. A golden retriever could probably get you engaged in three weeks flat.”

Phainon grimaced. “I am not pimping out Snowy for romance.”

“Then you’re wasting resources,” Stelle shot back.

Cyrene laughed, shaking her head. “Come on, though. You’ve never been like that, Phainon. You’ve never been the casual type. Not in high school, not in college. Not ever.”

“Damn right.” He slouched deeper into his chair, like the weight of their scrutiny alone was enough to give him back pain.

Stelle raised her brows. “So what then? You only date if you’re already planning the wedding?”

It was teasing, but Phainon answered without thinking. “…Yeah. Something like that.”

The silence hit like a cymbal crash. Even the goat in the background—mercifully—shut up.

Cyrene’s eyes widened, then started sparkling.

Stelle squinted at him like she was examining a rare bug under glass. “… Hold on. Dude. Then are you implying slash telling me you wanna *marry* this guy?”

“Wait—wait, wait—” Cyrene was already half doubled over, hand covering her mouth.

Phainon’s face went red so fast it was almost comical. He scrambled for words, each one worse than the last. “What—no—no, that’s not—I didn’t mean—what the hell are you even—”

“You literally just said it,” Cyrene sang, delighted.

“You did,” Stelle confirmed, calm and merciless, like a judge handing down a life sentence.

“I did *not*!” Phainon barked, pointing wildly at the screen. “Nope. Absolutely not. I am not having this conversation with you two. I’m done. I’m cutting the call. Good day to you, Stelle. Good day to you, Cyrene.”

“Phainon, wait—”

But the video went black, cutting them off. Stelle’s laughter shrieked through the speakers for half a second before vanishing, replaced by the hollow silence of the empty call screen.

Phainon stared at his own reflection in the laptop’s dark screen for a beat, face still on fire.

Working at Okhema had always been bad, but lately they felt like dress rehearsals for a funeral.

By the time Phainon pushed through the glass doors of Okhema Tech, the place already carried that tired, end-of-season energy, like a school limping into finals week. The lobby was bright enough, but it all looked dulled around the edges: half-drained plants by reception, carpet showing its age, the receptionist herself flipping through a magazine without even pretending to look busy. The AC clattered overhead in that way it did when the vents hadn’t been cleaned in years, and for a second, Phainon wondered if anyone would even bother fixing it now. Why spend the money if the logo on the wall would be someone else’s in a month?

He swiped his badge, waited for the turnstile to beep, and stepped into the main floor. The atmosphere hit him right away. It wasn’t tense exactly.

More like… weirdly resigned. People still typed at their desks, still took calls, but the energy was muscle memory, not motivation. Nobody was asking if the merger was happening anymore. That question had burned out weeks ago. Now it was all: *When it's done, where do we end up? How bad is the cleanup going to be?*

The conversations floating over cubicle walls sounded less like coworkers chatting and more like survivors picking over wreckage.

"When the new logos go up, I'm calling dibs on a corner desk," someone in design announced, too loudly, like claiming imaginary territory made it real.

"Corner desk?" his neighbor scoffed. "We won't even know where the corner is. They'll probably gut this whole floor."

There was laughter—dry, brittle, the kind that didn't come from anyone's stomach. A laugh you threw out just to prove you could still make noise.

Phainon adjusted the strap of his messenger bag higher on his shoulder, weaving his way down the aisle. He passed clusters of cubicles that looked like little stages mid–set change. Some were stripped bare, with only an unplugged monitor left behind. Others were half-packed, cardboard boxes crouched under desks, photo frames leaning awkwardly against staplers and stacks of folders, waiting for the signal to flee. A few people had carted off their things already—personal mugs, bobbleheads, novelty calendars. Desk plants had vanished overnight, leaving pale squares of dust in their place.

It was almost worse seeing the ones who stayed fully decorated, like nothing was happening. A little desperate. Like if you left your cubicle untouched, you were somehow declaring immunity.

Near the breakroom, two analysts loitered with paper cups of burnt coffee, voices pitched just high enough that everyone passing could hear.

"I heard HR already merged payroll," one said, brows raised in mock secrecy.

"No way."

“I swear. My buddy saw a Kremnos header on his direct deposit slip.”

The other groaned. “Fantastic. Just what I needed. At least they didn’t bounce it.”

They both chuckled, but it landed flat. Phainon slid by them, head ducked, and caught sight of Greg two desks over. Greg had stationed himself right next to their manager like a golden retriever, nodding at every bland reassurance, eager laugh perfectly timed. Meanwhile, over in QA, some guy had his sneakers up on his desk and was scrolling his phone like the end of the world had already been scheduled on his calendar.

It struck Phainon as surreal: half the floor hustling harder than ever to prove their worth, the other half already living like ghosts.

“Hey, Phainon.”

He turned. A coworker leaned on the wall of his cubicle, mug in hand, smiling like this was small talk in line at the grocery store.

“Better get used to it, huh? Won’t be long before you’ve got a new boss breathing down your neck.”

Phainon forced a smile, thin but passable. “Yeah. Can’t wait.”

The guy laughed and retreated, leaving Phainon in the fluorescent hum, staring at a row of desks that looked a little more hollow every day.

He let out a breath he hadn’t realized he was holding. He dropped his bag into his chair, spun it once by the strap, and hovered there, not quite ready to sit.

From where he stood, the office spread out in its usual little islands: cubicles walled off with thumbtacked calendars, the breakroom with its perpetually out-of-order vending machine, the long row of windows where someone’s January snowflake still clung on like it had tenure. On paper, nothing had changed. But the way people carried themselves gave the lie away.

Greg, two desks over, was still glued to their manager like he thought proximity might buy him job security. Across the aisle, sneaker-guy from QA (Phainon was pretty sure his name was Tyler, but he couldn't swear to it) had his feet propped on his desk, scrolling his phone. Every few minutes he barked a laugh, probably at Twitter, as if to prove he didn't give a damn. A designer shuffled past balancing a cardboard box with one arm, the plastic fern sticking out at an awkward angle. She muttered something about "just taking it home early, less to carry later," and nobody challenged her.

Phainon finally sat, rolling his chair in slow, aimless circles until it faced his monitor. His screen glowed a stubborn blue, waiting for him to log in. He ignored it.

This was the part of a merger everyone hated—the long, stale waiting room where the magazines were out of date and nobody knew if their name would be called.

They'd already had the first wave, the so-called "preliminary trimming." Contractors dropped. Underperforming teams dissolved with zero fanfare. A handful of unlucky people escorted out after those infamous "restructuring" emails that said absolutely nothing and everything at once. It had been ugly, sure, but manageable. Just enough cuts to make Okhema look lean and glossy in the pitch deck.

Now came the pause. That eerie calm where the axe stayed in the air, casting its shadow over everyone's desk. The logic was cold but simple: why fire people now if the new bosses were going to reshuffle anyway? Better to wait, let Kremnos do the killing once the ink dried.

And so they all waited.

"I heard recruiters are circling again."

"Of course they are. Sharks can smell blood in the water."

Phainon wanted to cover his ears.

“Yeah, they told us to put the rollout on ice until ‘post-integration.’”

“Translation: don’t spend money on a project when you don’t even know if the team’s still alive.”

Everywhere Phainon looked, people were bracing in their own ways. HR meetings with no listed agenda, just the cryptic “check-in.” Managers ducking questions with the same vague optimism as weather forecasters who knew a storm was coming but couldn’t admit it. Even the vendors had gotten cagey—Phainon’s inbox had two separate “pending approval” notices on invoices that normally cleared in a day.

He rubbed the back of his neck, trying to knead out the tightness. His dad had gone through this twice, and the stories always lined up: the real cuts came after signatures hit paper. Both companies slapped their org charts down side by side, circled the overlaps, and someone started making phone calls. Sometimes the purge came quick, ripping off the bandage. Sometimes it was slower, a bleed stretched over months.

Knowing Kremnos, he had a sinking feeling it’d be the quick and brutal version.

The thought pulled at his chest, a sudden tightening that left him short of breath. For a second, he imagined himself carrying a box out to the parking lot, badge disabled, cubicle stripped like he’d never been here at all. His stomach turned over at the image, hot and sour, like he’d swallowed something wrong.

He shut his eyes, forced a long exhale through his nose. It was fine. He was fine. He would be fine. No sense spiraling over something that hadn’t even happened yet.

Stretching his arm until his elbow popped, Phainon turned deliberately back toward his screen. “Work to do,” he muttered under his breath.

For now, as long as his nameplate was still taped to this cubicle, that had to be enough.

“…and anyway, the guy just hands me a bagel like it’s reparations. I don’t even work there!”

Phainon didn’t even flinch at this point. He’d learned that if he reacted too early, Caelus only got louder. Instead, he finished typing out a note in the spreadsheet, clicked save, and *then* looked up—just in time to catch his best friend halfway through spinning in the spare chair like he owned the place.

Caelus had made himself right at home: hoodie half-zipped, sneakers kicked up on the edge of the desk, iced coffee sweating over a stack of expense reports that definitely weren’t waterproof. He had that look on his face again—the one that said *he’d already been talking for several minutes before Phainon tuned back in.*

“Are you seriously eating that in here?” Phainon asked, eyeing the bagel crumbs accumulating like snow across his desk.

“It’s a public bagel,” Caelus said, mouth full. “Found property. I’m just honoring the circle of life.”

He reached over and started rearranging the magnets on Phainon’s filing cabinet, humming tunelessly under his breath. The top one—an old Batman magnet one of his baby cousins had given him—got replaced with a wrinkled sticker that read *“Gaslight, Gatekeep, Grindset.”*

Phainon squinted. “Please tell me you didn’t just steal that off HR’s motivation board.”

Caelus grinned without looking up. “Relax. I’m redistributing the wealth.”

“That’s what people say before they get escorted out.”

“Then I’ll finally have a story worth telling at parties.”

Phainon tried to get back to work—he really did—but Caelus had other plans.

“Bro,” Caelus said, leaning over to peer at his monitor, “what even *is* that? Excel? Or Minesweeper’s emo cousin? Why’s it all green and yellow like a

traffic light having a crisis?”

“It’s called conditional formatting,” Phainon said, not looking up.

“Yeah, well, your conditions look terminal.”

Phainon sighed. “Don’t you have a job or something?”

Caelus waved a hand. “I’m networking.”

“You’re literally sitting in my cubicle.”

He nodded solemnly. “Networking.”

Phainon clicked his tongue, half amused, half done. “Actually—wait.” He paused, finger hovering over the keyboard. “Where do you even *work* now? You’ve been ‘between gigs’ since, what, 2023?”

Caelus swiveled lazily in the chair, straw still in his mouth. “Define ‘work.’”

“Define ‘income.’”

“You’re asking a lot of personal questions for someone whose office chair squeaks like a dying possum.”

“You’re deflecting.”

“You’re projecting.”

“You’re unemployed.”

“You’re using Comic Sans in a spreadsheet.”

Phainon’s head snapped up. “It’s *Calibri*, you gremlin.”

Caelus held up his hands. “Sure thing, corporate boy.”

Phainon couldn’t help a small laugh slipping out—it was either that or throw his mouse. Caelus always had that effect on him: half aggravation, half comfort, like an annoying brother you still wanted around.

Caelus leaned back again, crossing his ankles. “Anyway, the grind’s the grind. Capitalism. Hustle culture. Various endeavors.”

“That’s not an answer.”

“It’s a *vibe*,” Caelus said, dead serious.

Phainon snorted. “Yeah, a broke one.”

Caelus pointed at him. “Judgment from a man who color-codes expense sheets. Wild.”

Phainon gave up with a sigh, turning back to his monitor. The clicking of his keyboard filled the silence for all of ten seconds before Caelus broke it again.

“So,” he said casually, “you seen Twitter this morning?”

“No,” Phainon said flatly, “and I’d like to keep my blood pressure that way.”

“Too late,” Caelus replied. “Okhema’s trending again. Not for the fun kind of reasons.”

Phainon froze mid-click. “…What kind of reasons, then?”

“Layoffs. Merger talk. You know the drill. People posting those vague ‘on to new adventures!’ updates on LinkedIn.” He gestured with his straw. “Half my feed’s got the little green ‘open to work’ banner again. Feels like déjà vu, man.”

“Fantastic,” Phainon muttered, eyes glued to the spreadsheet but not seeing a thing.

“Oh, and one of my friends freelances for one of your vendors? Apparently their invoice has been ‘processing’ since mid-August.”

That earned a slow blink. “…Processing,” Phainon repeated, the word heavy in his mouth.

“Yeah. Which, like, never a good sign. But hey—accounting, am I right?” Caelus said quickly, giving his shoulder a quick pat like it might undo the damage.

“Mm.” Phainon didn’t answer, staring blankly at his screen as the hum of the office seemed to dull around him.

For once, Caelus went quiet too, spinning slowly in the chair. He gave a low whistle, like he could taste the tension in the air.

“Hey,” he said finally, softer. “You’re fine, man. Worst case, you crash on my couch again. Or we both go off-grid. Start a commune somewhere. I’ll grow basil.”

“That’s the worst case?”

“It’s all I’ve got budget for.”

Phainon huffed a laugh, rubbing at the back of his neck. “You’re supposed to be my emotional support idiot, not my bringer of doom.”

Caelus smirked. “Hey, I’m just the messenger, bud. Blame the economy.”

He drained the last of his drink, stood, and stretched with an exaggerated yawn. “Anyway, I should probably go pretend to be productive somewhere else.”

“Good idea.”

Caelus slapped his shoulder lightly as he passed. “You’ll be fine. You always are.”

“Sure,” Phainon said, tone dry but eyes soft.

Caelus grinned, already halfway down the aisle. “Don’t work too hard, Calibri!”

“Go away, Caelus.”

“Can’t. Networking.”

Phainon shook his head, fighting a smile as he turned back to his screen. The sound of his friend’s sneakers faded down the hall, leaving behind the soft buzz of lights and the faint warmth of a laugh that lingered just long enough to feel like home.

By the time the spreadsheet hit line three hundred and forty-something, Phainon had stopped pretending he cared about any of it. He’d been pretending hard, too—headphones in, brow furrowed, cursor blinking in an endless grid of numbers that had long since lost meaning.

The office around him had sunk into that weird pre-lunch limbo where everyone’s soul quietly left their body. Someone was muttering about pivot tables. Someone else had been “in a meeting” since eleven and never returned. And somewhere, somehow, someone had again committed the sin of microwaving fish.

He tried to focus, really he did, but the cursor blinked like it was judging him. His brain buzzed like an unplugged outlet. Eventually he just leaned back, stretched, and let out a groan that came from deep in his soul. His spine popped audibly.

“Man, that was your *spine*,” Caelus said from the other chair—yes, he was back, spinning lazily in a stolen swivel like a gremlin who’d claimed it by squatter’s rights.

“Yeah,” Phainon muttered, rubbing his neck. “And that was my will to live.”

Caelus lifted his empty coffee cup in solemn salute. “May it rest.”

The clock above them dragged itself toward noon. The hum of the office printer faltered like even it was losing motivation.

“Lunch hour,” Phainon said under his breath.

“Deli time?” Caelus perked up.

“That was the plan.”

“Good, because I’m starving. And my bank account needs the five-dollar sandwich therapy.”

Phainon pushed away from his desk, stretching until his joints cracked again. His head still felt foggy, though—like he’d been running on low battery all morning. Then it hit him.

He hadn’t even had coffee.

Not a drop. Not even the burnt communal sludge by the copier.

It was, frankly, a moral failure.

He looked down at his empty mug and sighed. “You know what? Screw the sandwich. I’m getting caffeine first.”

Caelus blinked. “Now?”

“Now.”

“It’s noon.”

“And?”

“I just thought we were going to the deli.”

“We were,” Phainon said, shrugging on his jacket. “But I changed my mind. You’re on your own, partner.”

Caelus narrowed his eyes, feigning betrayal. “Unbelievable. You’re ditching protein for bean juice?”

“Character development,” Phainon said, patting his shoulder as he walked past.

“Consider buying me lunch to make up for it,” Caelus called, standing to follow anyway. “Where you headed? Jefferson?”

“Yeah. Coffee’s actually drinkable there. Less burnt, more… spiritual awakening in a cup.”

Caelus fell into step beside him as they made their way out. “Guess I’ll walk with you part of the way. Moral support.”

“Because the sidewalk’s dangerous.”

“Exactly. Full of rogue pigeons and misplaced ambition.”

And that’s how they ended up here after 5 minutes of walking.

The air hit like relief—crisp, bright, and smelling faintly of street food and overwatered planters. The lunch crowd moved in lazy herds: students, office workers, construction guys in orange vests. Conversations overlapped, traffic hissed, a bus sighed as it stopped at the light.

“Wait you were *serious* about getting coffee now?” Caelus said, incredulous as they weaved around a delivery bike.

Phainon laughed. “Of course I am. What’s the problem?”

“No problem,” Caelus said, dodging another pedestrian. “Just thought you were joking while we were doing the deli run. Some of us still believe in lunch.”

“Then again, you’re welcome to go without me.”

“Oh, I am,” Caelus said, grinning. “But I’m still walking with you, because apparently we’re heading in the same direction, and I enjoy annoying you.”

“Touching.”

“Truly. It’s the foundation of our friendship.”

They passed a guy arguing with his AirPods, a dog tied to a meter post eyeing the world like it owed him money, and a group of interns laughing too loud about something none of them found that funny. How interesting.

“So,” Caelus said after a beat, “you ever think about quitting?”

Phainon snorted. “Every day.”

“No, I mean actually quitting. Like, full-send. Disappear into the woods. Start a podcast. Grow a beard.”

“You wouldn’t last three hours without a phone charger.”

“I’d adapt.”

“You’d cry.”

“Incorrect. I’d hotspot off yours.”

Phainon gave him a look. “Touch grass.”

“I am. I’m literally walking next to grass.”

“That’s a weed, man.”

“Still counts.”

They reached the corner where their paths split—deli one way, coffee shop the other. The smell of toasted bread floated through the air, mocking him.

“Well,” Caelus said, slowing. “Guess this is goodbye, traitor.”

“How sad,” Phainon said. “Try not to miss me.”

“Oh, I will. Every carb-filled second.”

“Good luck with your bagel, philosopher.”

“Good luck with your bean juice, coward.”

Phainon laughed and gave his shoulder a friendly shove. “Later.”

“Later, man.”

The crowd swallowed Caelus’s voice as Phainon turned down his street. His phone buzzed in his hand—a cheerful little notification: *Order ready for pickup.*

Two reasons he’d come here today.

One, obviously, coffee. It wasn’t Anaxa-level perfection, but it was close. Smooth, strong, overpriced—the holy trinity.

And two…

His lips curved as he thumbed open his messages.

Phainon:
[I’m here! Don’t see you though??]

The typing bubble appeared almost instantly.

Bastard❤:
[I’m in the corner booth.]

Phainon hummed under his breath, smile growing as he pushed open the café door. The bell chimed softly, letting in a rush of espresso and cinnamon. Indie music murmured from the speakers, and sunlight streamed through the front window in perfect golden slants that made the whole place feel like a warm pocket of peace.

The barista—a tired guy with a buzzcut and three piercings—was already sliding a cup across the counter.

“Phainon?”

“That’s me,” he said, picking it up. “Mobile order.”

“Triple-shot oat latte, right?”

“Yeah.” He took a cautious sip, then smiled. “Perfect. Just shy of a spiritual awakening.”

The barista laughed. “Glad to hear it.”

“Have a good one.”

“You too, man.”

Coffee in hand, Phainon turned—and his grin broke wider, unstoppable.

Because there, tucked in the corner booth, sat Mydei—half-lit by the window, scrolling idly through his phone with one hand, the other resting next to a half-eaten cinnamon roll. Sugar clung to his sleeve; sunlight caught in his hair.

He looked up at just the right moment, met Phainon’s gaze, and smiled.

And that was enough to make the whole day start over.

For a second, Phainon just stood there. The sight hit him harder than it should’ve, this stupid mix of warmth and nerves bubbling up in his chest. He told himself it was just the caffeine he hadn’t had yet. Definitely that.

He took a quiet breath, let the flutter settle, and forced himself to move. Just coffee, just lunch, just Mydei. Totally normal.

His cheeks already hurt from smiling by the time he reached the booth. He slid into the seat across from Mydei, the leather squeaking under him. Mydei didn’t even look up again until Phainon’s knee accidentally bumped the table. Then those golden eyes lifted, assessing him like he was some minor inconvenience delivered by fate itself.

For a beat, neither of them spoke. The café hum filled the space between them—the low chatter, the hiss of the espresso machine, some indie song too mellow for its own good.

Phainon's lips tilted into a smirk.

"So," he said, resting his chin on his hand, "you finally figured out how to order without scaring the barista? I'm honestly surprised you haven't stolen my order yet."

That earned him a visible twitch at the corner of Mydei's eye. Beautiful.

"Not my fault," Mydei said flatly, "that they spelled your name *'Faynon'* again. Maybe if you tipped more than spare change and rural charm."

Phainon snorted. "Rural charm's priceless, thank you very much."

"You'd think that," Mydei said, stirring his coffee. "The barista didn't."

"That's fine. He can spell my name wrong as long as he makes my coffee right."

"Did he?"

Phainon laughed under his breath, leaning back. "Good to see you too, city boy."

"Mm. Pity's mutual," Mydei said, but the edge in his tone was softened by the faintest ghost of a smile—quick, reluctant, almost hidden behind his cup as he took another sip.

Phainon caught it anyway. He always did.

He lifted his own cup in reply, tapping the lid lightly against Mydei's mug. "Guess we're even then."

The sound of the soft clink seemed to hang there a moment too long, the noise of the café blurring around them.

“This place,” he said, swirling his drink once before taking a slow sip. “You ever notice how every café in this neighborhood looks like a Wes Anderson set? Pastel walls, mismatched chairs, one decorative typewriter in the corner. Like if I sit still too long, some guy in a corduroy blazer’s gonna start monologuing about ennui.”

Across from him, Mydei’s mouth curved—just barely. “Says the guy drinking what can only be described as mud in a mason jar.”

Phainon’s face bloomed instantly. “That’s blue-collar authenticity, thank you. I’m supporting small business and my caffeine addiction at the same time.”

“You’re supporting your stomach ulcers.”

“Worth it.”

Mydei made a low, skeptical noise. “You’d think someone born in the Midwest would know what real coffee tastes like by now.”

“Oh, I know,” Phainon said, gesturing with his cup. “I just also know fancy espresso doesn’t hold a candle to whatever sludge my aunt brewed in a cornfield at six a.m.”

“That wasn’t coffee,” Mydei said dryly. “That was a cry for help.”

Phainon laughed—a real one, sudden and bright, startling the barista who was restocking sugar packets nearby. “Yeah, well, it got the job done. Unlike certain people who think caffeine is a personality trait.”

“Correction,” Mydei said, lifting his cup with slow precision, “I think good taste is a personality trait.”

“Right. That why you ordered something with enough foam and sugar to drown a cat?”

Mydei took a long, deliberate sip. His eyes cut toward the window, where the glass caught his reflection—tired, maybe, or just far away. When he

turned back, the distance had vanished, replaced by that same cool, wry steadiness Phainon knew too well.

Phainon tilted his head. “You know,” he said lightly, “this reminds me of the time you tried to poison me.”

Mydei blinked. “Excuse me?”

“Oh, don’t act innocent. The cinnamon incident. Last year.”

A sound escaped Mydei—half groan, half laugh. “That wasn’t poisoning. That was strategic sabotage. You stole my caramel macchiato first.”

“It was labeled in *Latin*! How was I supposed to know it was yours?” Phainon shot back. “Who even does that? I swear Anaxa can barely stand humanity as a concept, and you made him write *Vita est brevis, caffeina est vita* on your cup.”

“I don’t know,” Mydei said, fighting a smile. “Maybe because normal people don’t drink whatever you call that.”

“*He would’ve spit in it*, you know,” Phainon said. “You’re lucky he didn’t.”

Mydei’s brows lifted. “He wouldn’t.”

“He would.”

“Worked for me,” Mydei muttered. “You spent the rest of the week glaring at me from across the shop like some gargoyle.”

“I was plotting your demise.”

“Sure. Except your ‘demise’ involved ordering cinnamon in *everything* just to prove a point.”

Phainon’s smile widened. “Yeah, until you accidentally swapped our drinks and doomed yourself.”

That earned a hand to Mydei’s face, muffling another reluctant laugh. “You laughed for twenty minutes with those old ladies in that book club.”

“You sneezed for thirty.”

For a moment, they were both laughing—the sound light and unguarded. Phainon felt something in his chest loosen, a warmth spreading there that wasn’t just from the coffee.

“See?” he said when their laughter tapered off. “You missed me.”

“I missed peace and quiet.”

“Same thing,” Phainon said, leaning back with mock satisfaction.

Mydei’s gaze lingered on him, steady but unreadable. There was a flicker—something shadowed and quick—that crossed his face before he smoothed it out again.

Then he smiled, faint but real, lowering his eyes to his phone. “You’re still terrible at coffee, by the way.”

“Yeah,” Phainon said, soft enough that the words barely bridged the space between them. “But I’ve got good company, so I’ll survive.”

Mydei’s thumb stilled on the screen. Just for a second, his expression went still, the air between them tightening. Then the noise of a passing bus broke the spell, and he gave a small nod, back to composed.

“Next time,” Phainon said, clearing his throat lightly, “I’m ordering for both of us. We’re not repeating that incident.”

“You couldn’t handle it.”

“Oh, I could.” Phainon’s grin turned crooked. “I’d even spell your name right this time.”

“Good luck.”

“I’ll guess. Starts with *B-A-S-T-A-R-D*, right?”

Mydei’s eyes lifted, that spark back just long enough to hide the weariness underneath. “Careful, angel,” he murmured. “I still know where you buy your coffee.”

Phainon laughed, but something about the look Mydei gave him—half-smile, half-silence—lingered long after.

“You know,” he said after a moment, shifting the conversation, “I kinda miss open skies. Back home, you could see forever. No buildings, no noise. Just sky and maybe a hawk.”

Mydei made a quiet sound—half a hum, half an acknowledgment—but didn’t look up.

“Here it’s different,” Phainon went on. “Every time I look up, there’s a billboard or ten miles of glass in the way. I keep saying I’ll find a place to watch the sunset, but—” he shrugged, “—somehow there’s always something else to do. Work, groceries, traffic. Life, I guess.”

When he looked up, expecting a jab about him sounding like somebody’s grandpa, Mydei wasn’t smirking. His gaze had drifted somewhere past Phainon’s shoulder, eyes unfocused, thumb tapping an uneven rhythm against his mug.

Phainon hesitated, a faint crease forming between his brows. “You good? You’re usually giving me hell by now.”

“Yeah.” Mydei’s reply came quick, too even. “Just tired. You talk too much.”

Phainon arched a brow, leaning back a little. The tease hit its mark but lacked its usual spark. “Uh-huh,” he said, unconvinced but letting it slide. Mydei’s tells were quiet ones—small, sharp flickers that disappeared if you stared too long.

The silence lingered for a beat before Mydei cleared his throat softly, like changing stations.

“You ever walk around this part of the city?” he asked, tone more casual now. “There’s a view by the river. Less noise. Better air.”

Phainon gasped. “You? Voluntarily touching grass? Who are you and what have you done with Mydei?”

Mydei gave him a look that could’ve curdled milk. “Shut up,” he said, standing anyway. “Come on. Walk.”

That made Phainon’s grin widen. “Look at you. Man of the people. Out here embracing nature.” He downed the last of his coffee and pushed up from his seat, catching Mydei’s sleeve before he could turn away. “What’re you waiting for, let’s go!”

Mydei froze for just a heartbeat at the touch—barely perceptible, but Phainon caught it. Then Mydei exhaled, the faintest smile ghosting across his lips.

“…Sure.”

His hand slid down in one smooth motion until their fingers brushed. Then, almost absentmindedly—but not quite—he intertwined them, tugging Phainon toward the door.

The café bell gave a soft chime as they stepped outside, light pooling across the pavement in slow, golden ribbons.

Phainon chuckled quietly under his breath, the sound carried off by a passing breeze. Mydei’s expression stayed composed—bored, if you didn’t know better—but his thumb traced a small, steady circle against Phainon’s knuckles.

And that, Phainon thought as they walked into the fading light, was more than enough sky for now.

Turns out, when Mydei said he knew a place, he wasn't kidding.

The city peeled open around them, the concrete easing into a narrow path that hugged the river. The late afternoon light hit the water just right—warm and gold, the kind that made everything look softer, even the skyline. Cars hummed faintly somewhere above, and a train rattled across a bridge in the distance. The smell of espresso drifted from another café patio nearby, mixing with the faint metallic tang of the river.

It wasn't nature-nature. But it was the closest thing to peace you could find inside Chicago city limits.

And peace, unfortunately, always made Phainon talk too much.

"See," he said, waving one hand at the skyline, "this right here's proof y'all don't know peace. You stand by a river, see a few clouds, and suddenly everyone's acting like they achieved enlightenment. Back home, this is just where you go when your cousin flips the four-wheeler and you need a minute to stop laughing before you help him."

Mydei raised an eyebrow. "That's your idea of serenity?"

"Absolutely," Phainon said without hesitation. "You ever had fried catfish straight from the lake? Not that fancy beer-battered junk. I'm talking burn-your-fingers, eaten-on-a-tailgate kind of catfish."

"That sounds barbaric."

"It's *tradition,*" Phainon said, mock-offended. "You people wouldn't understand."

Mydei smirked. "You're right. I don't understand willingly eating something that probably came with a tetanus side dish."

"Blasphemy," Phainon said, pointing accusingly. "You wound me. I bring you to this beautiful, serene location, and you insult my cuisine?"

"You didn't bring me anywhere," Mydei said dryly. "I'm the one who knew the place."

“Semantics.” Phainon’s grin widened. “You’re just jealous you don’t have proper culinary taste buds.”

“I have *standards*.”

“Same thing.”

Mydei gave him that long-suffering look he reserved specifically for Phainon.

They passed under a bridge, where the light dimmed to a copper haze. Pigeons strutted along the railing like they owned the place. Phainon slowed, squinted at them.

“See, that’s what I mean,” he said, nudging one with his shoe. “City birds don’t act right. Back home, they’d scatter if you so much as breathed too loud. These ones? They’ve got health insurance.”

“You’re deranged,” Mydei muttered.

“Correct. But you love it.”

Mydei didn’t deny it, though the amusement faded quicker than usual.

For a bit, they walked in silence—the quiet kind that should’ve felt comfortable but didn’t. Mydei’s gaze drifted toward the river, his expression gone unreadable.

Phainon noticed. He always did.

He kept talking anyway, light and easy, watching out of the corner of his eye. “—And that reminds me of the time we tried to turn the barn into a zipline—”

“Mm.”

“Uh-huh.” Phainon stopped mid-step, squinting. “You’re not even listening, are you?”

“I am.”

“Yeah? Then what’d I just say?”

Mydei blinked, caught. “Something about… uh. Ziplining?”

“Wow,” Phainon said, deadpan. “That’s some top-tier listening.”

He crossed his arms, weight shifting. “Alright, spill. What’s up with you? You’ve been weird all day. Usually by now you’ve insulted me at least three times, minimum.”

“I’m fine,” Mydei said too quickly.

“Uh-huh. And I’m the mayor.” Phainon’s tone flattened, skeptical but not harsh. “You sound real fine.”

Silence again, this time heavier.

Phainon let out a breath through his nose, voice softening. “Look, I know you. When you start doing that quiet thing, something’s wrong. So, either tell me or I’ll start making assumptions—and trust me, they’ll be dramatic.”

That earned the faintest glare. Mydei’s jaw tensed, his eyes skimming the water before he sighed.

“…How do you do it?”

Phainon blinked. “Do what?”

Mydei didn’t answer right away. For a while, the only sound was the water pushing against the riverbank and the faint rattle of a train somewhere behind them. His thumb moved along the railing in idle rhythm, eyes following the sunlight as it scattered across the current.

“You ever notice,” he started finally, voice low, “how people like us don’t get much quiet?”

Phainon tilted his head, not interrupting.

Mydei went on, words careful, like each one weighed more than he wanted to admit. “There’s always noise. Schedules. Deadlines. People pulling at you from all sides. And yet—” His jaw flexed. “You still manage to… laugh through it. Like it’s nothing. Like you don’t get tired.”

He exhaled through his nose, a short sound almost like a laugh. “You’re always like this. Joking. Smiling. Talking about food. I don’t know how you do it.” His gaze flicked away. “How do you stay so… happy?”

The question hung there.

Phainon blinked, caught mid-movement. For a second, he didn’t even breathe.

Then Mydei frowned and straightened, already regretting it. “Forget it. That came out wrong.”

“Hey—”

“No, seriously.” Mydei lifted a hand. “You don’t owe me an answer. It’s rude of me to even ask—”

Phainon sighed, pinching the bridge of his nose. “Nah, it’s fine.” His voice came out rough, heavier than usual, like gravel rolling in his throat.

He stepped toward the railing, leaning his weight on his arms. The metal was cool beneath his palms; the river, a restless mirror throwing back the skyline in shaky strips. For a moment, he just watched it move, trying to line up his thoughts into something that didn’t sound like a TED Talk.

This would’ve been the perfect moment for a grand speech. Something about perseverance, grit, and staying strong—the kind of quote that gets embroidered on throw pillows or posted in cursive font over a sunset photo.

Keep your head up. Stay positive. Every storm passes.

He could’ve said all that. He wanted to, even. But it felt too fake, too neat for the real mess in his chest. And lying to Mydei wasn’t something he could stomach.

So instead, Phainon said flatly,

“Well, for one, I fucking hated myself.”

Silence.

Behind him, Mydei blinked. “…What?”

Phainon turned just enough to throw him a crooked grin. “Yeah. Like, professionally. If self-loathing were an Olympic sport, I’d have gold. Probably a sponsorship deal too.”

The corner of Mydei’s mouth twitched despite himself.

“I got bad enough that my sister started nagging me about therapy.” Phainon gave a low whistle and shook his head. “But then we checked the price. And I don’t know if you’ve *seen* the price of therapy in the U.S., but we both noped outta there faster than a raccoon from a flashlight.”

He sighed.

“Yeah, well, skipping therapy shockingly didn’t cure me.” Phainon’s tone brightened just enough to be self-mocking. “I couldn’t look at mirrors for a while. Or water. Anything that might remind me I was still… me.” He paused, then chuckled dryly. “My sister tried crystals and tarot. I tried whiskey. She won. Barely.”

Mydei exhaled.

“There’s that point,” Phainon went on, “where you start thinking, ‘Maybe I’m the problem.’ And then you realize—yeah, I *am* the problem, but I’m also the only one who can fix it, and that’s way too much responsibility for a Tuesday.”

He took in a breath, leaning back against the rail. “I once told myself I’d fix my mental health after harvest season. Three years later, still harvesting excuses.”

That earned a genuine frown from Mydei.

Phainon smiled faintly, but didn’t look over. “I don’t know,” he said after a bit. “One day I just got tired. Tired of hating myself. Tired of thinking every bad day was proof I deserved it. So I stopped taking it so damn seriously. Figured if I can laugh at it, maybe it stops winning, you know?”

He shrugged, voice dipping softer. “Plus, statistically, the universe can’t bully me harder than I already do, so… checkmate.”

It landed like a joke but didn’t quite sound like one.

He laughed anyway—a small, tired sound—and shook his head. “So yeah, not exactly the best guy to ask for mental-health tips. I checked therapy prices again last week—still criminal. So if I seem positive, that’s just because sarcasm’s cheaper than antidepressants.”

He turned then, expecting Mydei to throw a jab back, but instead found him quiet—frozen, almost, with one hand half-lifted, like he’d started to reach for him and stopped midway.

Phainon blinked, grin faltering. “…What?”

Nothing. Mydei just looked at him—a mixture of worry, surprise, something too honest for words.

Phainon sighed and turned back toward the river. “Okay,” he muttered, “maybe I should stop joking for five seconds.”

He leaned forward again, elbows propped on the railing. “Didn’t used to be like this,” he said more softly. “Back in high school, I… hell, I hated myself. Got real low. Thought I wouldn’t make it some days.” He rolled one shoulder, forcing a lighthearted tone. “But I kept busy. Kept my hands working. And now I figure, if I can laugh at it, that means I won.”

Mydei stepped up beside him, resting his arms on the railing too. “…You think laughing makes it smaller,” he said.

Phainon’s answer came easy. “Ain’t about making it small. Just remembering I got through it.”

They stayed like that—side by side, city hum behind them, river light in front—until Phainon turned.

“Now that I’ve told you all that,” he said, “it’s only fair you tell me what’s bothering you, right?”

Mydei huffed a faint breath, the ghost of a smile returning. “…I suppose it is.”

And the water kept moving, catching the sunlight in restless shards, like even the river itself was pretending not to listen.

Then Mydei said, so evenly it almost sounded like an opening to another joke,

“My father’s acting like the second coming of Christ and it’s getting to me.”

Phainon nearly choked on air. “…Huh?”

“Yeah.” Mydei didn’t even look up from the river. “Allow me to explain.”

He said it like he was narrating a minor inconvenience. “He’s been on this… reformed streak lately. Calls me just to ask if I’ve eaten. Buys fruit baskets. Gives advice about sleep schedules. Keeps talking about ‘making up for lost time’ like he’s been possessed by a self-help book.” He exhaled softly, the corner of his mouth twitching. “It’s—exhausting.”

Phainon blinked. “That doesn’t sound so bad.”

“It wouldn’t be,” Mydei said, “if he hadn’t spent the last decade pretending I didn’t exist.”

The words were light, but they hit with the weight of a dropped stone.

Phainon opened his mouth, closed it again. “Oh.”

“Mm.” Mydei’s gaze followed the ripple of the water. “To make a long story short, he wasn’t always like this. There was a time he was…” he gave a small shrug, “…actually kind of brilliant. The sort of man who walked

into a room and everyone made space. Business, politics, whatever—he could bend things. Until he couldn't."

He tilted his head slightly, thinking. "Then came the drinking. Not constant, just… cyclical. He'd stop, swear off it, then start again whenever the market dipped or a deal went wrong. He'd come home smelling like whiskey." His tone didn't shift, but the silence that followed did. "At first he wasn't cruel. Just gone, even when he was there."

Phainon stayed quiet.

"When I was about ten," Mydei continued, "he came home drunk out of his mind. I don't remember what I said—probably something stupid—but he hit me."

He said it so casually that it almost didn't register as something that should hurt.

Phainon's hands tightened on the railing. For a second, all he could see was the flash of that faceless man, heavy-handed, towering—and the sharp, ugly thought that he wanted to find him and make him regret it.

Then Mydei gave this small, wrong-sounding laugh. "It wasn't even that dramatic. One hit. That's all."

Phainon turned sharply, jaw tightening. "That's not funny."

"I didn't say it was," Mydei said, finally looking at him. His voice wasn't cold, just tired in a way that felt older than he should be. "I just said it happened."

He lifted a hand, dismissive, like brushing off a speck of dust. "Anyway. My mother came home, saw him passed out on the couch and me looking like I lost a boxing match. That was it—she told him she was filing for divorce."

Phainon's voice was low. "So they—?"

"No." Mydei cut in, gaze dropping again. "Key word: *was*."

He pressed his lips together, thinking. “I didn’t want them to divorce.”

Phainon frowned. “Why?”

Mydei hesitated. His tone softened, lost that polished dryness. “I thought if we stayed a family, he’d get better. That it’d force him to.” A faint smile crossed his face, bitter around the edges. “So my mother moved out instead. Took me with her. They stayed married in name only. Guess that was my compromise.”

The pause that followed stretched long enough for the wind to fill it.

“It worked, eventually,” Mydei said after a moment. “He got sober. Got help. Started trying again. And I’ll give him that—he really has tried. But sometimes…” He exhaled, eyes flicking toward the horizon. “Sometimes he tries too hard. Like he’s auditioning to be someone new. Like if he overcorrects long enough, I’ll forget what it was like before.”

Another pause.

“This morning got to me,” he said finally, voice quieter now.

Phainon looked at him, at the tiny break in his posture, the small sag in his shoulders that Mydei was trying to pretend wasn’t there. It was a look that didn’t belong on him—defeat.

“…I didn’t know,” Phainon said.

Mydei waved a hand vaguely, not meeting his eyes. “Of course you didn’t. Who would?”

It came out like a joke, but the faint catch in his voice betrayed it.

The city wind pressed against them, tugging at jackets and sleeves. Neither spoke again.

But when Phainon shifted closer—just slightly, enough that their shoulders nearly brushed—Mydei didn’t move away.

He nudged Mydei’s shoulder with his own, the motion half playful, half grounding. “You look like you’re thinking yourself into a hole again,” he said. “Don’t do that. Dirt’s hard enough to climb out of.”

Mydei huffed, eyes still on the skyline. “You always talk this much when it’s quiet?”

“Only when someone’s glaring at me like they’re auditioning for a tragic art film.” Phainon leaned his elbows against the railing, gaze turning toward the glinting river. The water caught the city lights in thin, trembling ribbons. “Thing about life is, it don’t care if you’re ready or not. It’ll roll right over you, and you’ll still have to wake up the next day and feed the cat. That’s the secret—keep feeding the cat.”

That got him a faint snort from Mydei.

Phainon continued, softer now. “Well, folks used to say you don’t stop walking just ‘cause the road turns ugly. You patch your tires, you keep going. Sometimes that’s all it takes—keeping steady long enough to see the next bit of sunlight. World don’t get kinder, but you get stronger, y’know?”

A low hum came from Mydei, almost thoughtful. “Stronger,” he repeated, as if testing the word on his tongue.

“Yeah,” Phainon said, smiling faintly. “Even if you’re limping.”

For a while, neither spoke.

Phainon could’ve stayed there for hours. The quiet company, the reflection of city lights in Mydei’s eyes, the way the air finally felt light again after weeks of concrete and chaos—it all fit too comfortably.

Then, his phone buzzed.

He groaned. “You gotta be kidding me,” he muttered, patting his pocket. “Can’t even have one moment without the universe poking me.”

He fished it out, thumb hovering over the screen. The name made him pause.

Cassie:
[Have you seen the new email yet?]

He frowned. “What new email—”

He flicked open his inbox, eyes skimming the latest message. His expression shifted from confusion to mild dread as he read.

———

From: Administrative Office — Okhema Tech

Subject: Division Integration Meeting – Mandatory Attendance

Dear all,

As part of the ongoing Okhema–Kremnos merger completion, all personnel are required to attend the upcoming Division Integration Meeting at Okhema Headquarters, downtown.

Location: *Okhema HQ Conference Hall A*
Date: *Thursday, 4 p.m. sharp*
Purpose:
•*Official announcement of leadership transitions*
•*Introduction of consolidated divisions*
•*Overview of new interdepartmental operations and reporting structures*

This meeting is mandatory for all staff. Further details, including floor assignments and access credentials, will follow in a separate internal memo.

Thank you for your cooperation as we move forward together into this next chapter of Okhema Tech.

— Okhema Administrative Office

———

Phainon clicked his tongue. “Well, that’s one way to ruin a good mood. Sounds like corporate hell in heels.”

Mydei glanced over, eyebrow raised. “The merger meeting?”

“Yeah. Downtown, nine sharp. Guess it’s time for the big song and dance.”

Mydei hummed quietly. “I saw that earlier.”

Phainon blinked. “Oh, right—you’re Kremnos side of things. Means you’ll be there too, huh?”

“Unfortunately.” Mydei’s voice was dry, but his gaze stayed steady on him. After a beat, he added, “Do you want me to drive you?”

Phainon paused mid-scroll. “You what?”

Mydei didn’t look away. “We’re going the same direction. I can pick you up that morning. If you’d like.”

For a second, Phainon just stared, his brain short-circuiting somewhere between *he offered* and *he said if you’d like*. His chest did that ridiculous thing again—thudding harder, uninvited—and before he could stop it, the teasing slipped free.

“Well, I didn’t know you could be so generous,” he drawled. “What’s next, you gonna grab me dinner too? Maybe open the door for me? Careful, Mydei—you keep this up and it’s gonna start sounding like a date.”

Mydei blinked once, deadpan. “…Can it, Hayseed.”

Phainon laughed, loud and unrestrained, the sound rolling out across the quiet riverfront. “There he is. I was getting worried you caught feelings for a minute.”

“Keep talking,” Mydei warned, but the corner of his mouth twitched—just enough to betray him.

Phainon leaned back against the railing, grin lingering.

Maybe this was something worth feeding the cat for.

The first thing Phainon noticed was how quiet it was for a room packed with a hundred people.

Not silent—just that strained, pre-speech sort of quiet that hung in the air like static. The kind of quiet that made the faint click of heels sound like a threat and every polite laugh echo too loudly against the marble.

Even the air-conditioning hummed with restraint, as though it knew better than to interrupt a room full of people pretending to enjoy corporate networking.

Phainon shifted in his seat. The chair gave a small, judgmental creak. His tie was crooked—had been since the second he'd put it on—and his blazer was doing its best impression of "formal" while losing a button battle at the cuffs. Around him: rows of sleek suits, polished watches, lanyards that cost more than his rent. The perfume of ambition and expensive coffee.

And then there was him.

A wrinkle in the otherwise ironed-flat picture.

He tugged at his jacket anyway, like the motion could disguise how out of place he looked. Same jacket he'd worn to his cousin's wedding. Technically also to a court hearing. He was on a streak.

If he were being honest, he still wasn't entirely sure how he'd ended up here.

Well—he did, technically.

A flash of the morning came to him: stepping out of his apartment building, coffee in hand, blinking at the slick black car parked at the curb. The windows were tinted to the kind of black that whispered *classified government operation*. The driver stepped out, immaculate and unbothered, holding the door open like he was guarding royalty.

“Compliments of Mydeimos, sir.”

Phainon had just stared for a good five seconds, waiting for a camera crew to jump out.

Then he laughed. “Of course,” he’d muttered. “Of course you’d send a Batmobile.”

He’d considered texting—*Did you actually send this or am I about to get abducted by tax agents?*—but decided against it.

Rich people probably just did that sort of thing.

So he’d climbed in, sighed at how the leather seat adjusted itself automatically, and tried not to feel too weirdly… disappointed. Mydei had said he’d pick him up himself, but apparently “himself” meant a driver in a three-piece suit. Typical. He hadn’t even had time to roll down the window and complain before they were speeding toward downtown.

Still, it wasn’t all bad. The week had been hectic—Mydei buried in work—but they’d managed to text between meetings, enough that the silence between replies didn’t feel like absence.

So now here he was, in the big glass headquarters that smelled faintly of printer toner and nerves, trying not to yawn himself into unemployment.

At least he wasn’t alone.

“Speech should be starting any minute now,” said a voice to his right.

Phainon turned to find Castorice sitting there—posture immaculate, hair in its usual lavender-grey bun, the picture of composure. Her ID badge hung neatly in placel. She radiated that quiet, efficient energy that made everyone else seem slightly messier by comparison, but Phainon could tell she was just as exhausted and putting on a front so people don’t talk to her.

“Great,” Phainon said. “I was starting to worry I’d have to sit through this alone.”

She asked softly and amused, “No complaints yet about your outfit yet?”

He pressed a hand to his heart. “Hey, this is my formal jacket. I only wear it to weddings and court dates.”

Her laugh was quick and soft but real, enough to earn them a glance from a nearby coworker who clearly hadn’t laughed since the merger announcement.

“You do realize,” she murmured, tilting her head toward the crowd, “half the board’s here today. I even heard some of Kremnos’s top brass flew in.”

Phainon gave a low whistle. “Fancy. Hope they like the existential dread of workers.”

“Mm. I think they prefer cost-cutting,” she replied with a small smile.

He snorted. “Same thing, really.”

Castorice shook her head, amused. “You should at least pretend to care. This merger’s the biggest thing to happen to Okhema in a decade. They’re re-wiring the company.”

“Yeah,” he said, adjusting his tie with exaggerated effort, “and yet somehow I still make the same paycheck.”

She gave him a sidelong glance—sympathetic and grimly in the same boat as him. “Don’t act like you’re not curious who the new management is.”

Phainon hesitated, eyes on the stage as the low murmur of conversation swelled again. “Curious isn’t the word I’d use. More like… cautiously terrified.”

Castorice’s lips twitched. “You and everyone else.”

He smiled faintly but didn’t reply.

Because truthfully, his mind wasn’t on the merger. It kept slipping back—to the texts, the car, the missing presence beside him. He told himself it was

stupid to notice, that Mydei had a life, a job, a billion reasons to be busy. But still. The seat next to him felt too empty. The night had felt too quiet without that smug bastard showing up five minutes early and some dumb comment about “country punctuality.”

He shook himself, straightening in his chair as the lights began to dim.

The projector screen blinked to life, white to black to silver, until the logo spread across the stage wall in sleek letters:

OKHEMA TECHNOLOGIES × CASTRUM KREMNOS
Division Integration Summit

A hush rolled over the auditorium. Phones slipped away, backs straightened, conversations cut off mid-sentence. The stage lights flared, sterile and perfect.

Phainon gave a low whistle, tipping his head toward Castorice. “Speak of the devil,” he said. “Looks like you were right about that speech.”

“Try not to snore through it,” she whispered back, adjusting her blazer.

“No promises.”

He remarked faintly, but as the first executive stepped up to the podium and began their polished introduction, Phainon found his fingers tapping restless against his knee. He wasn’t sure why. The air felt thicker somehow, his shirt collar tighter, like the room itself was holding its breath.

Something told him this wasn’t just another corporate day.

The overhead lights dimmed to a soft amber glow, and the murmur of hundreds of voices settled into expectant silence. The auditorium’s screens flickered awake—Okhema’s logo blooming across the walls, all white and steel blue.

At the center podium, Aglaea adjusted her microphone.

Phainon straightened in his seat before he even realized he was doing it.

He’d been to his fair share of corporate presentations, but Aglaea always managed to make the air feel sharper somehow—clearer. Maybe it was the fact that she’d been the one to pull him out of his old post and into this circus to begin with. Or maybe she was just one of those rare executives who looked like she actually believed in the words coming out of her mouth, though knowing her he doubted it.

“Good afternoon,” she began, her voice carrying easily, every syllable crisp. “It’s a pleasure to welcome you all to Okhema’s Division Integration Summit. Today is quite an important day, a beginning. About what happens when two legacies choose to build something new together.”

A few polite claps rippled through the audience. Cameras flashed. Phainon joined in, slow, rhythmic, as if applause were part of his job description. Beside him, Castorice gave the world’s most efficient three claps, then folded her hands in her lap like she’d trained for it.

“Today,” Aglaea continued, “we celebrate a partnership between Okhema Technologies and Castrum Kremnos—two organizations that have long shared not only a professional history, but a philosophy. We believe in purposeful innovation. In creating systems that outlast us. In a culture where transparency is common.”

The presentation behind her shifted to soft gradients, bold text, buzzwords dressed up in modern font. Phainon squinted up at one of the slides.

‘Driving cross-divisional collaboration.’

‘Leveraging shared infrastructure for scalable growth.’

He could almost hear the corporate drumroll.

“Cross-divisional collaboration,” he muttered under his breath, tasting the words like bad coffee. “Bingo.”

Castorice’s elbow nudged his ribs without her gaze leaving the stage. “Behave,” she whispered.

“I am behaving,” he murmured back. “I’m absorbing the synergy.”

Her lips twitched—barely—but it counted.

Onstage, Aglaea’s rhythm didn’t falter. “This isn’t merely an economic move,” she said. “It’s an investment in people—our engineers, our analysts, our field teams, our partners. We’re shaping not just the technology we use, but the way we connect through it. Because innovation without humanity,” she paused deliberately, letting the weight of the words settle, “isn’t progress at all.”

Another wave of applause. Polite, measured, mechanical.

Phainon clapped again, slower this time. His eyes drifted past the stage lights, to the glass walls beyond the rows of heads—the stars, albeit not much—glinting faintly through. It was too bright in here. Too clean. Every word sounded polished, edited, like something pre-approved by ten departments before leaving anyone’s mouth.

Still, he watched her. Listened enough to catch the tone underneath—the practiced steadiness, the warmth that almost made the buzzwords sound real. Almost.

“We stand on the edge of a decade that will redefine global research and digital ethics,” Aglaea went on. “Our shared goal is simple: not to compete for the fastest innovation, but to cultivate the most meaningful one. Together, we can build a foundation that endures—not just as companies, but as communities.”

That one caught him. He didn’t know why.

Build something that endures.

His thumb brushed over his notepad without realizing it. Maybe it was the phrasing, or maybe it was the fact that his own foundation had been feeling pretty temporary lately—his job, his apartment, the half-empty evenings where he sat talking nonsense on the phone until sunrise. Whatever it was, the words hooked somewhere quiet.

He exhaled through his nose, forced himself back into the room just as Aglaea's final line rose:

"So—to new ideas, to partnership, and to a future we build together."

Applause swelled. Cameras clicked. A few people stood.

Phainon clapped, eyes half-lidded. In his head, the words blurred together—cooperation, partnership, vision, growth—all of it melting into a low hum. He smiled faintly to himself, thinking that if someone ever made a drinking game out of this kind of speech, no one would survive past the third slide.

The intermission announcement followed: ten minutes to stretch, grab coffee, or pretend to network.

Phainon was on his feet before the sentence ended.

Castorice noticed immediately. "You're leaving."

"I'm stepping out," he said. "Air, a break."

"Phainon."

"What? I'll be back before she finishes her next PowerPoint transition."

"You always say that."

"And I'm almost always right."

Her sigh was soft but tired. "Fine. Just don't miss the next presentation. Caenis will have an aneurysm if you're not here when the investors start their questions."

"Tell him I'm out gathering cross-divisional inspiration."

She gave him a look. "Go," she said at last, waving him off. "Before HR sees your tie."

He grinned. “Already on that.”

The corridor outside was blessedly empty. The air cooler, heavier with that faint ozone smell of early fall rain. He passed a few stragglers—people on their phones, a couple of assistants whispering by the elevators—but didn’t stop. He wanted open air.

The doors opened with a faint creeks

The city rushed in.

Chicago stretched wide and gleaming, the water cutting silver through the blocks below. Wind sliced past the glass railings, tugging at his sleeves, ruffling his hair. He loosened his tie all the way, draped it around his neck like a casualty. His shoulders unknotted for the first time that morning.

He leaned on the railing, staring out over the sprawl of rooftops and traffic. From up here, everything looked calm—motion slowed by distance, the noise muffled into something like rhythm.

“Five minutes,” he muttered to himself. “Just five minutes without the word ‘innovation.’”

Somewhere below, someone laughed. A trumpet wailed faintly from the street corner. The sound bounced up between the buildings like sunlight on glass.

He closed his eyes briefly, breathed in the cold air. It almost felt like quiet. Almost.

Then he turned.

And paused.

Because a few feet away, framed by the terrace glass, stood a figure that made his brain stutter before the rest of him caught up.

Blond hair—longer now, caught by the wind. Hands tucked into the pockets of a tailored coat. The same posture, the same half-cocked tilt of the head that screamed *too composed for his own good.*

That stupidly familiar mane.

Phainon's mouth curved before he could stop it.

"Well," he breathed, smile tugging wider. "I'll be damned."

He whistled low as he stepped out, hands in his pockets.

"Fancy running into you here," he drawled, voice carrying lazily through the dark.

Mydei didn't answer right away. He stood at the edge of the terrace, city light gilding the sharp line of his jaw, the wind teasing his hair like it knew him. There was a stillness about him, something distant.

Phainon took his time walking over, smile tugging at the corner of his mouth. "You know," he said, stopping beside him, "when people say they'll pick someone up, they usually mean *personally*. Not by proxy."

That earned the faintest curve of Mydei's lips. "And yet, here you are."

"Didn't want your driver to feel unloved."

"Always thinking of others," Mydei murmured dryly.

"Especially the ones with good air conditioning."

It drew a quiet exhale from Mydei, almost a laugh, and Phainon felt that ridiculous flutter in his chest again. He leaned forward against the railing, shoulder to shoulder now, close enough to catch the scent of Mydei's cologne—clean, subtle, maddening.

It wasn't until then that he noticed the cigarette, unlit, balanced between Mydei's fingers.

When Phainon’s gaze flicked to it, Mydei followed his eyes, then wordlessly flicked the cigarette away. The motion was casual, thoughtless.

But it hit Phainon harder than it should have.

“You didn’t even light it,” he said.

“I wasn’t going to.”

“You *always* do.”

“I changed my mind.”

The words were simple, but something in the quiet between them felt more personal than it should have. Phainon cleared his throat, looking for something—*anything*—to fill it.

“You’re too calm,” he said finally. “Everyone else in there looks like they’re about to get audited.”

“That’s because they probably will.”

Phainon laughed. “God, you’re terrible.”

“I’m realistic.”

“You’re *annoying* is what you are.”

“Coming from you, I’ll take that as a compliment.”

Their laughter blended into the wind. For a moment, it was easy—too easy.

Phainon looked at him again, really looked this time: the faint glow brushing the slope of his cheekbone, the careful way he stood like even gravity needed his permission. Controlled. Contained. Unreachable.

The kind of person you shouldn’t want but end up orbiting anyway.

“You ever think,” Phainon said suddenly, “that maybe we’re all just pretending we have any idea what we’re doing?”

Mydei turned slightly, brow lifting. “Random but sure. You mean you don’t?”

“I fake it pretty well,” Phainon said, half-laughing. “You’re the only one I can’t bullshit.”

“I’ll take that as a compliment too.”

“You shouldn’t.”

“I just did.”

Their eyes met briefly, and Phainon had to look away before he said something stupid. His heart was doing that dumb thing again—racing like it wanted out.

The silence that followed wasn’t empty; it was charged, almost humming.

“I like being around you,” Phainon said quietly.

Mydei didn’t look at him. “Why’s that?”

“Don’t know,” Phainon said, gaze fixed on the sky. “You make me feel less cold.”

That got him a glance. Mydei’s eyes softened just slightly, like the words had landed somewhere he didn’t expect.

“You make it sound simple,” he said eventually, quietly.

“Maybe it is,” Phainon murmured, a smile tugging at his mouth. “Not everything has to be complicated.”

“You’d be surprised.”

“Try me.”

There was a pause—long enough for the air between them to change.

Mydei turned fully toward him now, one hand resting loosely on the railing, the other brushing close enough that Phainon could feel the heat of it near his sleeve.

“My life doesn’t allow for simple things,” Mydei said quietly. “They tend to get… broken.”

“Then maybe you’re holding them wrong.”

That made Mydei laugh softly, the sound low and quiet and *god, unfair.*

Phainon smiled at the sound, but his heart was going wild. “Sometimes,” he said, barely above a whisper, “I think if I’m gonna put my whole heart into someone, it oughta be someone who won’t drop it.”

Mydei’s eyes flicked to his. “You’d risk that?”

Phainon shrugged, though his voice was steadier than he felt. “Guess it depends who’s catching.”

The noise blurred into nothing. All that was left was the wind and the faint, almost audible rhythm of his pulse.

Mydei took a small step forward. The distance between them thinned to inches—close enough for Phainon to feel the warmth of his breath.

“You shouldn’t say things like that,” Mydei murmured, but his voice had gone soft at the edges.

“Why not?”

“Because I might believe you.”

And that was it. That was the breaking point.

Neither of them moved first; they just leaned, caught somewhere between instinct and gravity, until Mydei’s hand brushed Phainon’s sleeve—gentle,

questioning—and Phainon didn’t pull back.

The air felt electric, delicate, waiting to shatter.

Then—

Mydei leaned in, slow enough to feel every inch of tension drawn between them, until his lips brushed Phainon’s—barely, and *softly*.

Warm. Careful. Dizzying.

The world outside kept spinning, but for one suspended heartbeat, Phainon swore the everything had gone silent—just lights, wind, and the taste of something he hadn’t realized he’d been waiting for.

For a dizzy second or two, Phainon didn’t move.

The world seemed to go still—the hum of the city below, the faint clatter of traffic, even the wind against his coat—all of it dulled into a low, ringing hush. His brain was trying to catch up with what his body already knew: *Mydei was kissing him.*

And God, he tasted exactly how Phainon imagined he would—cool air, sweet, something faintly like pomegranates, the kind of taste that lingered.

Then he snapped.

The thought never formed; his body just moved. One second his hands were at his sides, the next he’d fisted the front of Mydei’s coat, dragging him close with unfiltered, reckless need.

Mydei made a sound—half gasp, half swallowed word—before Phainon’s mouth found his again, rougher this time, no second-guessing or hesitation.

This wasn’t polite. It wasn’t measured. It was *hungry*.

Phainon kissed like he meant it—like a man who’d been holding something back for years and finally let it out. He pressed Mydei back against the terrace wall, the railing just brushing his hip, his free hand sliding to his

waist to tilt him forward, deepening the kiss until the line between air and heat blurred.

Mydei's hands came up reflexively—one gripping Phainon's arm, the other hovering at his chest, unsure whether to pull him closer or push him away. But the hesitation broke the second Phainon made a low, involuntary sound against his mouth.

That sound did it.

Mydei's fingers slid up, wrapping behind Phainon's neck, drawing him closer, deeper. The motion was shaky but genuine, the kind of surrender that burned slow. His control slipped in increments—first the way his head tilted to meet him halfway, then the soft, startled exhale against Phainon's cheek when he realized he wanted it just as badly.

The space between them disappeared.

Phainon's pulse roared in his ears, his whole chest aching with how alive it felt—how *warm*. His thumb brushed the edge of Mydei's jaw, feeling the tremor that ran through him, and something about it—the contrast, the fact that *this* man who never lost his composure was trembling under his touch—made him smile mid-kiss, just a small breath of a laugh.

"Hell," he murmured against Mydei's lips, voice rough and fond, "you really do know how to shut me up."

Mydei's soft, helpless laugh broke against his mouth, and Phainon thought for one wild second that this could be it—the kind of moment that rewires everything.

He kissed him again, slower now, the urgency melting into something deep, dizzying. The city light glinted off the glass behind them, painting them in streaks of amber and blue. It was just them—the skyline, the wind, the warmth of another person's breath mixing with his own.

It felt like something *good*.

Mydei’s hand slid up the back of Phainon’s neck, fingertips pressing lightly into his skin. But the longer they stayed, the more the tension returned—small things at first, almost imperceptible. The stiffness of his shoulders. The faltering rhythm of his breath. The way his fingers curled like they were fighting between holding on and letting go.

Phainon noticed, barely—just enough for a flicker of confusion to pass through him before—

A sound.

Small. Barely there. The terrace door creaked from the draft.

Mydei froze.

He went still all at once, every trace of warmth gone from his touch. Phainon felt it before he understood it—the sudden distance, the absence of motion. Mydei’s lips parted against his, breath shuddering once before he pulled away like he’d been burned.

“Mydei—”

The word slipped out on instinct, but Mydei had already stepped back. His expression was unreadable, pale under the city light, his chest rising too fast, eyes darting anywhere but Phainon’s.

“Hey,” Phainon said, voice rough, breath still uneven. He took a hesitant step forward. “What’s wrong? You—did I do something—?”

“I—” Mydei’s voice caught. He tried again, quieter. “I can’t.”

“Can’t what?” Phainon’s laugh came out thin, strained. “Can’t breathe? Yeah, me neither—”

“Phainon.” Mydei said his name like it hurt. Just one word, but it landed sharp. He shook his head, exhaled shakily. “I’m sorry. I have to go.”

“Wait, what do you—Mydei, hold on—” Phainon reached out, catching nothing but air as Mydei turned. “Can we just—talk for a second? You

don’t have to—”

But the door opened before he could finish. The slam that followed wasn’t loud, but it cut clean through the air like a line drawn in concrete.

Then silence.

For a few seconds, Phainon just stood there, still half-leaning forward, hand hanging where he’d reached out. The wind pressed cold against his skin, filling the space Mydei had just been standing in. His breath came too fast, too shallow.

He looked down at his hands, still trembling faintly, and it almost made him laugh—the absurdity of it, of feeling this warm.

The night went on around him. The cars below, the low rumble of engines, the heartbeat of the city.

He stayed there long enough for the cold to settle in his jacket, for the buzz of his pulse to fade into something quieter, duller.

When he finally exhaled, it came out uneven, like he’d forgotten how to breathe right.

The railing where Mydei had been pressed against still held the faint scent of his cologne.

Phainon stared at it for a moment, and for some reason, that—more than anything—was what finally made his chest ache.

When the world stitched itself back together, it did so under fluorescent lights.

The air inside was too bright, too clean, too indifferent to what had just happened. The conference hall hummed with the quiet chaos of people returning from smoke breaks and hallway gossip. The smell of catered wine and carpet cleaner mixed in the air. Somewhere across the room, a laugh

came a beat too loud, a glass clinked, and life—stubborn as ever—kept moving.

Phainon hadn't moved since sitting back down.

Same chair. Same half-untucked shirt. Same damn tie that suddenly felt like it had shrunk a size. His name badge hung crooked against his chest like it was mocking him.

On the big screen, the company promo reel kept looping—city hotspots, drone shots, smiling employees shaking hands like the world was a perfectly reasonable place to be in. The music swelled triumphantly for the fifth time in ten minutes.

Phainon stared straight ahead, eyes glassy. His brain, however, refused to cooperate.

It kept replaying *that*. The warmth of Mydei's mouth, the press of his hands, the quick, stunned breath they'd shared before the world tilted and crashed. The way the door had sounded when it shut.

He wanted to stop thinking about it. God, he wanted to. But his mind kept spinning the same loop like a scratched record.

I ruined it. He probably hates me. Hell, maybe he ain't even gay—

The thought hit hard enough he dragged a hand down his face, as if he could physically scrape it off. His palm came away warm. His cheeks were hotter than they should've been.

Get it together. You're a man, damn it. Don't cry. Be better.

That last part didn't sound like him. It sounded like his dad. Or his uncle. Or every old-timer from back home who thought stoicism was a survival skill.

He let out a quiet, humorless laugh under his breath. *Yeah, that's right. Be a man. Pretend your heart didn't just nosedive off a roof.*

He sat up straighter, squared his shoulders, tugged at his cuff. Just another guy in a conference hall. Just fine. Perfectly fine.

“Hey.”

The voice beside him was soft. Castorice had finally returned to her seat, the faint smell of her lilac perfume cutting through the stale recycled air. She was smoothing down her skirt, phone tucked between her fingers, before she turned toward him with that gentle frown that meant she actually cared.

“You don’t look so good.”

Phainon blinked, caught between confusion and gratitude that someone noticed. “I’m peachy.”

Her brows lifted slightly. “You sure? You look a little—well.” She hesitated, choosing a word. “Un-peachy.”

That pulled the ghost of a smile out of him. “Nah. Just thinking about how lucky I am to work for such an inspiring company.”

Castorice huffed a small laugh. “That bad, huh?”

“Oh, worse. But you missed the best part,” he said, nodding toward the stage. “Apparently we’re getting new parking passes. Game changer.”

Her eyes brightened. “See? There’s always a silver lining.”

He forced another smile. It almost held this time.

Around them, the chatter began to fade as people drifted back to their seats. Chairs scraped against the floor, the lights dimmed just slightly, and the air settled into that pre-speech hush again.

At the front, Aglaea reappeared—perfect posture, calm smile, half-full glass of wine in hand. She looked like she’d never been rattled a day in her life.

“Alright, everyone,” she began, voice smooth as ever. “Let’s pick up where we left off.”

The room quieted completely. Phones flipped facedown. All eyes turned forward.

Phainon did too, mostly because it was easier than looking anywhere else.

He folded his hands, stared at the stage lights, and let the motion of it all blur—the hum of the AC, the clink of glass, the polite laughter a few rows up. Somewhere, buried under it all, was the phantom memory of a kiss.

His throat ached, but he sat up straighter anyway.

Because that’s what a Midwestern boy does. He doesn’t fall apart under fluorescent lights. He just smiles, nods, and keeps pretending everything’s fine.

And under those too-bright, too-honest lights, that’s exactly what Phainon did.

“Thank you all for your patience,” she began, one hand resting gracefully on the podium. “I know it’s been a long evening, but I promise this last part will make it worth your while.”

Polite laughter rippled through the audience, the practiced, cordial kind that didn’t reach anyone’s eyes.

Phainon managed a faint smile. His jaw hurt from holding it that way. He tried to focus, eyes fixed on the sleek conference stage, but his pulse still hadn’t settled. Keep it together, he told himself. Just a few more minutes.

Keepittogetherkeepittogetherkeepittogether.

Aglaea moved seamlessly into her next cue, voice gliding through phrases that sounded important—*synergy, integration, growth, mutual trust*. The projector behind her rolled through carefully curated slides: a glossy Okhema logo alongside another—*Kremnos*.

He blinked at it, brain stuttering half a beat behind.

“—and as many of you already know,” Aglaea continued, “this merger marks the beginning of a shared vision. Together, Okhema and Kremnos are paving the way for a more connected, sustainable future.”

Applause spread politely across the room.

Phainon clapped too, his palms stinging, the motion mechanical. The sound barely registered in his ears.

Keep it together. Just keep breathing.

Aglaea smiled, composed as ever, her earrings catching the light. “It’s my absolute pleasure now to introduce the person who made this partnership possible. His leadership, innovation, and commitment to collaboration have truly shaped this moment.”

Another pause.

Her hand lifted toward the side of the stage.

“Please join me in welcoming the CEO of Kremnos.”

The room shifted at once—chairs scraping softly, a murmur of anticipation. Someone raised their phone. Someone else whispered, *“Finally.”*

Phainon glanced toward the stage, only half paying attention. Just a formality, he thought. He didn’t even care who it was.

Then movement caught his eye.

A man stepped into the light.

He was tall—his shoulders framed perfectly by the sharp cut of a charcoal-gray suit that looked like it cost more than Phainon’s car. The stage lights hit polished shoes, a tie with the faint sheen of silk, cufflinks catching a gleam of silver. His hand lifted in a modest, almost reluctant wave, expression composed but not cold.

The applause swelled.

Phainon’s chest tightened. He didn’t know why at first. Maybe it was the way the man carried himself—not stiff, not cocky, just sure. Or maybe it was the voice, low and even, thanking Aglaea, thanking the audience, talking about partnership and innovation and moving forward.

That voice.

He blinked hard. The lights made it difficult to see clearly, but—

Then the man angled slightly toward the crowd, his profile catching the glow.

Blonde hair, neatly combed back. Strong jawline. Familiar curve of a smile that wasn’t quite one.

No.

No, no, no—

His heart lurched violently, thudding once before forgetting its rhythm altogether.

The rest of the room blurred out. He barely felt the chair beneath him, the glass in his hand, the air in his lungs.

Because standing under those sterile, spotless lights, addressing the audience like he hadn’t just kissed him breathless on a rooftop hours ago—

Was *Mydeimos*.

Phainon’s blood drained clean out of his face. His fingers went numb. The applause sounded far away now, warped, like it was happening underwater.

Aglaea’s voice cut faintly through it all, still smiling. “And we are so grateful to have him here tonight. Mydeimos, everyone.”

There it was—confirmation, like the universe felt the need to twist the knife.

He couldn't even process the words Mydeimos was saying. Something about innovation, long-term vision, partnership. He saw his lips move, calm and confident, and all he could hear was silence. His mind filled the space instead—with memory. The press of his mouth. The sound of the door closing.

When he finally blinked, Mydeimos' eyes were on the crowd—but then, just for a moment, they found him.

It was brief. Barely a second. But Phainon knew it wasn't an accident.

That look—steady, unreadable, almost pained—hit harder than any word could've.

His stomach turned. The air was too hot, too thin.

He turned sharply toward Castorice.

"Castorice."

She didn't hear him over the applause.

He said it again, louder, his voice raw. "Castorice."

Her head jerked toward him, startled. "What? What's—"

"Get me out of here." The words came out low and rough, all the steadiness gone. "Now."

Something in his tone—whatever cracked through—made her move without asking questions.

"Oh—okay," she said softly, already gathering her purse, concern flickering across her face. She rose and touched his arm, steadying him as he stood. He barely felt it.

They slipped toward the aisle quietly, their movement lost beneath the applause that followed Mydeimos’ closing line. Each clap echoed sharp and hollow in Phainon’s ears.

Halfway to the doors, he looked back—just once.

Mydeimos was still onstage, shaking hands, smiling faintly for the cameras. But his eyes—his eyes—found Phainon again through the crowd.

Phainon looked away first.

And as the applause swelled again, he pushed through the doors, the sound chasing him out into the hall.

Chapter End Notes

Boo, angst, though not too angsty actually so YIPPYYYY!!!!

Chapter 7: A Field Guide to Mydei and Phainon, By Two (Five) Men Who Should Not Be Writing One

Chapter Summary

> Phainon's forced transfer lands him directly under Mydei's leadership, which is terrible for one simple reason: feelings. After a week of Olympic-level avoidance, a surprise rainstorm and a shared umbrella soften the tension just long enough for a certain someone(s) to stage the most obvious matchmaking trap in recorded history.
>
> Communication happens; dignity does not.

Chapter Notes

> Finally finished this up!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

If optimism were taxable, Monday mornings would fund the entire city.

The sun was shining, the birds were chirping, and the Windy City was alive with promise. The skyline glittered like ambition, commuters hustled with purpose, and even the pigeons strutted like they had quarterly goals to meet. A new week! A new chance to thrive! The kind of morning that made you believe in employee wellness programs, five-year plans, and the transformative power of a really good LinkedIn post.

Or so the brochure probably said. In full color. With a stock photo of people high-fiving around a salad.

Reality, however, had a much smaller marketing budget. The wind didn't "whisper through the streets"—it *punched* them, slapping a damp newspaper against a passing intern's leg and toppling an iced drink onto someone's loafers. The sky was technically blue, yes, but only in that

“somewhere-above-the-clouds” sort of way. Down at street level, the day was already overworked and underpaid.

And at precisely 8:00 a.m., in the cafeteria of Castrum Kremnos Headquarters, Phainon was doing his best to pretend this was all part of a promising new chapter.

Okhema’s old breakroom machine had sputtered out coffee that tasted like resignation and toner fumes. Kremnos, though—Kremnos had *baristas*. Polished counters, abstract art, ambient jazz that felt like it was judging your posture, and espresso shots so curated they could qualify for museum display.

Espresso shots, Phainon decided grimly, that tasted like debt.

He stood in line, the hem of his slightly wrinkled blazer refusing to cooperate, his old ID badge still hanging there like a tag from a clearance rack: **OKHEMA DIVISION TRANSFER ASSOCIATE**. He was supposed to get a new one soon, but apparently *“sometime this week”* in laymen terms meant *“don’t hold your breath.”*

Behind him, someone whispered, “Oh, merger transfer?” in the same tone you’d reserve for *“infectious rash.”*

He ignored it, eyes climbing the price board ahead of him. Ten dollars for a donut. *Ten*.

Did it come with a certificate of authenticity? Was there a down payment option?

Kremnos people moved differently—like they were late to a yacht meeting or a Pilates retreat. They had designer shoes, charcoal travel mugs, and a collective aura that said, *I actually enjoy networking.* Phainon shifted his weight, glancing down at his own boots. They had mileage. Character. Possibly dust from three zip codes ago.

He slapped his cheeks lightly, earning a few confused stares. Whatever. He was exhausted. Half the reason he was still upright was pure stubbornness.

His parents always said not to let the world's mood become yours, but right now, the world was tired, overpriced, and smelled faintly of sanitizer.

"Next!"

The barista greeted him with a refined smile so professional it could've been part of the uniform.

"Good morning, sir. What can I get started for you today?"

He tried to sound confident. "Uh… just, uh, normal coffee."

"One moment," she said, scanning the screen. "Would that be drip, pour-over, or cold immersion single-origin?"

He hesitated. "…The one that costs less."

That earned a micro-expression—something between pity and understanding. "Of course. That'll be ready in about five minutes."

"Thanks."

Transaction complete. He stepped aside as the next customer—a guy in an immaculate coat and the confidence of generational wealth—ordered something that sounded like a chemistry equation.

Phainon found a seat at one of the polished chrome tables near the window and sat down, elbows resting against the reflective surface. He wasn't even pretending to check his phone. He just stared, half-awake, watching the parade of shoes march by.

The place gleamed with ambition. Every sound—the hiss of steam, the faint clink of cups—felt like a reminder that he was now very much fucked.

Folks like him built fences.

Folks like them bought the land.

A match made in heaven, truly.

No wonder he was working here now.

He scrolled aimlessly through his inbox, thumb flicking through unread messages like it was a nervous tic. Half of them were from Kremnos HR—links to onboarding portals, cheery reminders about “integrating with our family,” and training modules that featured actors with unsettling eye contact. The other half were ghosts from Okhema—*Re: Re: Re: Q3 Updates (FINAL FINAL), Workflow Review 2.1, Team Appreciation Lunch RSVP (Mandatory)*—each one a fossil of better or at least simpler days.

He leaned back in his chair, the cafeteria’s chrome light glinting off the unread count climbing into the hundreds, until one name caught his eye in the sender column.

Caenis.

Of course.

It had all been fine and dandy after the merger. The big bosses had called it “a strategic alignment,” which everyone else correctly interpreted as “half of you will be unemployed by December.” Okhema staff had survived the transition mostly intact. There’d been meetings, rebranding, slightly different email signatures. The free snacks disappeared. The coffee somehow got worse.

Still, Phainon was managing.

Never mind the slow erosion of his mental health—or the quiet ache for a certain someone he’d promised himself not to think about. The new reporting system only crashed three times a week, his supervisor mostly ignored him, and no one had yelled at him in two full weeks. In office terms, that was practically a honeymoon phase.

Which was, naturally, the moment Caenis decided to transfer him out.

She hadn’t sent a formal email about it at first—she’d stopped by his desk in person, which was already a red flag. Caenis was the kind of woman who scheduled *everything*, including smiles. When she appeared unannounced,

perfume the and ghost of a childhood sadness arrived ten seconds before her actual body, Phainon knew something was coming.

“Phainon,” she’d said, voice smooth as butter. “Can you come by my office later? Just ten minutes.”

“Sure,” he’d replied, already mentally writing his own obituary.

Her office, later that day, looked like a furniture catalog and smelled faintly of lavender disinfectant. She sat behind her desk like a queen behind her throne, hands folded neatly over a stack of papers she absolutely didn’t need.

“You’ve been selected,” she began, smile so sharp it could’ve filed patents, “to help Kremnos understand Okhema’s work culture. You’ll be our bridge between divisions.”

Phainon had nodded slowly, pretending to consider it. “Bridge, huh? Do I get a raise if someone decides to burn it?”

She didn’t laugh—just that tight, managerial smirk that meant she’d heard a joke and filed it under *unhelpful commentary.*

“It’s a good opportunity,” she said. “You’ll be representing our branch. Kremnos values initiative, and I think this will be a great fit for you.”

Translation: *Get the hell out of my office and take your weird little energy elsewhere.*

He’d tried to match her tone, sitting a bit straighter. “Of course, I’m happy to contribute.”

“Excellent. You’ll start next week. I’ve already put in the request with HR.”

“That fast?”

“Transition periods are smoother when people don’t overthink them,” she said, still smiling.

He’d smiled back. “Right. Wouldn’t want to clutter up the process with feelings.”

She tilted her head, that predatory kind of amusement flickering for a moment. “Exactly.”

By the time he’d left her office, the move was already finalized. Kremnos HQ. “Cultural integration role.” No raise, no warning, and definitely no choice.

He had nodded through it like he didn’t understand the underlying message. Said all the polite, grateful stuff. *“Of course, I’m happy to contribute.” “That sounds like an honor.” “Thank you for trusting me with this opportunity.”*

What he meant was: *Please, for the love of God, let me keep my dental plan.*

He’d known it wasn’t random. Caenis didn’t do random. She’d seen him that day with Mydei. He *had* noticed that after the incident, she’d looked at him differently. Too polite. The kind of nice that came wrapped around a knife.

Guess she figured he’d fit right in up here.

“Order for Phainon!”

He blinked out of the memory and stood up, grabbing his coffee from the counter.

“That’s me.”

He took a sip, grimaced at the bitterness, and smiled anyway.

What a joke.

A week in, and Phainon still wasn’t sure what exactly his job was. He’d finished all the onboarding videos, survived three icebreakers, and spent two days shadowing a guy named Theo who said *“touch base”* every

second. His official title was Process *Integration Assistant*, which translated to: guy who updates spreadsheets nobody reads.

Every morning he told himself he was getting the hang of it. Every afternoon he proved himself wrong.

His cubicle—technically “a modular workspace,” according to Facilities—was wedged between a potted plant that looked perpetually on the brink and a printer that look wheezed like it had asthma. The walls were half-glass, half-fabric, designed for “collaboration” but perfect for hearing other people’s phone calls. Dual monitors blazed in front of him, both full of tabso he couldn’t remember opening. His Teams chat kept pinging with polite anarchy: people asking questions they could’ve answered themselves, project links leading to nowhere, a string of “welcome aboard!” messages he hadn’t known how to respond to.

Theo—his so-called mentor—had explained the job on day two with the confidence of a man who no longer remembered what his own position entailed. “You’ll be doing light integration cleanup. You know, low-stakes stuff. No pressure.” Which turned out to mean hours of reconciling duplicate entries from Okhema’s ancient systems with Kremnos’s overengineered new ones. It was like being a translator for two dialects of Excel that hated each other.

“Don’t worry,” Theo had said that morning, leaning against the cubicle wall with his third cup of coffee. “After a few weeks, it’ll click.”

Phainon had smiled. “What will?”

Theo had blinked. “You know… it.”

Lunch had come and gone, though he couldn’t really claim he’d eaten. He’d stared at the cafeteria board until everything started to blur—wraps, power bowls, something labeled *Harvest Medley*—and ended up settling for that one cup of coffee that somehow managed to taste both bitter and burnt.

Now, break time. Officially. Unofficially, the point of the day where everyone tried to act relaxed but still checked their notifications every thirty

seconds. Most of his coworkers had already clustered into polite little circles, balancing biodegradable forks and conversation starters: *“You settling in okay?”, “Did you see the new branding deck?”* That sort of thing.

He didn’t feel like joining. The lounge was too loud, too open, too full of people who seemed to know how to perform friendliness in front of cameras.

So instead, he slipped his ID badge into his pocket and started walking.

The hallways at Kremnos HQ were sleek in that curated, minimalist way that made everything feel temporary. Glass walls everywhere, every surface polished to a quiet gleam. The floor plan was a maze of “collaboration zones” with names like *Horizon* and *Nexus*, each outfitted with couches nobody sat on. A digital sign scrolled updates about corporate wellness initiatives—something about mindfulness sessions on Thursdays, sponsored by a vendor whose name sounded suspiciously like a drug.

Phainon passed a small group near the espresso bar—someone from HR, a designer, and a man he vaguely recognized from a town-hall slideshow. They were mid-discussion about “streamlining inter-branch communication.”

“Half our emails get lost in translation,” the designer was saying.

“Between departments or languages?” the HR rep asked.

“Both.”

He kept walking.

It wasn’t that he hated it here. The place ran on order—cold, deliberate order—but there was a strange comfort in that. Things worked. The lights always came on, the air smelled faintly of perfume, and the coffee, while questionable, was consistent. He could adapt to that.

Still, every few steps, he caught himself scanning for exits, half-expecting someone to tap his shoulder and tell him there’d been a mistake.

The elevator was somewhere past the next glass corner. Or maybe two corners. Every hallway looked the same, like it had been designed by a committee that feared individuality.

As he walked, he told himself—again—that he was adjusting. That maybe next week, he’d stop double-checking every email before hitting send. That he’d figure out what “process integration” meant in practice. That he’d stop overthinking the pauses when people said his name like they weren’t sure it was his.

He was fine. Mostly.

And even if he wasn’t, he could fake it for another hour. Optimism, he decided, was just another task on the checklist. Something you renewed before it expired.

He straightened his badge and kept walking toward the elevator.

Phainon pressed the button and leaned against the wall, thumb worrying the corner of his badge. The little circle lit up blue, promising arrival sometime before retirement.

“Alright,” he muttered, “this is fine. You’re fine.”

He said it again, slower, softer, like maybe the words would sound truer if he gave them time to sink in.

He’d been through worse. Plenty worse.

He’d survived the Great Server Meltdown back at Okhema, the one where a week’s worth of data vanished because some intern unplugged the main router to charge their phone. He’d made it through four budget cuts, two audits, and that one all-hands meeting where the CFO cried halfway through the slides.

Before that—Missouri. He'd scraped ice off the inside of a farmhouse window in January, fixed a carburetor in the rain, and spent twelve hours herding cattle across a county line because someone forgot to lock the damn gate.

So no, a slow elevator and a few too many spreadsheets weren't about to break him.

"Hell, you've got health insurance now," he told his reflection in the metal trim, voice tilting almost cheerful. "Can't scare me with a few slides and a temperamental management."

The elevator light stayed stubbornly still. He sighed and tapped his badge against his chest, thinking that if he stared long enough, maybe it'd take pity on him.

"You've got this, Phainon," he said, firmer this time. "You're adapting. You got a desk, a decent chair, a… uh, Theo. You got direct deposit. That's right. Every two weeks like clockwork. Look at you—living the dream."

He almost smiled. Almost.

He'd landed in Chicago with two suitcases, a dying plant, and a savings account that wheezed every time rent was due. But he'd found his footing, mostly. He could navigate the trains without pulling up three maps. He'd stopped saying *y'all* every third word in meetings—well, mostly.

"Progress," he told himself, nodding like it was official company policy.

Finally, the elevator dinged—a small, merciful sound.

"See?" he said, grinning as the doors slid open. "You stick it out long enough, life throws you a bone. An empty elevator. That's a win right there."

He stepped inside, shoulders loosening, optimism gathering itself for one last push. "That's right. Nothing to it. You've got this. Nothing, and I mean *nothing*, can stop you now."

He pressed his floor number. The button glowed a pleasant gold.

And right as he allowed himself that one small, earned breath of peace—

“Hold the door, please!”

The voice carried down the hall, quick and apologetic, shoes scuffing against tile.

Phainon’s eyes closed briefly. He sighed, the kind that came from somewhere deep, then stuck his hand between the doors before they could seal.

“’Course,” he muttered, still polite, still that good-natured steadiness his parents raised into him. “Would’ve been too easy otherwise.”

The elevator paused obediently. Phainon straightened his tie, expression settling back into its practiced calm.

“Alright,” he said under his breath, to the ceiling this time. “You can handle this too.”

The numbers above the door waited, glowing patiently.

Phainon plastered on a polite smile and called out, “No need to rush, I got it!”

It came out too cheerful—like he was auditioning for *Employee of the Month*—but fine. He could commit to the bit. Might as well.

Everything was alright.

Everything.

He said that, didn’t he?

He’d had worse.

God, he’d *had* worse.

He’d survived his upstairs neighbor’s month-long country music marathon (same three songs, same volume, all night). He’d figured out how to use the train without getting lost more than twice, survived a team-building retreat in Wisconsin that ended in a collective group cry, and even managed not to combust when his first paycheck bounced the same week his sister’s tuition was due.

He’d gotten through all of that. He could get through *anything*.

He was an adult. He paid taxes. He owned three identical button-ups and a microwave that only caught on fire once. He couldn’t keep falling apart over minor inconveniences.

“See?” he murmured, shoulders straightening as he waited by the elevator. “You’re okay. You’re okay. You’re—”

He paused, let out a breath, nodded at his reflection in the polished steel. “Alright, champ,” he told himself quietly. “Let’s take it easy today. No overthinking. No emotional breakdowns in public hallways. You got this.”

Everything was fine.

Perfectly fine.

Totally fine.

Which, naturally, is when the universe decided to test that theory.

He heard the echo of quick footsteps down the corridor—the brisk, businesslike kind that screamed “late for a meeting” and “probably important.” Phainon smiled faintly, the kind of automatic, polite curve of the mouth you gave coworkers in passing. He reached to hold the door—

“Thank—”

The voice hit him first.

Familiar. Calm. Just a little deeper than memory had kept it.

Then came the pause.

And the heartbeat that followed it.

Phainon looked up.

The world didn't *stop*, exactly—it just went still in that quiet, cruel way a dream does right before it turns on you.

Because of course.

Of course.

Standing there, perfectly real and perfectly impossible, was the man he had maybe—*probably*—cried about on the phone with Stelle.

Stelle, who'd listened without interrupting while he rambled about fate and bad timing and "how the hell was I supposed to know he's the goddamn CEO?" Stelle, who'd told him, "You're living in a Wattpad story, babe," and then, softer, "You're an idiot, but I love you."

The man he'd kissed.

The man who'd left.

No goodbye. No reason.

And Phainon had told himself it didn't matter. That Mydei had his reasons. That maybe there was a world where CEOs disappeared mid-sentence because of work emergencies or divine intervention or—hell, he didn't know. Anything was easier than believing it meant something.

But now—standing here, with light spilling harsh across polished marble floors—it mattered. Because Mydei was right there.

And he looked *good*.

Unfairly, cosmically good.

Binder in one hand, jacket folded over his arm, stride purposeful and steady. His sleeves rolled up, his tie loosened just enough to look human, and that faint frown—focused, impatient, utterly him. He looked like the kind of man who never lost his footing. Who never had to.

And Phainon hated how his heart leapt anyway.

“Thank y—” Mydei started again, looking up mid-step.

Their eyes met.

A breath.

Then another.

Two full seconds of recognition stretching far too long.

“…” Phainon said, eloquently.

“...” Mydei retorted, smartly.

Oh.

That was it—the flicker. Surprise, dawning understanding, and then that quiet, horrified *oh no* as the pieces clicked together in his head.

And through it all, Phainon’s smile didn’t move.

“Morning,” he said pleasantly, voice steady in that way only a man on the brink could manage.

Mydei opened his mouth—maybe to apologize, maybe to explain—but Phainon was already moving. His thumb found the “close doors” button with the singular conviction of a man choosing flight over fight. He pressed it once. Then again. Then several more times in what could only be described as moral panic disguised as composure.

“Wait—!”

Mydei’s binder hit the floor with a slap of scattered paper as he lunged forward. It wasn’t even graceful—he just *ran* for it, one hand outstretched like pure instinct had taken over.

DING.

The doors slid shut in his face.

The soft, soulless hum of elevator music filled the silence.

Phainon stared at the floor numbers blinking slowly upward. Inhale. Exhale. A polite, tight smile tugged at his mouth—the kind that said, *I’m fine. This is fine. Nothing’s on fire.*

Three floors passed like that.

At the fourth, the doors opened with a gentle chime. A chipper intern stepped in, coffee in hand, eyes bright. “Morning!”

Phainon didn’t move. “Mm,” he managed, still staring straight ahead like a hostage in a wellness ad.

The elevator hummed on.

Everything was fine.

That was what he kept telling himself anyway. It sounded better than “mostly functional.”

Phainon gripped his visitor badge a little too tight as the security gate hiccuped, buzzed, and tried to eat his ID. He tugged it free with a smile that barely qualified as polite.

“Welcome aboard, Phainon!” chirped the receptionist—bright, terrifyingly awake, and far too sincere for eight-thirty.

She remembered his name. Out of everyone walking through those glass doors, *his.*

Not reassuring at all.

“Thanks,” he said, a little flat. “Trying not to make a mess yet.”

Her laugh followed him past the lobby, light and genuine. It shouldn’t have stung, but it did.

Kremnos HQ was a maze pretending to be a building, every hallway identical, every surface too clean to feel real. Who designed this place—Sisyphus, with a grudge?

You’d think he’d know his way around by now.

He really should’ve.

But the universe—or maybe middle management—had a sense of humor. Someone was *always* asking him to deliver something to the other side of the building. Always across, never next door. If the company wanted to boost efficiency, they could start by issuing maps or hiring a sherpa.

Still, it was almost nostalgic. Almost.

Like his first weeks at Okhema—back when getting lost felt like an accident, not a pattern.

He got lost three times before lunch.

First: wandered into an HR wellness seminar. Someone pressed a stress ball into his hand and told him to “breathe through the tension.” He didn’t have the heart to say the tension had tenure.

Second: dead-ended into what he thought was a hallway but turned out to be a very convincing pane of glass. He stood there a beat too long, palm stinging, before muttering, “Jesus, you people really do love your glass.”

Third: wrong turn into a *C-Suite Strategy Briefing.* Twenty executives looked up in perfect synchrony. He froze mid-step, raised his coffee in silent apology, and backed out like a raccoon realizing it had wandered into daylight.

After that, he stuck to the stairwells. At least concrete didn’t lie.

By the time he finally found his department again, his phone was littered with three missed messages, two “where are you” pings, and one cheerful calendar invite titled *Orientation Follow-Up (Optional 😊).*

He dropped into his chair, exhaled, and stared at his monitor until his reflection blurred into the screen’s glare. Then he smiled.

The only real difference between this and his old routine at Okhema was that now he had to work a little harder to avoid a certain someone who knew he worked here.

Not that hard, right?

He could do that.

He could absolutely, definitely, without question do that.

Right.

Phainon had learned early that ignoring things was a legitimate workplace skill. The trick was to look busy enough that no one questioned your silence.

Like right now.

Two desks over, the kind of gossip that never actually stayed quiet drifted through the air.

“It’s just me, or has Mydei—ahem, boss—been moody again lately?”

“Moody?” someone snorted softly. “He’s not sleeping much. I saw him in at six this morning. Man’s got the kind of dark circles that scream existential crisis.”

“Didn’t something happen at that merger meeting?”

Phainon took a measured sip of water and pretended to scroll. The paper cup gave a brittle pop between his fingers.

“Wouldn’t know a thing about that,” he murmured, mostly to the water cooler, and dropped the cup in the bin before he could shred it completely.

He told himself it didn’t sting. He was fine. He was *functioning*. He even smiled when people talked to him. See? Thriving.

His coworkers were a treat.

“I love your accent!” someone chirped later that morning, eyes bright with that particular brand of curiosity that felt like touching glass with bare hands.

Phainon exhaled through his nose. “Thanks,” he said lightly, even though every muscle in his face wanted to fold in on itself.

“Oh, you’re from Okhema, right? Must’ve been… fun.”

“That must’ve been quite the adjustment for you.”

He nodded, smiled the practiced kind of smile that said *please stop before I start crying or laughing*, and quietly re-organized a file he’d already submitted. The sound of keyboard clacks made for decent white noise, at least.

It hadn’t taken long to figure out Mydei’s routine. Corporate calendars were an open secret, and people had a way of dropping details when they thought you weren’t listening.

So he built a system. Something neat and efficient—on paper.

Coffee breaks: two minutes after Mydei’s, assuming he actually took those.

Elevators: avoided entirely; stairwells didn’t ask questions.

Hallways: mapped to minimize risk.

Conference rooms: occasional hiding spots, though explaining why he was “reviewing acoustics” got awkward fast.

For a few days, it worked. The universe almost seemed merciful.

But every so often, he’d glance across the atrium or into a glass corridor and catch sight of someone—tall, coat slightly rumpled, binder tucked under one arm—pausing mid-stride. Searching, maybe. Looking around like he’d lost something he didn’t want to admit he had.

If Phainon didn’t know better, he’d swear Mydei was looking for him.

Not directly. Never directly. But there was a rhythm to it—the half-turn when a door opened, the distracted nods in meetings, the faint crease between Mydei’s brows when his gaze swept past a crowd and didn’t find what he wanted.

Yeah. No. Definitely was.

Which was exactly why Phainon doubled down on his escape artistry. If he moved fast enough, ducked at the right time, stayed just behind the reflective glare of glass, maybe he could pretend none of this existed.

By the time he collapsed back into his cubicle chair, the fabric squeaking in complaint, he let out a sigh that sounded suspiciously like surrender. He slumped until only his eyes cleared the top of the desk divider.

The screen’s glow reflected him faintly—rumpled tie, tired face, the picture of composure if you squinted hard enough.

Another day done.

Another day survived.

And for now, that was as close to peace as he was going to get.

His phone buzzed against the desk.

Phainon ignored it at first, chin propped on one hand, staring at the writing that had long since stopped making sense. Whoever it was could survive five more seconds without him.

Then it buzzed again—longer this time, stubborn.

He groaned, dragging himself upright, every vertebra in his back cracking like the soundtrack of defeat. The screen glared up at him, far too bright for someone whose soul had already clocked out for the day.

Unknown number. No—wait. Not unknown.

He blinked, leaning closer.

Dan Heng.

Oh.

Well, that was new.

His bad mood loosened, like the day suddenly remembered how to breathe again. It had been months since they'd talked properly—long enough that he'd half-assumed the archivist had gone off the grid again to dig through some forgotten library or commune with a stack of ancient scrolls.

Funny thing, how they even met. He had Caelus to thank—or blame—for that. The man somehow managed to be unemployed and cosmopolitan at the same time, drifting through Europe until one day he stumbled into March and Dan Heng somewhere in the U.K. (because of course he did). March had been photographing some cathedral, Dan Heng was there for research, and Caelus—well, Caelus was there because he "followed the cheap flight."

One weird afternoon turned into a week of pub food and train hopping, and when Caelus finally wandered back home to Missouri, the friendship stuck. March and Dan Heng started visiting whenever they passed through the States, which meant Phainon eventually got pulled into the chaos too—Stelle and Caelus made sure of it.

Dan Heng had always been the calmest of them. The kind of calm that didn’t come from stillness but from quiet focus—like he could fit whole worlds into a sentence if he wanted to.

So yeah, seeing *his* name flash across the screen now… it did something funny to Phainon’s chest.

He scrubbed a hand over his face, half-smiling despite himself. “Of course it’s you,” he muttered. “Time zones don’t exist, do they?”

He swiped to answer. “Hello?”

Dan Heng was calling. Which, in Phainon’s world, meant one of two things: either the man had a question only the universe’s most obscure database could answer, or he just wanted to check in.

And somehow, the latter always caught him more off-guard.

The line clicked.

“Hello?”

“Dan Heng!” Phainon straightened automatically, grin breaking across his face before he could stop it. “Man, it’s been forever since we actually called each other.”

A quiet laugh. “It has. I was starting to think you forgot what my voice sounded like.”

“Please,” Phainon said, leaning back in his chair, “you think I’d forget that sleep-deprived poet tone of yours?”

“I’ll take that as a compliment,” Dan Heng replied, perfectly even—though Phainon could practically hear the smile hiding behind it.

“Yeah, yeah. How’ve you been anyway? Last I heard you were in—wait, was it Spain? Or that train museum in France? The one where you nearly got locked inside?”

“Switzerland,” Dan Heng corrected. “But yes, I stopped in France for a day. The archives there are… quiet. You can hear the wind moving through the cracks in the stone.”

Phainon huffed out a laugh. “Only you could make a drafty hallway sound poetic.”

“You’d change your mind if a stack of parchment fell on your head.”

He snorted. “Yeah, well, that’s what you get for touching things older than my grandpa.”

Dan Heng made a soft, amused sound. For a moment it felt like they were back on the couch in Stelle’s apartment again, several years ago, arguing about whose thesis was better.

“So,” Phainon said, the grin returning to his voice, “what’s the special occasion? Lost a bet? Got lonely? Or are you secretly dying and this is your final call to me?”

“Actually,” Dan Heng said, tone gentling, “I just wanted to see how you’re doing. March had mentioned you transferred departments.”

Phainon groaned, letting his head fall back against the chair. “Of course she did.”

“You settling in?”

“Trying,” he said, rubbing the back of his neck. “Building’s bigger than my hometown.”

“That’s not saying much, Phainon.”

“You’re right,” he admitted, smiling. “I’m being generous.”

That earned him another quiet laugh.

They slipped into easy chatter again—the kind that filled the quiet without needing to mean much. Dan Heng talked about train rides across Europe,

the way the dawn light cut across the windows, the steady rhythm of the tracks beneath him.

“I swear,” Dan Heng said. “it’s the only time the world feels balanced. Just motion and air and no reason to rush anywhere.”

“Sounds peaceful,” Phainon murmured.

“It is. But it’s strange.” A pause. “The more places you go, the more you start missing people instead.”

Phainon stared at the ceiling tiles, listening to the hum of the office beyond the cubicle walls. “Yeah,” he said softly. “Ain’t that a bitch.”

There was a long beat before Dan Heng spoke again, tone deceptively light. “Speaking of people—are you seeing anyone lately?”

Phainon blinked. “That’s a hell of a topic change.”

“I’m making conversation.”

“Uh-huh.” He pushed off from the desk, chair rolling a few inches. “Let me guess. March—or *Cyrene*, said something again.”

“I might have heard a few things.”

“Oh, for—of course you did.” Phainon dragged a hand down his face. “What was it this time? That I’m being dramatic again? In denial? That I cried to an Adele song?”

“‘Phainon’s pretending he’s not still hung up,’” Dan Heng quoted smoothly.

Phainon groaned so loud it echoed. “Lord help me if I end up falling for this man twice.”

Silence—then the quietest smile in Dan Heng’s voice.

“…You already did, didn’t you?”

“Go to hell, Dan Heng.”

“Geographically speaking,” he said mildly, “I might already be close.”

Phainon laughed despite himself, pressing a hand over his mouth. “You’re the worst.”

“And yet,” Dan Heng said, gentle as ever, “you still answer when I call.”

“Yeah,” Phainon admitted after a moment, voice softer now, the grin lingering even as it faded at the edges. “Guess I do.”

For a while neither of them spoke. The hum of static filled the silence—easy, comfortable, familiar. Phainon spun his chair once, the world blurring around him, before letting it drift to a stop.

In hindsight, he really should’ve seen this coming.

Especially after *that* conversation.

What conversation, you ask?

Well. Picture this: mid-afternoon at Castrum Kremnos HQ—the lull where people either scroll through docs pretending to work or stand in front of the fridge pretending to think. Phainon was doing the latter, except he wasn’t even pretending. He was just hiding.

He had one hand on the fridge handle, reading the same yogurt label for the third time, when the door swung open behind him. Two voices filtered in, that easy, clipped cadence of people who’ve survived too many meetings together and are now bonded through corporate trauma.

The first voice—impossible to mistake.

Ptolemy.

Loud, charming, the human equivalent of a LinkedIn post that actually gets engagement. Phainon had met him months ago at the mingling event, right

before the whole “car ride with Mydei” fiasco. He’d hoped never to see him again.

The second voice was smoother, calm with a faint Balkan lilt. It had the practiced neutrality of someone who spent more time in airports than at home. He caught the name a second later.

“Leonnius,” Ptolemy said, somewhere near the espresso machine.

Right. *That* guy.

If Phainon had to guess, Leonnius was one of those diplomats—title vague, influence terrifying. The kind of man who could sit through a seven-hour negotiation without a single hair moving out of place.

“—He’s been miserable for weeks,” Ptolemy was saying, voice bouncing off the glass tiles. “You’d think someone ran over his cat.”

Leonnius didn’t miss a beat. “He doesn’t own a cat.”

“Exactly! That’s the problem. No emotional outlet. He’s haunting the office like a man one sad song away from writing a manifesto.”

The sound of a spoon clinking against a mug. “He drinks chamomile like it’s whiskey,” Leonnius added, dry as copy paper.

“God, yes. And that *stare*.” Ptolemy let out a theatrical sigh. “You ever see a grown man look that tragic before noon? I started apologizing before I even knew what for.”

Phainon blinked.

He didn’t know who they were talking about, but he had the sinking feeling he was about to.

“Apparently,” Leonnius went on, “it’s all over some… Phainon, was it? Guy?”

Phainon nearly dropped the yogurt.

He froze, half crouched, the refrigerator light glaring on his face like a spotlight. “Different Phainon,” he muttered to himself. “Common name. Happens all the time. Statistically possible.”

Ptolemy snorted. “Phainon? That’s not even remotely common. You ever met another Phainon, Leo?”

“Not personally,” Leonnius admitted, “but I’ve read one in a myth. Does that count?”

“Not really. Theo, maybe. Even an Alex. But Phainon? C’mon.”

Phainon mouthed a soundless *oh my god* to the dairy section.

“I remember Mydei mentioned something,” Leonnius said thoughtfully. “A falling out, perhaps. He didn’t elaborate. Just stared at the window like he was composing an elegy.”

“Classic,” Ptolemy muttered. “He’s got work, friends, actual things to do. But no—let’s brood by the window like an unpaid intern in a perfume ad.”

“You’re assuming he hasn’t written poetry about it.”

“…Has he?”

“I wouldn’t know,” Leonnius said in a tone that absolutely meant he did. He stirred his coffee with deliberate calm. “But if he starts quoting tragic verse at lunch again, I’m staging an intervention.”

Phainon’s stomach sank. *Again?*

That meant it already happened. Which meant they weren’t exaggerating.

“Oh, you’d love that,” Ptolemy laughed. “Standing there like, ‘Mydei, you are loved, but please stop reciting Sappho to the salad bar.’”

Leonnius made a dignified noise. “You’re mocking me, but it worked last time. Temporarily.”

“I’m not mocking, I’m admiring the commitment,” Ptolemy said. “But seriously—man’s in deep. Over some Phainon, no less.”

“Who,” Leonnius said mildly, “may or may not work here.”

Phainon went very still.

Ptolemy perked up. “Wait, that’s right! Didn’t I see that name in an internal memo last week? Something about an onboarding in the Kremnos division?”

He paused suddenly, tilting his head. “Could be coincidence, though.”

“Yeah, and I’m the CEO.”

“Traveling might’ve scrambled your memory again,” Ptomely said, taking a slow sip. “You really shouldn’t do six time zones in a week.”

“I’ll have you know I’m sharp as ever.”

“Of course,” Ptomely said smoothly. “Sharp as a butter knife.”

“Ha-ha. You know, some of us still have functioning brains.”

“Functioning? Debatable.”

Their banter trailed toward the door, still trading half-sincere insults as they left. The sound of the automatic lock clicking behind them was almost merciful.

Phainon straightened slowly, staring at his reflection in the stainless steel fridge.

“…Yeah,” he muttered, setting the yogurt back. “Should’ve seen that coming.”

And that, as it turned out, was the beginning of the end.

For whatever reason, afternoons at Castrum Kremnos had a way of testing one’s commitment to employment.

The air-conditioning always dipped too low after three. The lights buzzed faintly. Emails multiplied like they’d been left unsupervised. It was the hour when the soul grew tired before the body did.

So really, it shouldn’t have surprised Phainon that the next memorable event in his day was, apparently, an *intervention*.

It began innocently enough.

He was heading toward the elevators, rubbing the growing ache at the bridge of his nose and mentally negotiating with himself about whether he had the stamina for one more budget review, when someone called out behind him.

“Hey—you’re that transfer, right?”

Phainon turned. Halfway through putting on his polite corporate face, he found himself looking at two men who radiated the kind of practiced competence that came from surviving years of corporate trench warfare.

The first was tall, dark-haired, and wore a suit that somehow managed to look both expensive and lived-in—like he’d been in ten meetings already and still had energy for ten more. His smile was smooth, confident, and the kind that made people instinctively like him.

“Hephaestion,” he said, offering a firm handshake. “Corporate Strategy. Welcome to the circus.”

Phainon shook it. “Phainon. Accounting.”

The second man stepped forward with considerably less enthusiasm. Shorter, broader shouldered, with a relaxed slouch and headphones hanging around his neck like an accessory he forgot to take off.

“Peucesta,” he said. “AV and Cultural Operations.”

Which, based on his tone, translated to: *I fix broken projectors, manage sound systems for events, and tolerate everything else.*

Hephaestion's smile only widened. "We've been meaning to say hi. Transfers usually get a whole welcome packet and a tour, but I think HR misplaced you in the system."

"Wouldn't be the first time something ate my name," Phainon said, amused. "Still appreciate the effort."

"Oh, trust me, we're professionals," Hephaestion said. "Castrum Kremnos has a reputation for being a maze. Half the departments don't even know each other exist. You'd think they designed it this way on purpose."

"Would explain the staircases," Phainon mused. "Every day feels like a obstacle course."

Hephaestion tapped his temple. "That's the spirit. Only the strong survive."

Peucesta snorted quietly. "You're making it sound like a cult again."

Hephaestion glanced at him, utterly unfazed. "Only a friendly one. We have snacks."

Phainon cracked a smile despite his fatigue. These two were…oddly refreshing.

Conversation drifted easily after that—commutes, cafeteria food ("edible, but only in theory"), which departments were secretly gremlins, which ones held grudges. Peucesta chimed in occasionally with the dry comments of a man who'd seen too much malfunctioning equipment to be impressed by anything.

Phainon relaxed. They weren't pushy. They weren't intense. They weren't —

"Heard you made quite an impression on our CEO."

Oh.

There it was.

Phainon blinked once. “Pardon?”

Hephaestion’s smile didn’t falter, but there was a spark there—amused, perceptive. “Mydei. People talk, you know.”

Peucesta didn’t even pretend to be invested. “He says that to everyone,” he told Phainon, sipping from a mug. “Don’t let it get to you.”

Phainon stared at him, expression politely blank in the way that absolutely screamed: *it has already gotten to me.*

“Anyway,” Hephaestion continued breezily, “we were heading to lunch. Figured we’d bring you along. It’s practically tradition to make sure transfers don’t eat alone on their first month.”

There was no graceful way to decline without sounding rude, so Phainon followed—reluctantly, but resigned.

They took the elevator up to the 27th floor, where the “Client Hospitality Dining Room” lived. Technically not an executive cafeteria, but it might as well have been: quiet, polished, soft lighting, furniture that whispered fancy.

The moment they sat, the interrogation began.

“So,” Hephaestion said lightly, swirling his fork through his salad, “how do you feel about jazz?”

Phainon stared. “Jazz?”

“Any kind,” Hephaestion said. “Smooth, big band, fusion—very atmospheric genre.”

Peucesta lifted his eyes to the ceiling with the weariness of someone who had lived through this conversation at least five times. “Hephaestion, subtlety.”

“This is subtle,” Hephaestion insisted.

“No,” Peucesta said flatly. “It’s not.”

Phainon tried a polite smile. “Is this… some kind of survey?”

“Of course not,” Hephaestion said, much too quickly. “Though—speaking of scenery—have you been up to the 32nd floor garden yet? Spectacular spot. Very private. Great for… conversations.”

Phainon set his fork down and gave him a leveled stare.

“You boys takin’ a survey or matchmaking?”

Hephaestion didn’t blink. “Why not both?”

Peucesta sighed, long-suffering. “This is why HR blocks your emails.”

“It’s called team morale,” Hephaestion said, entirely unbothered. “Some of us care about fostering connection.”

“Some of us should be supervised,” Peucesta muttered.

Phainon groaned and let his head fall briefly into his hands. A tired laugh escaped him. “Lord, just smite me next time.”

He straightened, wiped any visible despair from his expression, and managed a strained smile. “Pardon me, but I think I’ll take my lunch to go.”

Hephaestion’s face fell, halfway into a protest—

—but Peucesta, moving with the resigned reflexes of someone who had done this before, calmly reached over and clapped a hand across Hephaestion’s mouth.

“We get it,” Peucesta said, muffled but comprehensible. “See you around.”

Phainon nodded, gathered his tray, and escaped with all the speed and dignity of a man fleeing an emotional ambush.

He didn’t slow down until he reached the glass doors at the end of the hall. Sunlight caught the floor, too bright after the dim dining room. He checked the time.

5:30.

“Figures,” he muttered.

Maybe a walk would help—air, distance, a little space to unclench his soul after whatever that lunch had been.

If divine smiting wasn’t available, fresh air would have to do.

Funnily enough, the sky had that flat, heavy look it got right before the clouds decided to punish everyone at once. Phainon noticed it the moment he stepped out of Castrum Kremnos’ revolving doors—still spinning a hair too fast, still threatening to smack someone’s backpack straight into traffic if they weren’t paying attention. He escaped without incident today, badge intact, dignity mostly intact, and he’d made it a full two minutes down the street with the illusion that maybe—just maybe—the universe had clocked out with him.

Then, inevitably, the universe remembered it had his number.

A cold drop hit the back of his neck. Another on his shoulder. Then a whole constellation of them.

“…Of course,” he muttered, staring up as the drizzle thickened into rain that meant business. “Sure. Why not. Was overdue anyway.”

Umbrella? Absolutely not. He’d left it at home in a rare burst of optimism. Jacket? In his locker. And he was not—under any circumstances—spending fifteen hard-earned dollars at the kiosk on the corner for something that looked like it would disintegrate the moment wind touched it.

He breathed in slowly, the kind of long inhale grown adults take when they’ve run out of creative swear words.

“Well,” he said to no one, “ain’t nothing rain can do that someone else hasn’t already tried.”

He rolled his shoulders back, braced himself, and stepped forward—

fwip.

An umbrella opened above his head.

Phainon jerked like it was thunder cracking right over him.

For half a second—one small, desperately human second—his chest loosened. Someone being kind. Someone stepping in. After a week that felt like getting sanded down on all emotional fronts, the tiny gesture hit him harder than it should’ve. His throat tightened. He blinked quickly, trying not to look like a man on the verge of crying over a piece of nylon fabric.

He turned, words already spilling out in relief.

“Thank y—”

They fell apart the moment he saw who it was.

Mydei stood there.

If the universe was throwing punches, this one was straight to the gut.

Rain slid along Mydei’s collarbone, sank into the loosened knot of his tie, clung to the rolled sleeves of his dress shirt. His hair was damp, not quite disheveled, but definitely far from the immaculate CEO look Phainon expected. He looked like a man who had walked out of a boardroom, down twenty flights of stairs, and straight into the storm without stopping long enough to breathe.

He also looked like a man who had not exhaled properly since the night everything had gone to hell.

“…You’ll catch a cold,” Mydei said softly.

Phainon blinked at him. Once. Twice. Slowly. His face barely moved, but something in him bristled.

“You’ll catch trouble if anyone sees you talking to me,” he answered, tone flat but not quite gentle. Not quite angry either—just tired. Depleted. The kind of tired that wasn’t from lack of sleep but from too much everything.

Rain filled the silence between them, soft and steady.

Mydei’s grip on the umbrella tightened. “I didn’t know you were… here,” he tried, voice quiet, like he was starting a conversation in a library instead of a storm. “At Kremnos , I mean. They didn’t tell me about the transfer list for the merger until last week and I—well. I figured you’d still be at Okhema.”

It wasn’t exactly small talk, but it wasn’t a justification either—just him reaching, clumsily, for anything Phainon might take.

Phainon let out a dry exhale that could’ve been a laugh if it had any strength left. “Didn’t plan to advertise it. Figured you had a company to run.” A beat. “And a panic button to hit, apparently.”

That hit. Mydei’s jaw twitched; he swallowed once, sharp and visible.

“I panicked,” he admitted. “That night. I know how it looked. I know it was —” His voice cracked, just barely. “It’s not an excuse.”

Phainon looked away, toward the reflections wobbling in the puddles on the street.

“I’d normally listen,” he said, quieter now. “But I’m real tired. And I just wanna go home before this rain decides to baptize me.”

Mydei’s expression softened, pained but not dramatic. He understood.

“Hell of a way to start a merger,” Phainon added, tone dry as the street wasn’t.

Mydei flinched like someone had tugged a string in his spine.

Then he breathed in, steadied himself, and said, “At least let me walk you. Wherever you’re going next.”

“Walking me out’s exactly the problem, ain’t it?” Phainon muttered. But there was less bite now, more weary honesty.

“Please.”

One word. Sincere in a way Mydei rarely allowed himself to be.

Phainon closed his eyes for half a second. Then sighed—the kind of sigh that sagged from bone to boots. He wasn’t strong enough right now to fight someone genuinely trying.

“…Fine.” He lifted one hand and gestured vaguely ahead. “I’m heading to the stop on Fourth. It’s close. Don’t panic—I’m not makin’ you trail me across the whole city.”

He started walking, deliberately not looking at Mydei.

Which, of course, meant he saw everything in his peripheral vision.

The way Mydei’s posture brightened, subtle but impossible to miss. The way his shoulders lifted just slightly, almost like a cat whose ears perked at its name. The way he had to catch himself from stepping too quickly to keep up, smoothing the motion into something normal.

It was almost cute.

Almost.

“Of course,” Mydei murmured, falling into step beside him. And without hesitation, he angled the umbrella to cover Phainon. Rain clung to Mydei’s exposed shoulder, but he didn’t even blink.

Phainon said nothing.

He didn’t need to.

The rain softened around them—not stopping, but easing into something gentler, as if the city had decided to give them five minutes of grace.

They fell into step the cautious way people did when they weren't sure who was following whose lead. The umbrella forced them a little closer than either would've chosen, shoulder to shoulder whenever the sidewalk narrowed, their steps syncing only because the alternative was bumping elbows every three seconds.

Neon signs blurred like watercolor behind the wet air. Cars hissed by in the distance. It wasn't awkward. Not yet. But it wasn't comfortable either.

Mydei kept glancing over—quick, guilty peeks, never longer than a heartbeat. Phainon counted the fifth one before sighing through his nose.

"Most folks," he muttered, "tend to look forward when they're walking. Helps keep the hospitals empty."

Mydei's face turned pink so fast Phainon almost forgot he was irritated.

"Yes, I know," he said. "I was making sure you weren't freezing."

Phainon side-eyed him. "Mydei, I grew up in a place where the wind'll take your hat and your dignity in one blow. I'll survive a drizzle."

"That doesn't answer the question."

"It wasn't a question."

"…Well, it felt like one."

A reluctant huff escaped Phainon—not quite a laugh, but close.

They turned onto a quieter street where puddles shimmered under yellow streetlamps. Mydei angled the umbrella toward him again, which forced his own sleeve into the rain. Phainon noticed, and irritation tugged at him—not angry, but tired, the kind of tired that came from months of not knowing where he stood with someone.

“You ain’t gotta do that,” he said. “I’m not gonna shrivel up because my shoulder gets wet.”

Mydei’s mouth twitched, not quite a smile. “I know. But it’s rude to offer someone shelter and then hog it.”

“That ain’t shelter. That’s you holding an umbrella like it’s a peace treaty.”

“A peace treaty implies we were at war.”

Phainon snorted. “We kinda were.”

That shut Mydei up.

Phainon shoved his hands in his pockets, fighting the sting of frustration rising up again.

He kissed me, he ran, he’s my damn CEO, and now he’s here playin’ umbrella escort like this ain’t complicated as hell.

He tamped the thought down before it showed on his face.

“You know,” he said after a moment, “you don’t gotta walk me home. I’m a big boy. Been walkin’ in storms since I was eight.”

“I know.”

“So why’re you still here?”

Mydei hesitated—visibly, audibly, almost painfully.

“…Because I didn’t want you walking alone in the rain.”

Phainon’s jaw clenched. Not because it was a bad answer—not because it was untrue—but because it was too *gentle*, too careful, too close to everything he’d been trying not to think about.

He didn’t respond.

They walked the last block like that: Mydei quietly attentive; Phainon pretending he wasn’t noticing.

The street split at a wide corner. One path toward Phainon’s stop; the other back toward the business district. Phainon stopped beneath a dim streetlight, water dripping from the brim of the umbrella.

Mydei stopped with him, instinctively.

“Well,” Phainon said, rubbing the back of his neck, “this is me.” His voice came out rougher than he meant. “Thanks for the—uh—overhead protection. And, I dunno. The company, I guess.”

“Anytime,” Mydei said.

Phainon tried a smile. It wobbled like a bad table leg.

“Right. Well. Have a good evening.”

He stepped back.

Mydei reacted without thinking—his hand caught Phainon’s wrist. Warm. Surprising. Firm enough that Phainon froze, heartbeat lurching like someone had kicked it out of rhythm.

Mydei seemed to realize what he’d done a second too late; he released him instantly, clearing his throat, fingers flexing once in apology. Then he held out the umbrella handle.

“Take it.”

Phainon blinked at him. “You’re wetter than I am.”

“It’s fine.”

“Mydei, your shirt is plastered to you like you’re auditionin’ for a sad music video.”

“My walk’s close.”

“You’re still—”

“Yes,” Mydei cut in, “I’m still giving it to you.” He nudged the handle toward him. “Return it when you can.”

Phainon opened his mouth to protest. He wasn’t sure if he was more annoyed or more touched, and either way he didn’t want it to show. But Mydei didn’t give him the chance—he placed the umbrella into Phainon’s hand, wrapped his fingers around the handle with a careful, deliberate press of his palm, and stepped back with a nod.

“Good evening, Phainon.”

Before Phainon could respond—before he could decide whether to say thank you or ask him why the hell he cared so much—Mydei turned and walked away.

Phainon stood at the corner, soaked and staring after him, the umbrella limp in his hand.

“…He really just—” He tipped his head back, letting out a tired, breathless laugh. “Damn sneaky bastard.”

Later—hours later, after dripping his way into his place and shaking off the night—he noticed the initials lightly carved into the wooden handle.

It wasn’t fancy. Wasn’t even intentional, probably. Just his name.

But it was enough.

Just an excuse to see him again.

The bar looked like it had already put one boot in bed.

Most of the lights had been dimmed to that warm, syrupy amber that clung to the wooden beams and made shadows stretch slow across the floor. The jukebox hummed low, a lazy old thing refusing to fully quiet down, and

every table had its chairs flipped upside down—every table except the one in Phainon’s corner.

Cipher had left that one alone for him. Whether it was pity or poor judgment was anyone’s guess.

The fryer clicked as it cooled, the sound sharp in the otherwise settled hush, and a mop bucket sat forgotten in the corner from when Cipher decided she’d “handle that later.” She never did.

And on that one lonely chair sat Phainon, hunched forward like he was trying to fold himself in half and disappear.

His elbow dug into the varnished counter, cheek mashed into his palm. The cocktail in front of him had gone mostly water, ice floating like it had given up a long time ago. He stared at it with the single-minded misery of a man who absolutely did not need another drink but desperately wanted one.

A low mutter escaped him—half sigh, half complaint, all pitiful.

Cipher caught it instantly.

She was only a couple feet away, wiping foggy glasses with the smooth, practiced rhythm of someone who’d survived far too many closing shifts. Her bracelets clinked together in light metallic ticks, and her tailored suit jacket shifted as she leaned one hip against the bar, giving him a stare sharp enough to cut.

“Lord above, you are just a picture,” she drawled, amusement sliding warm under her tone. “What’re you even doing, Deliverer boy? Tryingvto win the award for Most Dramatic Man Alive?”

She tapped his glass with a fingernail—once, twice—as if checking for signs of life.

Phainon didn’t lift his head. Just groaned deeper into his palm, voice muffled.

“Cipherrrr. What do I doooo…”

“You stop mopin’ in my bar like a kicked possum, that’s what.” She swapped glasses, slung a towel over her shoulder. “Mercy. You’re gay as hell, sugar, it ain’t that complicated.”

He made a wounded grunt, the kind he’d probably deny making later. “I am not—well—I mean—that’s not—okay but—”

Cipher flicked a hand, dismissive, tolerant, fond.

“Hush. You like him. Big shocker. Men that pretty turn all of us stupid sooner or later. Nature’s never been kind in that department.”

She shelved another glass. Her tone settled into that soft scolding she reserved for stray dogs and men who didn’t know what to do with their feelings.

“And don’t you dare act like you ain’t been pacin’ around here all evening like you’re halfway through writin’ sad country lyrics. You came because you needed to vent. Lucky for you, I’m a generous woman.”

“Are you?” Phainon muttered, barely lifting his eyes.

“Debatable,” she said breezily. “But I let you in after hours, didn’t I?”

He gave a small grunt—a grunt that carried mild gratitude, mild skepticism, and mild suffering all smashed into one sound.

Cipher leaned her hip harder into the counter, squinting at him like she was debating whether to shake him or hug him. She eventually settled for neither, plucking his glass away instead.

He immediately reached for the bottle.

“Nope.” She smacked his hand with a practiced crack. “Yeah, no. You’re cut off ’fore you start crying on my counter. Got enough stains I regret.”

Phainon groaned again, dragging his fingers down his face. “You’re cruel.”

“Mm-hm. I sleep fine.” She propped her hands on the counter and looked him over. “And now real talk—how in the hell did you not know who he was?”

That sliced straight through the fog.

Phainon’s head snapped up, eyes wide. “Wait—what?”

Cipher raised a brow like this was common knowledge.

“Boy works half the business circles I deal with. Hell, we were at the same university for a hot minute.”

Phainon choked, coughed, slammed a fist to his chest like he’d swallowed a shard of glass. “You—you WHAT—”

“Sit still,” she said, already turning away. “Gettin’ you some water before you pass out on my shoes.”

“That’s—not—Cipher, hold on—what do you mean you were—”

“Well how else you think I know him?” she called, rummaging for a clean glass. “Ain’t like handsome men rain from the damn ceiling.”

Phainon opened his mouth, ready to argue, but the thought tangled up on itself and stalled.

Because—actually—that tracked. All of it. The weird timeline, the Massachusetts comments, the short-lived dropout period she never explained, the sudden return years later with two degrees and a smug grin. It… made sense.

Too much sense.

Cipher slid the water toward him and rested her arms on the counter, posture loose, almost contemplative. When she spoke again, her voice dipped quieter—not sad, just reflecting something she rarely let anyone see.

“I didn’t finish at the time,” she said, thumb running over a faint scratch in the bar. “Life got… complicated.” A short huff of breath. “Went back a few years ago—you remember that. Got my degrees proper.”

Phainon did remember. He remembered her calling him, breathless and triumphant. He remembered how proud he’d been, even now, drunk and miserable.

Cipher tapped the counter, the click steady and sure.

“Hospitality, consumer psych… little marketing tricks. Enough to make grown men empty their wallets if I smile right.”

Her voice kept drifting—half to him, half to herself—as she wiped at spots that weren’t there.

“Anyway—it ain’t a story worth fussin’ over. Met your man in one of those elective seminars. Logistics or somethin’. Quiet, mature boy, smart as hell.” She waved a hand lightly. “Now, if you’ll allow me, I’ll recount our exact meetin’ in exquisite detail, loverboy. It started when—”

Phainon blinked.

Her voice softened at the edges, curling in that familiar Southern cadence she didn’t use as much anymore. Somewhere between the alcohol, the dim lighting, and the warmth in her tone, everything blurred.

Her accent wasn’t nearly as thick as when he first met her.

He hadn’t noticed the change until now.

What a strange thing to realize.

Phainon stared at her, glassy-eyed, as Cipher continued on—completely unaware she’d lost him to memory and liquor both.

Phainon wasn’t sure if he was getting sentimental, or if the whiskey had finally decided to wring his heart out like a dish rag. Either way, something

loosened in him—just enough for old memories to start peeling up around the edges, curling back like wallpaper in a humid room.

His head dipped onto his folded arms. A low sound—half sigh, half growl—slipped out before he could stop it.

“Why’s it always you I end up cryin’ to,” he muttered, voice thick and muffled by the crook of his elbow.

Cipher didn’t even pause wiping the bar. “Because you ain’t got an ounce of pride left in you once you’re drunk.”

He made a noise that could’ve been a laugh or a wounded cough.

“And,” she continued, flicking a crumb into her palm, “because I don’t let you run off and do somethin’ stupid.”

“Well,” he said, dragging the word, “that’s kind of you.”

“I’m an angel,” she deadpanned.

“Mm.”

She snorted—light, dismissive, fond. No judgment, no pressure. Just the quiet hum of the closed bar around them and the low amber lighting pooling on their faces.

And maybe it was the warmth, or the silence, or the fact his guard was already slipping—but his thoughts drifted toward her again. Not Cipher as she was now—propped on one hip, plenty of attitude, lecturing him about hydration—but the Cipher he’d met years ago—or more accurately—pieced together. A story made out of scraps she’d dropped accidentally or let slip when she was tired, when her walls had hairline cracks in them.

He remembered the first time she’d mentioned her birthplace. New Orleans. Some tight-knit Greek neighborhood tucked between tourist traps and trouble. She’d talked about it the way old folks talked about their favorite church pew—familiar, frayed, and stubbornly theirs.

Her parents were gone by the time she could remember anything clearly. Car wreck, storm damage—she switched explanations depending on who she was talking to and how nosy they were being. What mattered was simple: she refused to get swept into foster care, refused to be taken from her block, from the people who fed her more often than they lectured her.

So she survived the only way a kid in that kind of place could.

Quick fingers, quicker eyes.

Small cons, small lies.

Charm used like a bottle cap, flicked open whenever she needed something.

Phainon found himself smiling—crooked, reluctant, but warm.

Cipher glanced over. “What’re you smilin’ at, beefcake?”

“Somethin’ dumb,” he murmured.

“You think about plenty dumb things.”

“Appreciate the reminder, sweetheart.”

She pointed her towel at him. “Call me sweetheart again and I’m puttin’ lemon in your next beer.”

“Pumpkin,” he countered lazily.

She narrowed her eyes. “You’re playin’ with God’s animals.”

He huffed a tired laugh, the kind that softened the lines around his mouth. With Cipher, it was easy—too easy—to slip back into the way he talked growing up. Maybe it was the liquor. Maybe it was her. Or maybe it was the fact he still remembered those damn coworker from earlier who’d told him they “loved his accent,” and he was still mildly irritated about it.

Pa always said: *Be polite to women, even when they’re bein’ weird as hell.*

So he’d thanked her, stiff as a two-by-four.

Didn’t mean he liked it.

His eyes drifted back to Cipher. He thought of the secondhand pieces he’d gathered over time—the only three things she’d ever said about her first arrest.

“I stole stuff. Not proud. Needed to.”
”Juvie sucks.”
“Missouri was better.”

That was all she’d given him.

Everything else, he had filled in with his own imagination—pictures of a teenage Cipher tearing down broken New Orleans sidewalks, cops on her heels, her grinning like she’d invented trouble. He could see it clear as day: her rounding a corner, skidding on beat-up sneakers, clutching stolen hoop earrings like trophies.

The image made him snort into his arm.

Cipher shot him a look. “What now?”

“Nothin’, Pumpkin.”

She groaned. “I will *end* you.”

He just smirked into his sleeve.

His thoughts wavered again, drifting to the morning years ago when Cipher had stayed with his family. He’d woken to the smell of coffee and found her in the kitchen with his mother, talking soft—too soft for Cipher. He’d only caught the tail-end of it, but he remembered the name.

The *“older Greek lady.”*

Aglaea.

Back then, Cipher had tried to play it off—pretended no one knew who that woman would become in her life. Pretended Phainon hadn't heard anything.

Aglaea still ran her garment shop—fancy now, all draped windows and mannequins with elegant necks—but that had always been her first love, long before Okhema and its gleaming tech swallowed her schedule. Maybe that was why she'd been quick to merge the companies. Maybe she wanted her hands back in fabric. Needles. Silk. The things that made her light up.

If that was the Aglaea Cipher met as a kid, then she must've been younger, newer—traveling state to state, hustling for suppliers, stitching together the bones of a dream.

Cipher had once let slip—just once—the outline of their first meeting.

Aglaea was in New Orleans.

Cipher lifted her wallet.

Aglaea caught her instantly.

And instead of pressing charges, the woman bought her a meal and talked to her the way adults *should* talk to kids: steady, gentle, real.

Something about that must've struck deep. Cipher never explained what.

When they finished eating, Aglaea gave her a burner phone.

According to Cipher, the advice was simply:

"Call if you need me, Cifera."

Cipher didn't call.

Not until years later—after something went wrong back home. Something she never talked about. She ran north on grit and panic, hitchhiking through Arkansas, limping through Missouri, sick and starving and stubborn as hell.

He hated remembering the end of that journey.

A teenager collapsing on the rural highway outside his hometown.

Skin dull. Eyes too big.

Clothes hanging on her like she'd been washed out by rain.

His parents found her first.

Cipher always insisted she "just fell over a lil' bit."

He'd seen the photos.

She had been *gone*.

Phainon blinked hard, jaw tightening. The bar lights blurred faintly at the edges.

"Hey." Cipher snapped her fingers. "Quit starin' holes in my countertop. You're thinking too loud."

He lifted his head a little, cheeks flushed from alcohol, eyes tired and a little raw.

"M'not thinkin'."

"Uh-huh. And I'm the Queen of France."

A rough, unwilling laugh slipped out of him.

Cipher placed a hand on one hip, smug. "There he is."

He didn't answer, just sank back down again, cheek pressed to his arm, letting the room tilt gently like a rocking boat. The quiet wrapped around them—warm, familiar, lived-in.

And despite everything—despite the road she'd crawled through to get here—he was grateful.

Maybe it was fate she ended up in Missouri.

Maybe—

She stayed with them a long while after that.

Him and his family, he meant—though in that first month, Cipher acted like the whole house might vanish if she breathed wrong. His parents didn't make a fuss about it. They were the type who believed in feeding someone before interrogating them, and they fed her like she'd walked in starving. Maybe she had.

Cipher didn't know what to do with that kind of gentle consistency. Phainon, at thirteen, didn't know what to do with her either.

He remembered her then as this brilliant-chaos older girl who could lie smoother than sugar water but still cried silently in the bathroom while wrapping gauze around her own hand. She'd curse under her breath in some tangle of half-Louisiana vowels and half-something-foreign, trying not to drip blood on his mom's floor. She swore she'd stay "just a week, promise."

A week became three.

Three became months.

Nobody mentioned it.

Not his father. Not his mother. Not Cyrene, who simply started leaving out an extra bowl at dinner.

And just like that, a year folded itself quietly behind them.

No dramatic speeches about family or belonging. Just dishes drying on the rack, winter boots by the door, Cipher and Cyrene arguing over who got the last piece of cornbread. Little moments that stacked into something solid.

They sheltered her, fed her, eased her back into being young again. And they talked. Lord, there was so much talking.

Especially from Phainon.

Back then he was a relentless chatterbox, a one-boy radio station. Cipher called him *"loud as a damn cicada,"* but she still listened every time. She'd sit at the kitchen table with her arms crossed, pretending she didn't care about his rambling play-by-play of school drama, or his theories about why the neighbor's goat hated him, or his earnest pride about Cyrene winning her science fair.

Cipher pretended she didn't like those stories—but her eyes always softened somewhere around the middle.

It was the first steady friendship either of them had.

Though, neither had the vocabulary to say so.

Eventually the morning came when Cipher decided to leave.

She didn't make an announcement. Phainon just woke up to find her by the counter, backpack slung over one shoulder, face a careful blank. The kind of blank people wear when they're bracing for something.

Before she went, she made a call.

Aglaea arrived that afternoon.

Their meeting wasn't dramatic either. The older woman stepped through the door, introduced herself, thanked his parents with a quiet sincerity that made even his dad straighten up. She looked around the house—not judging, not pitying, just… acknowledging it. Respectfully. Like she was filing away the fact that these were the people who kept Cipher alive this long.

Phainon remembered thinking she didn't look like the type who'd pick up kids off the street. But she talked to Cipher like she'd been waiting to see her again for a long time.

Maybe that was why, years later, when Phainon dragged himself to Chicago broke, raw, and newly dumped, Aglaea didn't hesitate before offering him a job. One phone call, one favor, and suddenly he had rent money.

Almost made him jealous.

Almost.

But when it came to Cipher, jealousy never stuck. She deserved good things. And if good things meant people showing up for her, then fine—he'd take his pride and sit on it.

Funny thing was, Cipher had been jealous of him too, back in the early days. Not out loud, but in the tightness of her shoulders whenever his parents hugged him, or the way she went quiet when Cyrene ran to show him something. Two kids with two different kinds of missing pieces. They didn't talk about it then. They barely talk about it now.

Cipher left Missouri with her health back but nothing else.

She thanked his parents until her face turned red. Tried to thank Aglaea too—softly, like someone unused to gratitude. Promised she'd pay them back even though everyone insisted she didn't owe a cent.

She headed east.

That was the last time he saw her in person until adulthood, though she kept calling the house. She'd ring up Cyrene asking about school, or ask his mother for recipes, or pretend she wasn't checking on Phainon when she very obviously was. Once he got his own phone, she blew that up too.

Then came Massachusetts—"far, civilized, full of places nobody knows you," she'd said. She collected scholarships like stray pennies; Aglaea covered the rest.

Cipher claimed she studied "somethin' that makes folks spend money wrong." Marketing, psychology, economics—Phainon never got them straight. Just knew she was damn good at it.

Turned out she attended the same elite university Mydei later graduated from, which he *just* discovered. It explained a lot about the way she talked around certain polished types.

He remembered the night she called him four states over sobbing—real crying, not her usual annoyed sniffles—because she'd actually graduated. He'd sat on the back porch staring at the Missouri stars, tearing up right along with her. Cyrene pretended not to notice, but left tissues by his elbow anyway.

Then came Chicago.

Cipher liked the city because it let her build something without drowning in East Coast noise. Close enough to Missouri that she didn't lose that part of herself. Cheap enough to invest. Rough enough to respect her.

Aglaea funded her early. Cipher hustled the rest. She knew everyone now—bartenders, bouncers, accountants, corporate sharks and shadowy characters who owed her favors. Loved money, sure, but loved her people more.

When she called and breathed, *"I'm opening it. A real place. Mine,"* he cheered—whooped in a full-body, obnoxious type of joy—and Livia, whose spare room he was staying in, hollered through the wall for him to shut up.

He felt that pride again now—sharp, warm, a little drunk.

A laugh escaped him, sudden and bright.

Cipher looked up from cleaning the bar. "What's funny with you?"

He exhaled, slow and heavy, heart right at the surface. Before he could swallow them, the words slipped out:

"I'm… I'm so proud of you…"

Soft. Slurred. Honest.

Cipher went still like someone hit pause.

Her eyes widened. Her cheeks flushed hot. She stared at him like he'd just offered to adopt a stray possum on the spot.

"The hell you sayin'?" she muttered, scandalized.

He tried to explain, but the attempt melted into nonsense.

“You’re jus’… y’know… good. An’—I’m—proud. Real proud. Me. You. Somethin’.”

Garbage. Complete linguistic trash.

Cipher sputtered, ears red all the way to the tips. “Alright—okay—enough. Don’t—look, thank you, damn.” She scrubbed a glass like she was trying to polish a hole straight through it. “Hate when you get sentimental,” she grumbled, voice a little wobbly.

She checked the clock, sighed, and moved through her final closing sweep—flipping stools onto tables, wiping sticky rings off the counter, muttering about “men who drink my sweet tea liquor and turn philosophical.”

Phainon watched her, one eye open, mostly slumped in his chair. He felt a touch guilty for keeping her after hours.

A touch.

Almost.

“So,” Cipher drawled, one hip braced against the counter, towel slung over her shoulder like a warning sign, “weren’t you yappin’ ’bout your boytoy earlier?”

Phainon’s head shot up so fast the overhead lights streaked.

“Cipher—no, come on—don’t call him that,” he groaned, stretching her name like it was stuck to his tongue. “Why would you—why would you even say it like that?”

Cipher winced, eyes closing as if bracing for impact.

“Should’ve kept my mouth shut,” she muttered.

Too late.

Phainon inhaled once—then the dam broke.

“I thought he was such an asshole,” he started, waving one arm like he was directing traffic, “and he *is*, don’t get me wrong, he absolutely is. He’s got that look—you know the one—where he’s starin’ at you like he’s calculating the weight of your soul? That face? I hate that. I hate him.”

Cipher made a quiet, unimpressed “mm,” wiping a glass that had never been dirty.

“But then,” Phainon continued, shoulders slumping as the honesty spilled out, “he’ll go and do somethin’ stupidly kind outta nowhere. Not even normal kind—like quietly thoughtful. Like he thinks I won’t notice.” He scoffed. “Please. I grew up fixin’ fences in the dark, I can hear a mouse breathe in a hayloft. I notice everything.”

“Hm,” Cipher acknowledged, switching to a glass that also didn’t need attention.

“And he’s got this—this sense of responsibility that makes the rest of us look like we’re just playin’ at bein’ adults. I swear, he carries every problem like it’s a fragile little bird he’s scared of crushing! Doesn’t complain. Doesn’t make a show of it. Just—handles it.” He laughed once, low and disbelieving. “And when he goes quiet? That’s him thinking. Not checking out. Thinking. And you can *feel* it in the air like a storm coming. It’s—hell, I dunno. It does somethin’ to me.”

He sagged down onto his folded arms, fingers idly tapping the wood in a rhythm he didn’t notice.

Cipher didn’t interrupt. She didn’t have to.

Phainon was long gone.

“And—God help me—his *body*,” he said, half-whispering it as if the Lord Himself might walk in. “What in the world is he even built for? He’s got shoulders like he was put together by someone real fond of overkill. And

those arms—good Lord. I'm not even exaggeratin'. I've seen tractors with less horsepower."

Cipher's towel paused mid-wipe.

Phainon kept going, helpless.

"And it's like—how is any man supposed to think straight when he leans over you? He's tall for no reason. He stands next to me and suddenly I'm back on the farm starin' up at the water tower feelin' like I'm about to get baptized by God himself. *He's not even taller than me!* And nobody needs a chest like—"

Cipher slammed the glass down.

"Alright. Enough."

Her eyebrows climbed halfway to the ceiling.

"That's too much information for one poor woman to bear."

Phainon blinked up at her. "You asked."

"No," she corrected. "I made the mistake of speakin'. Don't twist it."

He sighed, face dropping back to his arms. "I'm doomed."

Cipher stilled.

Utterly.

Towel halfway to the sink.

Eyes narrowed, mouth tightening, brain spinning in slow circles like a dog realizing it's about to do something real stupid.

"Oh, Lord," she muttered. "I cannot believe I'm even thinking 'bout helping you two fools with your little lover's mess."

Phainon raised his head an inch. “…what?”

“Nothing,” she said instantly, snapping the word like a mousetrap.

But she kept muttering, pacing behind the bar—quiet curses, soft groans, the sound of a woman preparing to commit to a mistake she’d deny in court.

Phainon squinted blearily. “Cipher… somethin’ wrong?”

She dragged a hand down her face. “Angels above, I cannot believe I’m about to get dragged into this. Y’all are givin’ me gray hairs faster than hurricanes roll in.”

“Cipherrr—”

“Fine,” she snapped. “I’ll help. There. Happy?”

Phainon blinked, utterly lost. “Help with… what?”

“Nevermind,” she repeated with finality. “If you ask again, I’m leavin’ you in the alley.”

Before he could untangle that sentence, she reached beneath the counter, grabbed a bottle of water, and thunked it in front of him with the force of righteous judgment.

“Drink.”

He reached. Missed. Reached again. Got it.

And promptly managed to choke on the first swallow.

Cipher sighed, long and deep. “Pitiful.”

She rounded the bar, slid his arm over her shoulder, and hauled him upright. He did not help.

“You’re stayin’ at my place,” she informed him. “Ain’t lettin’ you wander off and get yourself flattened by a bus. And don’t forget to pay your damn

tab later.”

Phainon leaned on her like a wet coat. “Cipher… you’re a good woman.”

“Don’t butter me up, farm boy. You’re heavy.”

They reached the door.

Cipher shoved it open with her hip.

“Tomorrow,” she muttered, “is gonna be real eventful, Deliverer boy.”

Phainon, drunk and miserable and sloppy-honest, whispered, “That… sounds ominous.”

Cipher snorted. “That’s ‘cause it is.”

The door swung shut behind them, leaving the bar in peace for the first time all night.

Wind skimmed off the river like it was trying to make a point.

Phainon walked anyway, shoulders tucked against the cold and the weight of the umbrella strapped to his bag—a sleek, stupidly over-engineered thing with reinforced ribs and a grip molded so clean it felt like it should come with a warranty card. Too nice for him. Too nice to ignore. Too nice to forget who handed it to him in the first place.

He really wanted to return it.

Returning it meant seeing him.

Seeing him meant—

Yeah, no. Not here. Not where his face could do something stupid and end up in a stranger’s Instagram background.

He tightened the strap and muttered, mostly to the wind, “Should’ve left it with you, jackass.”

A little too honest, a little too weary. Whatever. The river wasn’t gonna judge.

The whole day had been like that—tiny reminders he didn’t ask for, nudging him in the ribs. And Cipher, apparently not content with letting him stew in peace, had swung by his desk that morning like a specter of obligation.

No greeting. No knock. She just snapped her fingers in front of his face when she realized he’d spaced out, then dropped a glossy brochure across his keyboard. Something with flowers. Bright ones.

“Fresh air’s good,” she’d said. “Go touch some grass.”

And she’d walked off like she hadn’t just said something that unhinged.

He’d stuffed the brochure into his bag without looking. With Cipher, it could’ve been a pamphlet for a gardening workshop or a multi-level marketing scheme for artisanal moss. Hard to tell.

Twilight edged over the river by the time he drifted toward a food cart with a hand-painted sign and a guy behind the grill who looked like he’d been working the same corner for twenty years.

“One chili dog,” Phainon said, “extra onions.”

The vendor gave him a look halfway between challenge and amusement.

“Extra onions? On a weekday night? You trying to lose friends or keep ’em?”

“I got a durable constitution,” Phainon said. “And nobody worth impressing tonight.”

“Attaboy.” The man constructed the thing with the care of a surgeon.

Phainon took the first bite and genuinely felt his knees loosen. Food had always done that to him—been his best cure-all since he was a kid with an appetite that made grown relatives stare in disbelief. Chicago hadn’t helped. Too many hole-in-the-wall places serving comfort in paper boats. He still needed to go back to that gyro spot he found last week, the one where the owner called him “darlin’” in a voice that brooked no argument and served tzatziki like it solved moral failings. Maybe tomorrow. Or—

“PHAAAAINON!”

He froze mid-chew.

God. No. Not now.

He turned like a condemned man and, of course, found Hephaestion waving both arms overhead like Phainon was a long-lost cousin returning from war. Peucesta trailed behind him with the graceless tranquility of a man carrying two cups of steaming herbal tea that smelled like someone had boiled an entire front yard.

Phainon closed his eyes, muttered a prayer that went unanswered, and opened them again.

Still there.

“Lord help me,” he said. “Y’all followin’ me?”

Hephaestion flashed a grin that could power streetlights.

“No! …Not in a weird way!”

Peucesta lifted one cup in greeting, expression unreadable. “We were in the area.”

“In the area?” Phainon repeated. “This ain’t even close to your area.”

Peucesta took a slow sip. “We expanded.”

Uh-huh. Sure.

Phainon narrowed his eyes. “Do y’all need a kidney or a witness statement? Just tell me upfront.”

Hephaestion sputtered. “What—no! Absolutely not. Mostly not.”

Peucesta considered this with a tilt of his head. “A witness statement could be handy.”

“Stop talking,” Hephaestion hissed at him.

Phainon took another bite of chili dog to protect himself.

“Anyway,” Hephaestion said, bouncing back like a golden retriever in human form, “we’re going somewhere, and you’re coming with.”

Phainon’s stomach dropped. “That’s a terrible introduction.”

“It’s an invitation,” Hephaestion corrected. “Fairview Botanical Conservatory. Night Bloom. Lights, heat, food, plants pretending to be mystical—”

“Pretentious plants,” Peucesta added. “Very calming.”

Phainon stared at them over the edge of his chili dog.

“Sounds like a date.”

“Exactly,” Peucesta said without blinking.

Hephaestion smacked him hard. “He means it’s not—we’re not—look, just come with us. Worst case, you hate the whole thing and hold it over us forever. That’s a bonding experience.”

Before Phainon could protest, Hephaestion looped their arms like this was legally binding. Peucesta drifted to his other side like an assigned escort.

“I didn’t agree to—”

“No time!” Hephaestion sang.

“I’m eating,” Phainon protested weakly.

“Walk and chew,” Peucesta advised. “Basic motor skill.”

Phainon glared at him. “You know I can outrun both of you.”

Peucesta shrugged. “Not if Hephy over there tackles you.”

Hephy????

Hephaestion brightened. “I *could*.”

This was happening. Against every natural law of the universe, this was happening.

They were halfway down the path when Peucesta casually dropped, “Cipher said you’d love it.”

Phainon stopped dead. They did not.

He stood there, chili dog suspended mid-air, something low and suspicious coiling in his gut.

Cipher.

Great.

That meant something was brewing, and he was smack in the middle without a clue.

He jogged after them with the resigned energy of a man accepting his fate.

“Y’all better not be luring me into a cult,” he called.

Hephaestion raised a hand without turning. “Too late!”

Peucesta lifted his cup. “Welcome.”

Phainon groaned into his bite, already regretting everything.

The Fairview Botanical Conservatory rose out of the dark like a cathedral that accidentally got built out of greenhouse parts. Glass panes arched overhead, catching little shards of Chicago's skyline, and warm bulbs hung in loose zigzags across the entryway—like the decorators gave up halfway through but somehow made it charming.

The moment they stepped inside, the air wrapped around Phainon in a damp, floral hug. Humidity clung to him instantly, softening the edge of his hair and sticking his shirt faintly to his chest.

It wasn't *bad* per se.

Just… like walking straight into someone's lungs.

Soft jazz drifted through the greenery—old, warm, and so unobtrusive it almost felt like the plants were the ones humming. Thin fog rolled near the ground from hidden humidifiers. The walkways glimmered under amber spotlights, and couples kept drifting around them like this was the city's unofficial date-night pilgrimage.

And Phainon hated—*hated*—how romantic it was.

"This is a damn trap," he muttered, tugging at his collar. "A good-lookin' one, but still a trap."

Peucesta had already peeled off toward some sign about a rare orchid, reading the fact card like it was a midterm exam. Hephaestion hovered nearby with the exact posture of a man pretending he understood words like *epiphyte*.

Phainon wiped a bead of moisture off his cheek. "Why's it hotter than July in here? In Chicago. In November."

"It's tropical," Hephaestion offered.

"That ain't an answer."

“It’s the intended climate,” Peucesta added, still staring at the sign.

“That’s *less* comforting,” Phainon said. “Feels like the devil’s greenhouse in here.”

They didn’t respond. They just kept giving each other quiet looks—pointed, secret, very we’re *definitely lying right now* looks.

The weirdness escalated fast.

Hephaestion started checking every door they passed like he expected one to whisper plot-critical secrets. Peucesta took out his phone, angled it toward a fern, and proceeded to “take pictures” of… absolutely nothing. At one point the phone was pointed at the floor drain. He even nodded at it thoughtfully.

Phainon squinted. “You two ain’t slick. If y’all sell drugs, just say that.”

Hephaestion stumbled over a sago palm. “We don’t—no one sells anything—there is no selling happening—”

“That’s *exactly* what a dealer’d say.”

Peucesta cleared his throat. “Please ignore him. He gets nervous in public spaces.”

“Nervous?” Phainon scoffed. “I’m observant. There’s a difference.”

But truthfully, they were acting strange. Whispering. Checking their phones. Whispering again. They moved like interns trying to coordinate a surprise party with no rehearsal.

If they pull out matching trench coats, he thought, *I am walking out of here.* Calm and collected. Like a man escaping a pyramid scheme.

Statistically, he was eighty percent sure he was being sold.

Twenty percent sure they were dodging taxes.

Sixty-forty, realistically.

Still, when Peucesta wandered back to him, he tried not to judge. No one deserved suspicion just for acting weird… even if they were acting weird as hell.

Peucesta actually made good conversation—quiet, unhurried, gently distracting. He asked if Phainon had tried the little empanada cart near the entrance. Mentioned a room of succulents that apparently smelled like orange peel. Grumbled that the humidity was making his curls “inflate like a balloon quartet mid-performance,” which was admittedly more poetic than expected from him.

Phainon laughed—genuinely, low in his chest.

He even forgot, for a moment, to keep side-eyeing Hephaestion.

That was probably the only reason he didn’t notice sooner when they turned a corner and—

Oh.

A hallway stretched in front of them, long and glass-ceilinged, flanked by tall palms trimmed in fairy lights. The lights shimmered like stars tangled in fronds. At the far end, a fountain whispered to itself, water falling into a marble basin with soft, rhythmic sound.

No couples.

No staff.

Nobody.

Just them.

Phainon blinked. “Okay… this is pretty. Pretty in the ‘someone paid a lotta money renting this’ way. Or the ‘we are trespassing and about to be escorted out’ way.”

He took one step back. “I think we should leave—”

Hephaestion raised a hand. “Just a moment.”

Those three words again. A curse. A prophecy.

Phainon heard a rustle—light footsteps, fabric shifting—and turned automatically.

And froze.

Mydeimos stood down the hallway, half-turned, mid-sentence to two other men. One was Ptolemy, wearing an expression like someone had handed him a subpoena. The other was a medical guy Phainon vaguely recognized from the hospital halls—a nurse? tech?—who instantly slapped his phone to his ear as if international diplomacy required his presence *right now.*

Mydei finished his sentence, turned toward the sound—

And completely stilled.

The lighting hit him unfairly well. Soft gold across his cheekbones, faint reflections in his light hair, the kind of glow that made Phainon’s stomach do something irritated and lovesick at the same time.

Their eyes locked.

Shock cracked across Mydei’s features first. Then resignation. Then a silent, city-bred *you have got to be kidding me.*

Phainon was not feeling any more graceful; heat crawled up his throat, embarrassed and furious at how good Mydei looked in fairy lights.

For a full second, no one breathed.

Then realization hit them both at once, sharp and synchronized.

Phainon raised a brow.

You too?

Mydei gave him a look, tired and apologetic.

You have no idea.

Mydei turned toward Ptolemy and the nurse.

Phainon turned toward Hephaestion and Peucesta.

And all four conspirators reacted like someone had hit the Raccoon Emergency Button.

Hephaestion made a strangled noise—somewhere between a blender and a broken clarinet.

Ptolemy clapped once, loudly. “WOULD YOU LOOK AT THAT—”

The nurse declared into his silent phone, “MY SHIFT—YES—STARTING—RIGHT NOW—SEE YOU.”

Peucesta said, perfectly calm, “Bye,” and vanished.

They scattered in four different directions, limbs flying, pure chaos.

Like the Chicago wildlife Mydei always complained about—the alley cats that sprinted when porch lights flicked on.

Phainon stared at the empty hallway. “What in the Scooby-Doo hell was *that*.”

He turned back.

Mydei was still looking after Ptolemy, jaw tight, muttering under his breath in the most Chicagoan exasperation possible—something about idiots running like raccoons after a garbage truck.

Then slowly—slowly—he turned toward Phainon.

There was hesitation there. Uncertainty. Maybe regret. Maybe hope.

He took a step toward him.

Then another.

Phainon's breath caught tight in his chest.

Oh God.

Mydei stopped a few feet away at first, hands loose at his sides, as if he wasn't sure whether stepping closer counted as trespassing. For a second, he looked like he might just stand there forever and hope the air did the talking for him.

But then he let out a slow breath, squared himself, and closed the gap until he stood fully in front of Phainon.

Close enough for Phainon to catch the faint flush blooming across his cheekbones. Close enough to see humidity catching in the strands of his hair. Close enough to see—because fate had a sick sense of humor—that his collar was crooked.

Phainon clamped his arms across his chest so he wouldn't reach up and fix it.

He raised an eyebrow instead. "Knew it," he said. "I've been ambushed."

A fleeting grimace crossed Mydei's face. "Yeah. Same. Sorry about them."

He paused, then added dryly, "They mean well. Unfortunately."

Phainon snorted. "Could've fooled me."

The greenhouse fans hummed. Palm fronds rustled overhead. Mydei swallowed once—something small but noticeable—and seemed to steady himself.

Then he reached behind him.

He hesitated, just long enough for Phainon to get suspicious, and pulled out—like he was revealing contraband—a bouquet.

If one could call it that.

Wildflowers. Not store-made, not trimmed, not arranged. Stems uneven but chosen with care. Leaves bent in places, a few petals frayed at the edges. A little earth still clung to the roots of one that had clearly been replanted into the bunch. Purple blossoms tucked between faded yellow ones, not messy so much as earnest—clearly handled by someone who refused to buy anything he hadn't tried to fix himself.

Phainon stared at it. Then at Mydei.

"…Mydei. What in the hell is that."

Mydei looked at the bouquet like it had personally betrayed him. "A mistake," he said.

A beat.

"A meaningful one."

Phainon's mouth twitched. "Did you mug a meadow?"

Mydei sighed through his nose. "No. I needed flowers today, all the shops were closed, so I got in my car, drove out past the suburbs, found a field, and walked around until I saw something that looked… cheerful."

Phainon's jaw dropped. "You went where? At night? Past the suburbs? For flowers? Are you—have you lost your damn mind?"

"Yes," Mydei replied flatly. "Obviously."

Phainon opened his mouth again—ready to ask *Wait, so you planned this?*—but Mydei lifted a hand, cutting him off before he could get the words out.

“Before you jump to conclusions,” he said quickly, eyes skittering away, “these weren’t for tonight.”

That caught Phainon.

Stopped him clean.

“…Mydei?” he said, quieter.

No answer.

“Mydeimos.”

That did it.

Mydei folded like someone had pressed a palm between his shoulder blades. His posture sank a fraction, gaze slipping toward the floor. Color crept up the back of his neck, his ears turning a shade that looked almost painful. Embarrassed in a way that made him look startlingly real and—against Phainon’s will—endearing.

“I’ve been carrying them around like an idiot for three days,” he admitted, voice embarrassed. “In case I ran into you.”

Phainon stared. Heat dragged up his throat, settling high and warm in his cheeks.

“You… carried dead plants around town for days?”

“I replaced them,” Mydei muttered. “A few times.”

A beat.

“I’ve acquired more wildflowers this week than the rest of Illinois combined.”

Phainon let out a choked laugh—first a snort, then a full, helpless cackle that bowed him slightly forward. It echoed off the greenhouse rafters, startling a bird somewhere above them.

It was the first time he'd laughed like that in weeks. Maybe months.

When he finally managed to catch his breath, he wheezed, "How'd you even know I liked these ones?"

Mydei shut his eyes briefly, bracing.

Then:

"I didn't," he said. "So I asked around."

"…Around where?"

"Everywhere."

He huffed. "Coworkers. Former coworkers. Some guy from Okhema who picked up on the second ring. A lady from the bookclub set in Anaxa's cafe. The mail carrier. A barista I cornered during their break. I think someone's aunt chimed in at one point."

Phainon stared at him like he had grown a second head.

"You didn't."

"Oh, I absolutely did." Mydei rubbed a hand over his brow. "People started texting me pictures of random plants. It turned into a neighborhood watch, except for your taste in flowers."

Phainon pressed his palm to his forehead. "Oh my god."

"My favorite was the cactus," Mydei continued grimly. "Someone told me you liked 'stubborn plants.' I still don't know what that means."

Under his breath, Phainon murmured, "Means they were right…"

"And," Mydei finished, resigned, "I have a spreadsheet now."

That was it.

Phainon burst out laughing again—loud, bright, uncontrollable. His shoulders shook with it, breath catching. Mydei watched him with a look that hovered between offended and something privately grateful for the sound.

By the time Phainon wiped a bit of moisture from his eye, he realized Mydei was smiling. Barely there, but real.

The tension between them didn't vanish—but it loosened, softened at the edges, became something breathable.

For a moment they stood like that, suspended in the warm greenhouse light: one holding a crooked bouquet, the other looking at him with a heart beating too loud in his ears.

Finally, Phainon exhaled, slow and steady. "Alright," he said, voice gentler. "Let's not let everyone's scheming go to waste."

The smile slipped from Mydei's mouth—not gone, just overshadowed by something more serious.

Their eyes met.

Mydei inhaled once.

"Alright, Phainon," he said quietly. "Let's… talk."

Mydei didn't rush it this time.

"When you kissed me," he began, choosing each word carefully, "I reacted badly."

Phainon lifted a brow. You *think*?

Mydei continued. "Not because I didn't want it. That wasn't the issue." His mouth twitched in a dry, self-aware smile. "If anything, I wanted it more than I knew what to do with. And that… scared me a little. Or a lot. I didn't know how to hold something like that without dropping everything else I've been carrying."

Phainon didn’t say anything, but he shifted his weight, like he was giving him space to keep going.

“So I panicked,” Mydei said. “And I left. And then I tried to go back, but you weren’t there, and every hour that passed made it easier to tell myself I just needed a plan, or a script, or something so I wouldn’t screw anything up.” He shook his head once. “That was cowardice, I admit it.”

Phainon’s gaze sharpened. “You could’ve told me any of that. Instead, you dropped off the face of the earth.”

A muscle jumped in Mydei’s jaw. “I know,” he said, and there was no defense in it. “I know,” he repeated, softer. “And I’ve had plenty of time to sit with how unfair that was to you.”

He didn’t fidget but his hands opened and closed at his sides like he was grounding himself.

“It wasn’t fair,” he said again. “I kept trying to think of some explanation that didn’t sound like a flimsy excuse. I don’t have one. Just… the apology.”

Phainon let out a slow breath. “You talk like that and people might start thinking you’re responsible.”

Mydei blinked, surprised enough that a small, helpless laugh escaped him. “Please don’t spread that rumor. I’ve got shareholders.”

“Shareholders of what? Poor life decisions?” Phainon said, deadpan.

Mydei took the hit clean, though the edges of his eyes softened in a way that said he was grateful for the levity, even if it came wrapped in sass.

“Look,” Phainon said, crossing his arms loosely, “I’m not gonna pretend I’m made of stone. But you better not think you’re getting forgiven just because you showed up with some flowers and your best sad puppy face.”

“I don’t expect that,” Mydei said immediately. “I’m not here for instant forgiveness, or a clean reset. I’m here because… I don’t want us to go back

to being strangers who’d just pass each other.”

Mydei carefully set the wildflowers down on a potting table. The conservatory hummed around them—a faint fan, the layered scent of wet leaves—and then a soft tapping began overhead.

Phainon glanced up. “Is it raining?”

“It started about ten minutes ago,” Mydei said. “You always get chilled after walking in cold weather, so I moved us closer to the fern.”

That was small, but thoughtful in a way that wasn’t showy—just something instinctive and gentle. Phainon’s expression flickered, something warmer threading through the guarded look.

Mydei straightened slightly. “There’s an exhibit this weekend,” he said. “At the museum downtown. Solid curation. Interesting pieces. Thought it might be something you’d… enjoy.”

Phainon’s eyes narrowed, suspicious. “You know I’m into that stuff?”

“Of course I do,” Mydei said, sounding almost offended at the implication that he wouldn’t. “I asked Caelus to find someone who worked with you during your old apprenticeship when I remembered you mentioning it a few months back. Needed some intel.”

Phainon let out a single, disbelieving laugh. “You’re kidding.”

“I wish I were,” Mydei muttered. “The man talked for thirty minutes about pottery shards. Thirty. Full minutes.”

Phainon covered his face. “That man loves pottery.”

“He really does,” Mydei said, exhaling like he’d survived a war.

For a moment they just stood there, listening to the rain deepen overhead. The conservatory lights reflected soft gold across the glass panes, and something in the air eased between them—still tentative, still careful, but moving.

Phainon’s voice came quieter, more honest. “I should’ve talked to you sooner, too. I kept telling myself you made your choice, so why bother? But maybe I should’ve just said what I needed to say instead of avoiding you. Could’ve saved us a whole lot of stupid.”

Mydei nodded once. “Maybe. But you don’t owe me the clean-up for my mistakes. I should’ve faced you the morning after. That’s on me.”

The quiet held—comfortable now, not brittle.

Then, almost shyly, Mydei extended a hand. Not demanding. Just offering. “Walk with me?”

Phainon glanced down at the familiar navy handle peeking out of his bag. Mydei’s umbrella. The one he’d never given back.

He snorted under his breath. “Of course you want to walk in the rain.”

“It’s a good rain,” Mydei said, voice soft as the falling water.

Phainon looked at him for a long moment—really looked—and something settled.

“Alright, lover boy,” he said, letting a smile pull at his mouth. “Let’s walk.”

Mydei didn’t hide the way his breath eased out in relief.

But Phainon reached for his hand first, lacing their fingers with deliberate steadiness before tugging him toward the conservatory doors, rain waiting just outside.

Phainon didn’t even realize he’d snagged the bouquet until they were already halfway to the doors. His hand had closed around the stems on instinct—like some part of him already knew he wasn’t leaving without them. The flowers brushed his leg with every step, a small, warm reminder.

Outside, the rain had settled into a soft, steady fall, turning the glass walls behind them into sheets of gold where the lights hit. Mydei flicked open the umbrella and angled it just enough to cover both of them. Their shoulders

brushed as they stepped into the damp evening, and neither made any effort to shift away.

From a distance, the scene would've looked almost storybook: the conservatory glowing behind them, rain glimmering in the light, two silhouettes moving in quiet sync beneath one umbrella.

Naturally, the moment lasted all of twelve seconds.

Because behind a giant fern—one that was absolutely not large enough to hide anything—Hephaestion and Peucesta crouched like two children filming a low-budget nature documentary.

Peucesta whispered (badly), "He kept the flowers. That's a win."

Hephaestion dabbed theatrically at the corner of his eye with the sleeve of his hoodie. "Our boy's in love."

Mydei and Phainon stopped in perfect unison.

Turned.

And delivered a synchronized glare potent enough to curdle milk.

Hephaestion froze mid-gesture, then sighed with the drama of a man surrendering to fate. "Okay—wow—hostile. Fine. Whatever." He stood with languid resignation and waved them off. "Not my problem anymore. I retire from matchmaking. Effective immediately."

Peucesta scrambled upright after him. "He doesn't mean that," he stage-mwhispered to Mydei. "He'll come back Monday with a color-coded PowerPoint on communication styles."

"Go," Mydei said flatly.

They went—Hephaestion dragging Peucesta by the back of his jacket like someone hauling off a misbehaving pet. Their bickering faded into the rain.

Silence settled again. The soft kind.

Phainon adjusted the flowers under his arm, the stems tucking neatly into the crook of his elbow. And there it was—that small, stupid smile tugging at Phainon’s mouth, the one he’d been trying to smother all night.

Mydei noticed, of course. He didn’t call it out, but something in his expression gentled, like he might tuck the smile somewhere safe if he could.

They fell into step once more, side by side, the night carrying them forward.

And Phainon thought, quietly:

Maybe folks like him don’t buy land.
But every now and then, someone asks if they wanna walk a little of it together.

Chapter End Notes

> Just three chapters left? I’m gonna have to squeeze a lot in if I wanna go with my original draft, sorry if the chapters are a bit longer from now on 😭

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